

THE DOLL MAKER FILES



THE LAST ROOM

YEHOR SELIN



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PROLOGUE

The Eighth Column

Cape Erimo, July of the twenty-eighth.

Cape Erimo held the wind the way one holds a taut string. It did not tear the string and did not let go. For three days running, twenty-three meters per second from the southwest stood over the cape, and the fishing pier beyond the village, built in the sixty-third and set on stone piles in the seventy-first, held that wind the way it had always held it—shoulder-on.

Kurosawa came alone, by car, in a black coat below mid-thigh, in leather shoes with soles resoled twice. He left the car at the parking lot by the lighthouse and walked down to the pier. Two terns shifted on the path and did not fear him.

Nine columns stood in a row beneath the lower edge of the pier, on the seaward side, sunk into the concrete of the lower platform.

Thick cedar piles, cut off level at a man's height, black from damp below and gray above, with bronze brackets that had once held lanterns and now held only the memory of them. The lanterns were taken down in the two-thousandth, when Erimo-Misaki was moved to autonomous power.

He counted the columns from the shore.

At the eighth he stopped.

A bronze lantern bracket, with a ring at the top and an angled clip below, was held on four bolts—two of them rusted red, two new, of the kind sold in Otaru at the shop on Denuki Boulevard, four or five years old, no more. Kurosawa saw this from thirty meters. Coming up, he laid his palm on the inner face of the pile—where the bronze clip entered the wood—and the clip gave.

Behind it was a niche.

He did not examine it for long. Twenty centimeters deep, cut into the body of the column, lined with one sheet of heavy gray paper, the same paper sold in Otaru at the stationery shop on Denuki. Inside the niche—two things.

One—a small child's collarbone. The right one. With a thin crack through its very center, old, calcified—ten years ago, or maybe fifty. Kurosawa was not a forensic examiner. Endo would have been.

The other—one sheet of paper, folded in four, inscribed in black pen.

Kurosawa.

He stood over the niche for a long time. The wind took him from the seaward side, tugged at the skirts of his coat, did not catch in his hair because his hair was short. The two terns came back and settled on the far column—the ninth, the empty one.

He put the collarbone back. Lowered it deeper into the niche, closer to the back wall, the way one lays a bone in a coffin that is not to be taken out. The bronze clip—back into place, pressed with his palm until it clicked.

The sheet he kept.

He did not unfold it. He folded it once more, from four to eight, and put it into the inside pocket of his coat—the same pocket that held the yellow slip from the department about the new duty roster. Two things side by side, in a coat.

The road to the last room began here.



CHAPTER ONE

The Department. August of the Twenty-Eighth

*The new chief wanted the case closed. Kurosawa said neither yes nor
no.*

The Hokkaido Prefectural Police Headquarters stood on the same corner it had stood on thirty and ten years ago. In August it held the same faintly stifling warmth that September did not always manage—ceilings high, windows narrow, the air conditioners loud but holding the damp.

Kurosawa entered at eight forty-seven.

The guard behind the partition was new. Not Mori. Mori had been transferred to Hakodate in February. The new one—Kobayashi, thirty-two—straightened at the desk when he saw

a lieutenant's rank on the coat, and made a formal bow of fifteen degrees. Kurosawa nodded. He committed the new guard's name to memory the way one writes down in a notebook things that will be needed in five days.

The elevator smelled of wet cloth from somebody's jacket. On the wall inside—a new poster, white on black, with a red band at the bottom: "*Internal Investigation into the Shichijō Tractor Incident: Conclusions on August 25.*" Kurosawa looked at the date longer than he meant to. Eleven days remained until the twenty-fifth.

The elevator chimed on the fourth.



The Missing Persons unit held the same stifling warmth as last winter, and the winter before, and two weeks ago, when he had opened this room for the last time before his leave over the death of Ogawa. Three desks in one room. A glass partition in the right corner—only now Ogawa did not sit behind it. Behind it sat a man in a gray suit, in a white shirt with the top button undone and no jacket—the jacket hung on a peg by the window—and he did not raise his eyes when Kurosawa came into the unit.

Sasaki, at the middle desk, did raise them.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Sasaki-*junsa-buchō*."

She stood. Not at once—a half-second late, the way people stand who are weighing whether it will be unnecessary. Then she stood anyway. A short bow, five degrees. Kurosawa returned it in the same measure.

"Good that you are back," she said.

"Good that you are here."

He hung his coat on a peg. The scarf he tucked into a side pocket; this scarf was not the one whose wool had held fine cuts in winter—this one was light, summer, cotton, dark gray. He set the thermos on the desk. Second coffee of the morning. He drank standing.

The calendar on the wall was crooked on one pin—a new one, August—with a photograph of the Teshio River. Teshio did not please him. He preferred the January bridge.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

The voice from behind the glass partition. Quiet. Tokyo standard, no admixture.

He turned.

Tanaka Ryosuke was already at the door of his office—the same door where a year and a half ago Ogawa used to lift his chin and say "*sit down*." Tanaka's right hand rested on the handle.

"You have a minute."

"Yes."

"Come in."



The office was the same and not the same.

The bottle of water on the lower shelf behind the desk—was not there. The desk—without the two stacks of folders Ogawa always kept on the left and right of himself—now held one stack in the center, level, with a single soft red plastic tab on the top folder. The visitor's chair—the same wooden one with black cloth—remained. The ashtray on the sill—taken away. Tanaka did not smoke.

Kurosawa came in, closed the door behind him. He did not sit.

"Sit down, Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

He sat.

Tanaka did not sit for another ten seconds. He stood by the window, hands behind his back, back to Kurosawa. Beyond the window—the portico, beyond the portico—the intersection. A truck went by below. On the wall behind Tanaka—the same framed certificate that had hung in Ogawa's office: "*For thirty years of unblemished service, Kurosawa Yukio, 2020.*" Tanaka had not taken it down. That held Kurosawa for a second. Ogawa had kept that certificate right above Kurosawa's own head, the way one keeps an old nail from which one can hang a coat. Tanaka had left it there the way one leaves in a room the things of the previous occupant, until the tidying is done.

"I assume the functions of head of this unit from the twenty-sixth of June," Tanaka said to the window. "Ogawa-san died on the second. The interim rotation lasted three weeks. From the first of August I am here permanently. You know this."

"Yes."

"You were on leave for six weeks. By permission of the deputy prefectural chief. You know this too."

"Yes."

Tanaka turned. Walked to the desk. Sat straight, the way people sit who have long trained themselves to sit straight.

"I wanted to see you before you opened the first file. That is why I asked Sasaki-*junsu-buchō* to inform me when you entered the fourth floor."

Kurosawa did not show that he knew this.

Tanaka set his palms on either side of the top folder on the desk. He did not open it.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*. Did you rest well?"

"Yes."

"That is good."

A pause.

"I will not summarize for you what I read in the folder. You wrote it. I want you to hear me on one short sentence."

Kurosawa was looking at the top folder.

"I am listening."

"The Doll Maker case is closed."

Silence. One second. Two.

Kurosawa did not move.

"The primary subject—by our data—is dead," Tanaka said evenly. "The network—uncovered. Families—waiting. There is no open line that would, in the understanding of the NPA and the Ministry, keep this case alive."

He paused.

"I know that you do not agree with this."

Kurosawa did not move.

"I know that you went to Cape Erimo in July. Alone. Without clearance. On leave."

Kurosawa did not move.

"That is your right as a man on leave. But in my part of things I take it into account. Kurosawa-*keibubo*, I have no grounds to carry

that trip further. I did not see it."

A pause.

"I only want you to understand: if by the end of this week a line appears on your desk that points to *the Doll Maker alive*—that is, if you initiate operational action that takes us beyond the closed case—you do that under your own responsibility. Without internal backing. And without Ogawa—" Tanaka allowed himself a short, barely audible breath, "—under the phrase *Ogawa-san would have covered this from behind my shoulder*."

He put his palm on the top folder.

"I am not Ogawa."

"I know."

"You will say that you need to know something else."

Kurosawa was silent.

Tanaka looked at him for ten seconds. Then leaned back in his chair. Took the folder, opened to the second page.

"I have two inquiries on my desk this week from district stations. Ito Kazuo-san's wife wrote a note of thanks—the body was found in April, the case is closed. Nakamura Aoi-san's mother sent a letter about the return of personal effects—I will pass it through Sasaki-junsa-buchō. That is what you close. That is what I want on my desk by Friday. That is your current work. You hear me."

"Yes."

"Go."

Kurosawa stood.

At the threshold—he turned.

"Tanaka-san."

"Yes."

"Thank you."

Tanaka did not lift his eyes.

"Go, Kurosawa-*keibubo*."



Outside the office Sasaki sat at her desk and did not look in his direction. Her fingers on the keyboard moved evenly. Kurosawa walked to his desk. Sat. His coat remained on the peg. Thermos on the desk. Coffee still warm.

He laid his palm on the right inside pocket of the coat—then he reached through the shoulder, drew out the sheet. Folded in four. Then in eight. Then in sixteen. He did not unfold it.

He only held it in his palm.

The sheet had lived on him for six weeks. Two weeks in the coat. Four—in the bottom drawer of the chest in Maruyama, beneath a shirt Kurosawa had not worn since January. He knew the sheet was there and therefore did not open that drawer—not because he did not want to see the sheet, but because he knew that if he opened it he would not close it the same evening. On Friday last he had, in the end, opened the drawer: he tucked the sheet into the inside pocket of his coat, put the coat into the wardrobe. The coat had hung in the wardrobe until this morning.

Then he put it into the top drawer of his desk, under a thin folder with two reports Tanaka wanted by Friday. He did not lock it. He pushed the drawer shut.

He lifted his eyes.

Sasaki at the keyboard was still for one second.

"Sasaki-*junsa-buchō*."

"Yes."

"In five minutes—at my desk. With the folder on Nakamura-san."

"Return the mother's effects to that address?"

"Yes. And write down Yamada-san's number in Niigata. We'll have a conversation with her on Tuesday."

"Yamada-san?"

"Ayano-san. My brother's daughter."

Sasaki nodded.

She did not ask, the way she had asked five months ago, in January, when he had said something for the first time. She simply opened her notebook, wrote down the number he dictated from memory, and closed the notebook.

Kurosawa did not look at her as he spoke. He looked at the calendar with the Teshio River, and thought that the Teshio flowed north, toward Otaru, only from the other side of the peninsula—and that the town where his case with his father had begun in two thousand and five lay not on a river but in a bay, on the seaward side, where Pier Two was.

Then he opened the drawer and looked into it once. The sheet lay as he had left it.

He closed the drawer.

The coffee in the thermos had gone cold.

CHAPTER TWO

Sasaki

She knew he had gone alone. She did not ask why. She asked what.

At six forty Sasaki came into the unit with two paper cups in her hands.

Coffee from the machine on the ground floor. Not from the canteen: canteen coffee came with powdered milk, and Kurosawa did not drink it. From the machine in the lobby—one button, black, no sugar, hot. One cup with a red lid, the other with a red lid too, with a small mark from her nail near the rim. The mark was Sasaki's, so she would know which was hers.

Kurosawa came in at six forty-seven. He hung the coat. He did not take out the thermos.

Sasaki set one cup on his desk. She said nothing. She walked to her own. Sat. Opened her notebook. Did not start writing.

He looked at the cup for five seconds. Then sat. Took it. Pulled the lid off with two fingers by the rim. Drank a little.

"Thank you, Sasaki-junsa-buchō."

"You're welcome."

Tanaka was not in his office. Tanaka came in at eight sharp. That was his rhythm.

Kurosawa set the cup down beside the thermos. He had not brought the thermos today—he had forgotten, and that surprised him a little, the way a thing surprises a person when they have kept it

in the kitchen for nine months in a row and have not set it down.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"You went to Cape Erimo," Sasaki said evenly. "In July. The ninth. Or the tenth."

Kurosawa returned the cup to the ring of damp it had left.

"The eleventh."

"The eleventh," she repeated. "July eleventh."

"Yes."

She did not look at him. She looked at the notebook. She held the pencil the way one holds a cup—by the top, carefully.

"You did not tell me you would go."

"No."

"You did not tell Ogawa either."

"Ogawa was already gone."

"I know."

A pause. Under the baseboard a thin current of cool air from the concrete slab held, as always. Through the air conditioner the rustle of turning blades could be heard.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*." She lifted her eyes. "Tell me what you found."

He was silent for about five seconds.

Then he pushed the thermos aside, drew a key from the lower pocket of his trousers—small, brass—set it into the lock of the top drawer of his desk. Turned. Opened.

Took out the sheet.

Folded in four. Not unfolded for five weeks. The paper lay flat, unyellowed—heavy gray, the same paper sold at the stationery shop on Denuki in Otaru. Kurosawa looked at this paper and knew where it was from and did not want to say it aloud.

He stood. Walked to Sasaki's desk. Set the sheet down in the middle, on her open notebook. Did not unfold it.

"One time."

She nodded. Set the pencil aside.

Took the sheet between two fingers. Unfolded to eight. Then—to four. Then—to two.

One sheet of B5 format, folded in four. One word, written in black pen, in the center.

Kurosawa.

Not Ogawa's hand. Not Toshi's. Not the earlier clipping—that had been red felt-tip, a ring around the face. This—black pen, a dry hand, a Japanese upright register. The same register as the five words on the envelope at Sato's, that long-ago morning in the *izakaya*.

Sasaki looked at the sheet for eight seconds.

Then she lifted her eyes.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"So he is alive."

"Yes."

"So we continue."

Kurosawa said nothing. Not *yes*, not *no*. He looked past her—at the calendar with the Teshio River—and nodded once. A small nod, the kind one gives when a word is not needed.

Sasaki folded the sheet back. Into four. Then into eight. Not into sixteen—there was no need. She held it out to him.

"Take it."

He took it. Put it back into the top drawer. Closed it. Did not lock.

"Does Tanaka know?"

"No."

"Tanaka knows that you went."

"He knows."

"But not about this."

"No."

She folded her hands on the notebook.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*. You understand that if we open this line without Tanaka's knowledge, Tanaka will close it on us at the first operational request."

"I understand."

"You understand that if we open it with Tanaka, he will close it before the first data."

"I understand."

"You understand that between those two options is a narrow corridor."

"I understand."

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*. You have already chosen."

"Yes."

"Say which."

He looked at her. Not at once.

"We go the corridor," he said quietly. "Three weeks. Then I tell Tanaka in person, when there is data."

"Three weeks," Sasaki repeated.

"Yes."

"Who else?"

"Kenji."

"Yamada-san."

"Yes."

"He is in Sapporo?"

"Yes. I called him yesterday evening from a private phone. He knows he is coming to our unit today at nine. He knows Tanaka does not know about it."

"He is with us."

"He is with us."

She nodded. Took the pencil. Wrote three things in the notebook. Kurosawa did not see what—she held the notebook at a slant.

Then she raised her eyes.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*. I want to tell you one thing."

"Tell me."

"In July I knew you were going to Erimo. I did not ask before you went, because I knew you would say no and go anyway. I decided that of the two—better that I let you go than that I made you lie."

He was silent.

"But when you did not come back by morning," she said evenly, "I drove to your house in Maruyama. At six. I stood in the courtyard under the lamp for four minutes. Then I rang your mailbox—there was an advertising flyer in it about a new candy store in the metro—and I took it out and put it back. Then I went home. You came back in the evening at nine. I knew you had come back, because in your apartment on the third floor the light came on in the kitchen window."

Kurosawa did not ask how she knew which was the kitchen window. He knew how. Last winter they had come back together from a scene on Kita-24, and Sasaki had driven him home, and had waited in the car until he went up, and the light in the kitchen window came on. She saw it. She looked at it steadily until he drew the curtain aside.

Now he set his palm on the ring of damp from the cup.

"Thank you, Sasaki-*junsā-buchō*."

"You're welcome."

"I should not have left you alone."

"No. You should not have."

"It will not happen again."

"I know."

He looked at her notebook. Sasaki's notebook cover was new—light brown, with a thin white sticker in the lower right corner

on which she wrote in pencil "*From*" and the date. In the corner stood: "*From 12 July 2028.*" That meant she had closed the previous notebook the day after his trip to Erimo. Kurosawa did not ask how many pages of the previous notebook she had filled that day. He knew how Sasaki wrote—in an even line of seven or eight signs, with side notations—and he knew that something in the previous notebook was there that he should not go back to.

"Sasaki-*junsa-buchō.*"

"Yes."

"You started a new notebook from the twelfth of July."

"Yes."

"That is a choice."

"Yes."

"I am not asking about the previous one."

"I know."

She turned the page of the notebook to a clean one, with a short motion of her left hand—the way one turns a page in a book from which one is not going to read aloud. Then she set the pencil down beside it, level with the fold.

She was not looking at him. She looked at the notebook. But the corner of her mouth for a moment went inward—not a smile, only what goes in place of a smile in people who do not smile at work.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo.*"

"Yes."

"Kenji-san is coming at nine. We have an hour and twelve minutes."

"Yes."

"Will you tell me in that time what you saw in the niche of the eighth column?"

Kurosawa looked at his closed desk. At the top drawer. At the key in the side pocket of his trousers.

He did not look into the desk.

"One collarbone. The right one. A child's. A thin crack through the center—old. The collarbone I put back. The sheet I took."

"A child's."

"Yes."

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"A child's collarbone—that is a new line. Not from the network. From something deeper."

"Yes."

Sasaki nodded. Wrote one phrase in the notebook. Closed the notebook.

A pause. One second, two.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"You will tell me one thing I did not ask, and will not ask."

"I will tell you."

"The collarbone—from a child. In eight of nine columns on the pier. You put it back."

"Yes."

"That is a choice."

He was silent.

"You could have taken it. You saw a child's collarbone. You knew that to some parent that collarbone would weigh more than one sheet of paper. You left it."

"I did not want him to know I had taken it."

"He will know anyway. You left it not for him."

Kurosawa looked at the bottom of the cup. There was a small crystal of sugar at the bottom that the machine had mistakenly poured in. He had not eaten it.

"I left it," he said quietly, "because on the eighth column of nine it had to be. That is his drawing. If I take one collarbone out of the drawing, I change the drawing. I am not ready to change it. Not today."

"So you see his drawing whole."

"Not whole. But I see it."

Sasaki nodded. She did not write this in the notebook.

"Let Kenji-san come ten minutes late. I will go down for ten minutes to the machine and bring you another coffee. You will drink it before he comes in. And then I will come in again."

"All right."

She stood. She took Kurosawa's empty cup—the one with the red lid and no nail mark, that is, his—and threw it into the bin under the desk. This morning, at six, when she had stood for five minutes in front of the machine, she had chosen the way she always chose.

One button.



She went out toward the elevator.

Kurosawa sat at the desk. One hand he kept on the ring of damp. The other—on the pocket of his trousers, where the key to the top drawer lay.

He did not move until she came back.

CHAPTER THREE

Kenji. The Radio and Forty-Seven Names

Kenji asked for a month. Kurosawa gave him three weeks.

Yamada Kenji came in at nine oh nine.

He always arrived with a surplus of nine minutes or nine seconds—Kurosawa had noticed this once but had not asked why. In Kenji's left hand was a black nylon backpack, in his right—a wet umbrella. He set the umbrella in the stand by the door of the unit, the backpack on the floor beside Sasaki's desk, took off his jacket—the thin gray windbreaker layer he wore from April through October with the same repair seam on the shoulder—and hung it on the peg.

"Kurosawa-san. Sasaki-*junsa-buchō*."

"Kenji-san."

"Yamada-san."

Not "Yamada-*keibu*," not "Yamada-*junsa-buchō*." "Yamada-san." Kenji had been a civilian consultant on digital traces two years ago and now, after Ashibetsu, was a sergeant of the operational group attached personally to Kurosawa. But there was no sergeant's suffix between them. Between them it was "san."

Kenji did not sit at once. He stood straight, backpack at his feet.

"Tanaka in?"

"Not yet. Comes in at eight—" Sasaki glanced at the wall clock, "—that is, already."

"Then quickly."

He opened the backpack. Took out a black external hard drive, a USB cable, a thin brown spiral notebook, and one paper folder. He put it all on Kurosawa's desk, pushing the thermos and the cup aside with the motion of a man who does not ask permission when he is in a hurry.

"Two lines," he said. "Radio and the Yoshidas. Radio I began on the sixth of July, when Kurosawa-san was still on leave. Yoshidas—on the twentieth. Both unfinished. But something can already be seen."

Kurosawa pulled up a chair. Sasaki brought her own—from behind her desk—and set it on his right. All three sat around his desk the way they had sat long ago, when Ogawa was not watching through the glass behind and no one was sitting behind the glass partition. Only now behind the glass partition someone was sitting, and all three remembered that.

Kenji spoke quietly.

"Radio. Between the twenty-seventh of May and the eighth of July, three signals were logged on the shortwave over Hokkaido, not from our repeaters. Not from JMH-2, not from the Sapporo-Wakkanai relay. Not on the fishing bands. One tone—short, eight point two hertz above the standard CB frequency—then three seconds of silence, then the tone again. Each session lasts from ninety seconds to two minutes."

"Timestamp?"

"May twenty-seventh at twenty-three nineteen. June fifteenth at twenty-three twenty. July eighth at twenty-three eighteen."

"Same time."

"Twenty-three nineteen, plus or minus a minute. Yes."

Kenji plugged the external drive into a laptop he took from the backpack. He opened the laptop on his far side of the desk. Kurosawa and Sasaki turned to see the screen.

On the screen—a map of Hokkaido. Three points. All three—in southern Hidaka, in the triangle of Shizunai, Erimo, Urahoro. The westernmost—near Cape Erimo, in the mountains above Genshō-an—but Kenji did not know that name.

"Triangulation from three JARL stations. Error—plus or minus a kilometer or three-five. But in Hidaka the mountains, so in reality—three-seven. The westernmost point falls on the massif above the Genshō valley. That is monastic territory, no road in, only on foot from the Midori-tsuka side."

Kurosawa was looking at the screen.

"Why one hour?"

"I don't know. The same time—that is either a ritual, or a protocol, or the habit of a person who does not want to fall into a new habit. Nobody runs a business broadcast at twenty-three nineteen. That is not professional work. That is a person who wants someone else to know she is there."

"Who is listening."

Kenji raised his eyes.

"Don't know. I checked three stations that could have been listening at that hour in Hokkaido and that log. None of them

received these signals. That does not mean no one is listening. It means whoever is listening is not in my registry."

"Could be Niigata."

"Could be. But in Niigata the air is dead at that hour. In Tokyo too. In Kansai—the same. This is not two-way, Kurosawa-san. This is one man speaking into the empty and hoping that a particular person, at that minute, is sitting at a receiver."

"Or he is the receiver. And the transmitter—is another."

Kenji nodded.

"That I did not check. I only checked Hokkaido on transmission. Reception—a new line."

Sasaki wrote something down. Kurosawa looked at the westernmost point. Genshō. He knew that name—from the abbot of Reisen-ji's report—only as the name of an old monk in Sōunkyō. Now a point on a map. The mountains above Erimo.

"Kenji-san."

"Yes."

"You said two lines."

"The second—names."



Kenji closed the map. Opened a spreadsheet. Excel, three columns, four hundred and twenty-one rows.

"Yoshida," he said. "That is the most common surname on Hokkaido. In the driver's registry—thirty-two thousand. In the voter registry—forty-seven thousand and ninety. I took the voters, narrowed by age—fifty-five to seventy on the ninth of July

twenty-eight. I narrowed by region—Hokkaido as registered address for no less than ten years. I got four hundred and twenty-one individuals."

He scrolled down. Kurosawa looked at the list. The characters 吉田 repeated evenly, row after row.

"Then I narrowed by one feature that was not in Tanaka's." Kenji revealed a fourth column that had been hidden until now. He opened it. "Men only. The Doll Maker—a male voice in the audio recording Ogawa left in the safe two days before his death. Audio—Toshi fragment, three seconds, from Ashibetsu-yama, from the dictaphone. Endo confirmed it. So—men. I got one hundred and ninety-eight."

"Next."

"Then I excluded those registered permanently in cities over a hundred thousand. Sapporo, Hakodate, Asahikawa, Kushiro—excluded. Our profile is not urban. The Doll Maker is in Hidaka, in the mountains, from a monastery or from beneath a monastery. I got eighty-three."

"Next."

"Then I excluded those who over the last five years had gone for an annual medical checkup at a city clinic." Kenji looked at Sasaki. "That matters. The Doll Maker, if he is in a monastery, will not go for a checkup in Sapporo. That excludes people with a settled medical history. I got sixty-two."

"Next."

"Then I excluded those who pay property tax at a fixed address in city districts for more than twenty years. That is, those who lived somewhere in a city in a settled way and put down roots. The Doll

Maker changed addresses at least twice in the last ten years. I got forty-seven."

He opened a new tab. Showed the list.

Forty-seven rows. First column—surname and given name. Second—year of birth. Third—last known address.

"These," Kenji said evenly, "are forty-seven people on Hokkaido who at the second level of check still fit the profile. None confirmed. This is a candidate list. It has to be narrowed to one."

"How long."

Kenji pressed his lips together. Looked at the list.

"A month. Manual work. The pension registries—those are paper archives in Sapporo and Otaru, not fully digitized for Hokkaido. I have access, but I have to travel. I have to read career sheets. I have to cross-check with the registries of children's homes, schools, teachers' unions. I have to cross-check with an updated photograph—and photographs in the pension records there are none, we have only the paper sheet with name, date, addresses. I have to find someone who can describe the appearance. A month—realistic."

"A month we do not have," said Kurosawa.

"I know."

"We have three weeks."

Kenji did not answer at once. He looked at the list. Then raised his eyes.

"Three weeks I will not hold up, Kurosawa-san."

"You will."

"I need to sleep."

"You will sleep here."

Kenji smiled. It was not a smile of joy. It was the smile of a man who understands he will not argue further.

"Three weeks."

"Yes."

"Kurosawa-san. One thing."

"Yes."

"The pension records in Otaru—I have another source. Not official. I have an acquaintance in the archive there—Suzuki, from the Otaru municipal library—he can give me photocopies of the field surveys the municipality does not digitize. On Friday, when he is alone on shift. That is forty-seven rows down to twelve in two days. I will give you the list in ten days, not three weeks."

"Take that line."

"I'll take it. Only one thing."

"What."

"Suzuki—five years ago he lost a child. Since then he is in such a state that he does not like anyone asking him about the archive of wards. He will see me only if I do not mention orphanages. I approach him on a neutral turn—*pensions by appointment*. He will give it to me. But I cannot ask about Jindai-en, or about Mori, or about anyone's room."

"Ask about pensions."

"I ask."

Sasaki closed the notebook. Then opened it. Wrote "*Suzuki*" in pencil.

"Then I take two helpers from the Sapporo district. One—Tanabe. The other, younger—Hara, out of the internship. Silent. Not from our unit."

"Take them."

"Will Tanaka give them?"

"Do not ask Tanaka. Say it is carrying out his order on closing the case. He will not object."

"All right."

Sasaki, who had been silent for the last six minutes, now spoke.

"Kenji-san."

"Yes."

"One row is bothering me."

Kenji looked at her finger on the screen. Row nineteen from the top, third column.

"Yoshida Hiro. Year of birth—nineteen sixty-two. Last known address—Otaru, Temiya district, with the note *released from post for reasons of health, twenty-sixth of March, twenty-seventh*. Post not specified—column empty. In our forty-six others the post is specified. Here—no."

Kenji nodded, as if he had been waiting for that mark.

"That bothered me too," he said. "I stopped on that row. But in the source—the Otaru registry—there is also a gap. I put another tick."

He set one small red mark in the far right column beside row nineteen. Kurosawa saw it, but did not speak.

Sasaki looked at the screen. Then at Kenji. Then at Kurosawa.

"Three weeks."

"Three weeks," Kurosawa repeated.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"In that time you will tell me why you went to Cape Erimo on the eleventh of July, and not the tenth or the twelfth."

He was silent.

"You will tell me either now or before we go to Tanaka in twenty days."

"Before Tanaka."

"All right."

Kurosawa nodded. Kenji closed the spreadsheet. Unplugged the drive. Folded the laptop. Put everything into the backpack.

He stood beside the desk with the backpack in his hand.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"One thing I will tell you now because I will forget later."

"Tell me."

Kenji looked at the list of Yoshidas, which was now closed on the monitor but still open evenly in his memory to all forty-seven rows.

"In two thousand and eight I was in Otaru for two weeks at a summer OSINT circle. I don't remember who my instructor was. One of them cried at the farewell. A grown man. One word stuck in me—*sensei*—in the tone of an older ward who then went into crime. I don't remember the word exactly. But looking at the list—at row

nineteen—I thought it might be him."

"Yoshida Hiro."

"I don't know. I could be wrong. I tell you this not as a fact. I tell you this as a shadow."

Kurosawa looked at him.

"A shadow is already something."

"Yes. A shadow is already something, but not evidence."

"I know."

Kenji nodded. Took the backpack. Walked to the door. On the threshold—he turned.

"Do not tell Tanaka I was here."

"He is coming in ten minutes."

"Then tell him I came for the copies on Nakamura-san."

"I will."

Kenji went out.

Sasaki closed the notebook. Not at once.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"We are now not looking for one man. We are looking for one man among forty-seven."

"Yes."

"With a shadow on the nineteenth."

Kurosawa looked at the monitor that Kenji had closed. Then at the top drawer of his desk, in which lay a sheet with one word in



black pen.

"With a shadow on the nineteenth."

He did not open the drawer.

CHAPTER FOUR

Two Ayanos

*One of them he knew by name. The other he knew by family record.
One of them sent the parcel.*

The parcel came at ten forty-two.

The courier—Yamato, in a black vest with a yellow stripe—brought a box seventeen by twelve by ten centimeters, wrapped in plain brown kraft paper without pattern, tied crosswise with two lengths of twine. The address on the top face—by hand, black pen, Japanese calligraphic characters: "*Hokkaido Prefectural Police Headquarters, Missing Persons unit, Kurosawa-keibuho, personal.*"

Stamp—Memuro, Tokachi, ninth of August. Memuro—a small town a hundred and forty kilometers east of Sapporo, in the foothills of Hidaka.

Sender—not specified. In the 送り主 field stood only two characters, inscribed in a thin black pen:

綾乃.

Ayano.

The secretary from the ground floor brought the box up to the unit in white gloves, the way parcels with undetermined senders had been brought since the twenty-sixth, by Tanaka's order. Tanaka was in his office, closed off, with the phone. The secretary set the box on Sasaki's desk, bowed, went out.

Sasaki did not touch the box for a minute. She looked at the upper face.

Kurosawa came over. Stood beside her. Said nothing.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*," Sasaki said quietly. "Ayano."

"Yes."

"This is that Ayano."

"No."

She raised her eyes.

"Not from Niigata?"

"I don't know."

"Not from Jindai-en?"

"I don't know."

On that "I don't know" he held his palm to the corner of her desk, where the corner was worn to a slightly darker shade from where Sasaki had set her notebook on it a hundred and eighty times a year. He knew about that, and Sasaki knew he knew.

"Sasaki-*junsu-buchō*. We have two Ayanos."

She was silent. Then nodded—briefly, the way a person nods who knows more than she wants to and does not want to admit it aloud.

"That is."

"That is, one—Ayano the nurse. Clinic in Niigata. I saw her in interrogation last November. She told us nothing then. She was dismissed for family reasons two weeks later. Then hired back. No one raised the question. The prosecutor recorded nothing."

"And the other?"

"The other—my brother's daughter. Kurosawa Ayano. Born in Otaru, in two thousand and eight. Raised by her father until two thousand and twenty-two. After her father's disappearance—by her widowed mother, that is, by her mother's parents. Her mother had left the family earlier. Ayano—a ward of her grandmother and grandfather in Niigata, now she is twenty. She is in her second year of the master's program at Niigata University, art history faculty. Interning in Sapporo this summer. Lives in a dormitory near Hokkaido Daigaku."

Sasaki placed her palm beside the box. Did not touch. Just laid it there.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*. Twenty minutes ago you said tomorrow—Yamada-san from Niigata."

"Yes."

"Then you were speaking of Ayano-the-niece. Not of Ayano-the-nurse."

"Yes."

"And the box—is from Ayano-the-nurse. Or."

"Or."

A pause of ten seconds.

"Or from Kurosawa Ayano."

"I cannot rule it out."

"Your niece could not have done this."

"Could not. But I cannot rule it out."

Sasaki nodded. She took gloves from Kurosawa's side drawer—latex, white, for contact with things not yet passed to forensics. She put them on. Then she put on a paper handkerchief—thin, folded once—covered the upper edge of Kurosawa's box, undid the twine. Not tore—untied. Kurosawa watched.

Inside the box—a thin layer of cotton wool. And one figure.

Small, eight centimeters tall. Porcelain. A child's—with arms spread to the sides, in a kimono with a lilac pattern. The head—the shape of a ball. There was no face. Smooth bone color, like *ichimatsu* dolls without paint. No brows. No eyes. No mouth.

Such was the doll from the shelf above the altar in Kamishiroi. Such was the doll from Hachirodate. Such was the doll from Sato's.

Now—such.

Sasaki did not touch it with her fingers. She only tilted the box.

Under the figure, on the second layer of cotton—one sheet.

B7 format. The same heavy gray paper from the stationery shop on Denuki in Otaru. Black pen. One word.

綾乃.

And one line beneath it:

"Kurosawa-san, I have not forgotten."

Silence.

Kurosawa looked at the sheet for nine seconds.

"Not Ayano-the-nurse," he said quietly. "The nurse wrote in Latin script. This is not her hand."

"So."

"Either Ayano-the-niece, or the one who writes under her name."

"The Doll Maker."

"Yes."

He stepped back from Sasaki's desk half a pace. Looked at the calendar with the Teshio River. Not through the calendar—past it.

Ayano-the-niece. Twenty years old. Hair—light chestnut, cut short in spring, as his mother-in-law had told him on the phone in May. Nose—Ren's. Eyes—Ren's. Not the father's; not the grandfather's. Kurosawa's father and grandfather were not in the eyes—they had left the eyes into the family that same morning when Ren was witness and Yukio was the object of the beating—and in the niece the nose and eyes were the mother's, that is, Yukari's, and Yukari had left the family in the ninth. Kurosawa had seen Ayano last in April, at the cemetery in Niigata, when they buried her grandfather—Yukari's father—and Ayano had stood there in the black schoolgirl dress of a first-year master's student, with a black ribbon in her hair, and had not cried.

Ayano-the-nurse—forty-seven. Or forty-six by the documents. Kurosawa had seen her at interrogation last November. Face—plain, without sharp features. Eyes—dark, deep, clear. Speaks quietly. Never raises her voice.

Kurosawa looked at the calendar.

"He is dividing us," he said. "He is showing us that we do not know which of the two Ayanos to turn to. He wants me to go to the niece and be unable to put the direct question. Or to put it and hear *no*. Or to decide the niece is with him. He wants me to make a mistake in this place."

Sasaki was silent.

"Sasaki-*junsā-buchō*. I will go to the niece. On Tuesday. But before that—you will get a telephone check from Niigata. I want to know whether Ayano-the-nurse is at work today or not. I want you to know that by the end of the workday."

"I'll do it."

"And I want you to write down one line for me. In the notebook. Two Ayanos. One—nurse, age forty-six, real name not yet established. The other—Kurosawa Ayano, twenty, niece, art history, Niigata. One—from the network. The other—from the blood. One of them sent the parcel. One of them—is a victim."

"Kurosawa-*keibuchō*."

"Yes."

"A third is possible."

He looked at her.

"The third is."

"The third is when he writes under her name and Ayano herself does nothing. Not the first, not the second. Not a victim, not a sender. Just a name he hangs a signal on."

Kurosawa looked at the sheet in the box. Then at her.

"You are right."

"I am not right. I have a variant."

He nodded.

Tanaka behind the glass partition raised his head. Saw the box on Sasaki's desk. Looked through the glass. Did not come out.

Kurosawa waved to Sasaki—a short gesture: *cover it*. Sasaki covered the box with the handkerchief and pushed it under the edge

of the desk.

Tanaka watched for another five seconds. Then lowered his head back into the papers.



At six in the evening Sasaki closed the notebook. She took her coat off the peg—the same thin one, dark blue, to the knee—put it on. She washed the thermos in the canteen and put it into the lower drawer. Kurosawa was still sitting. Kenji had not come back; Tanaka—still in his office, with the phone.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*."

"Yes."

"I'll be by from the morning. At seven. With coffee."

"Thank you."

"Yamada-san from Niigata. The check I finished at four. Ayano-the-nurse is at work today, from eight to seventeen. Not dismissed. Has not seen the head of the clinic since May. That is the standard mode."

"Good."

"Then I'm off."

"Yes."

She went out. Kurosawa sat for another fifteen minutes. Then he too rose. Tanaka behind the partition was already without his jacket, with the phone at his ear. Kurosawa nodded through the glass—a short nod that needs no answer. Tanaka nodded back the same way.

Kurosawa left the unit at six seventeen.



Sasaki lived on the second floor of a small building in Hotsumi, near Kita-24-jō station. Five minutes on foot from the metro exit. One entrance, three apartments on the floor, hers the far one on the left. Above her door was one small nameplate with the characters of her surname, and one iron plate with the number—two hundred and three.

She came up the stairs at six forty-two. In her mailbox was tired summer mail. One advertising flyer about a new candy store in the metro—the same one Kurosawa had had in his mailbox in Maruyama six weeks ago. One gas bill. One paper envelope—heavy, brown, kraft, no stamp, no postmark, no address. Only one word in black pen on the front.

姉さんへ。

"For elder sister."

Sasaki stood in the hallway with the envelope in her hand for twenty seconds. She did not open it. With her fingers she felt that inside was something solid. Small. In the shape of a ball with two little arms spread to the sides.

She knew what it was.

She set the envelope on the small table in the hallway. Did not open it.

She went to the kitchen. Put the kettle on. Took a cup from the lower shelf of the refrigerator—blue, with a small crack along the inner side—brewed a bancha with the tea dust that had been in the tin since April.

She stood over the cup for five minutes.

Then she came back to the hallway. Took the envelope. Did not open it.

She went into the bedroom. Set the envelope on the bedside table, beside the photograph of Nao in a frame—Nao in her master's-program uniform, with a black belt on her head—and lay down in bed.

She did not turn on the lamp.

She looked at the envelope in the dark.

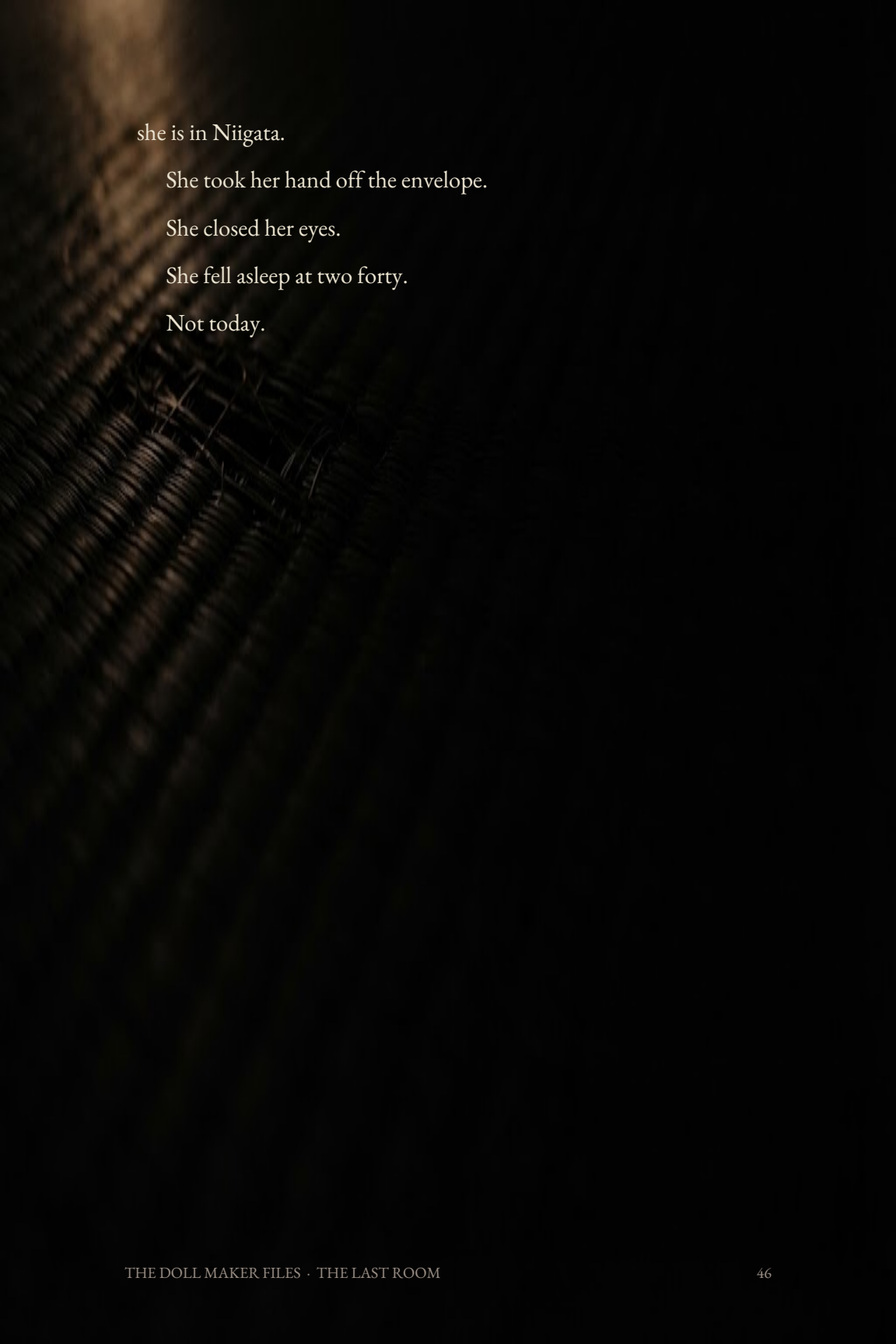
Outside the window the last bus went by—route eight hundred and eight, from Kita-24 to Heiwana—with the same drawn-out horn as the last bus of two thousand and eleven, when she had first rented this apartment.

Nao in the photograph, in the master's-program uniform, had a black belt on her head and a light smile. The picture had been taken by one of her classmates in November last year, in Niigata—Nao had sent it to Sasaki over LINE with the note "*elder sister, I finally set this stick on top after three years*"—and Sasaki had printed the photo in a mini-photo lab on Kita-24 a week later. The frame was cheap, with a thin wooden rim; on the underside of the frame Sasaki had stuck a small piece of tape that had turned yellow in half a year.

She kept her palm on the envelope. Through the paper she felt the rounded, hard line of a small head without a face, with two little arms spread to the sides. She knew the form by touch, because she had seen it in three cases in a row. Now—on her own bedside table, two steps from the frame in which her sister was smiling.

"Kurosawa-*keibubo*," she said aloud, quietly, into the dark, as if he would hear her ten kilometers away across Maruyama. "I will not call."

She would not call, because calling would mean admitting that in this case she was not only an officer. This she admitted without a call. Not only an officer. A sister. There is a younger sister too, and



she is in Niigata.

She took her hand off the envelope.

She closed her eyes.

She fell asleep at two forty.

Not today.

CHAPTER FIVE

Toshi at Tsukigata

"All I know: Otaru."

The prison at Tsukigata stood forty kilometers north of Sapporo, in a field where onions had once been grown. In winter the field was white. In August—level, green, with low light-gray administrative barracks, to which Kurosawa drove up at ten in the morning.

He came by bus. The car would have stood two hours in the parking lot in the sun, and Kurosawa did not want to return to a heated car. The bus from Ebetsu station—forty minutes, two stops, wind from the field through the open window. Kurosawa sat in the front seat, the thermos between his feet. In his bag—notebook, passport, a visit permit signed by prosecutor Fujiwara.

He did not drink on the bus. Did not read. Looked out at the field and thought of nothing.



Prosecutor Fujiwara revoked Toshi's bail in March. Toshi did not appear for his weekly check-in—that week Kurosawa had taken him to Shiretoko for the operation at one of the network addresses, and the schedule collapsed. Fujiwara signed the warrant within the hour. Toshi did not argue. He got on the bus to Tsukigata himself, in his gray pullover, with a small bag of books in his hand, the way one goes to retirement.

The Sapporo pretrial center held Toshi a year. Tsukigata had held him seven months.

Kurosawa had come three times. Toshi was silent for the first twenty minutes three times.



The guard was the usual one—Kawaguchi-san, fifty, with a small scar on his upper lip. He knew Kurosawa. Knew to bring water, not tea—that mattered. Knew not to remind about the time.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*." "Kawaguchi-san." "He is in the second room. Reading." "What." "Don't know. A thin book. In Ukrainian he doesn't show us."

Kurosawa nodded. Toshi had read Ukrainian in the Sapporo center—Zbigniew Herbert in someone else's translation, secondhand, from the Furano library. One of the guards had let him have it. Kurosawa had not asked which.

He passed through two metal detectors. He handed over his watch, his pen, his phone. The thermos was opened, sniffed, closed. Let through.

The visiting room at Tsukigata was smaller than at Sapporo—three meters by two, no window, two chairs, a low metal table. Ceiling in square panels. One lamp behind a grille.

Toshi was sitting.



In seven months at Tsukigata he had lost another three kilos. His shaved head kept its color. Skin—dry, as always. Kurosawa thought that Toshi looked the way he would have looked if he had never left the monastery—a body made for stillness.

"You came." "I came."

Kurosawa sat. Set the thermos on the table. Unscrewed the cap. Poured water into a cup—his, plastic, from his bag. Set it between them, closer to Toshi.

Toshi looked at it. Did not thank. Did not take.

Kurosawa screwed the cap back on.

Toshi was looking at the wall to Kurosawa's left. Kurosawa—at the wall to Toshi's left. That was how it had been from the first day.

"Kawaguchi-san says you are reading." "Herbert." "The same one?" "The same one. *Mr. Cogito*."

Kurosawa nodded. Was silent.

Toshi said:

"You went somewhere." "I did."

A pause. Toshi did not ask where. He knew Kurosawa would say himself.



Kurosawa opened the notebook. Set his palm on the sheet. Did not write. He looked at his own palm for about ten seconds, as if to check it was his. Then he said:

"Toshi. I found a collarbone at Erimo."

Toshi did not move.

Kurosawa waited.

Toshi was breathing—evenly, the way people breathe who have counted breath for years. Behind the wall someone walked down the corridor—soft steps, rubber—and vanished. Toshi sat longer than he had been silent last time. Kurosawa counted the beats of the second hand on the guard's wall clock: forty, sixty, ninety. On the

hundredth Toshi shifted his eyes—not to Kurosawa, but to the cup between them.

"How many columns." "Nine. Eight had one each. The ninth—empty." "The eighth was to be yours." "Yes." "The sheet." "There. I took it."

Toshi nodded. Once.

Kurosawa said:

"You knew about Erimo." "No." A pause. "I swear."

The word "swear" was not one Toshi used. Kurosawa heard it from him for the first time in two years. He did not raise his eyes. Toshi did not raise his.

"But you knew something." "Yes."

Toshi went on breathing. Kurosawa gave him time. After a minute Toshi said, in the same quiet voice, in which there was neither resistance nor relief:

"Kurosawa-san. I did not know about Erimo. But I knew there is a place he always comes back to."

"Where."

"I don't know the address."

Kurosawa waited.

"He drove me blindfolded. Three times. In childhood. I did not see the road."

"You remember what."

Toshi thought.

"Smell of the sea—a couple of weeks. Not constant. The way it is when the sea is close but not from a window. Wood—old, dark,

damp. Stairs—two flights. One straight, inside. The other—down, into concrete, steeper. In the concrete it smelled of rust and floor-cleaning fluid. The kind sold in the seventies. Still smelled."

He stopped. Kurosawa did not hurry him.

"And what else."

"A roof of a train," said Toshi, "once every fifteen minutes. Freight. Long. Went low above the house."

"Freight." "Yes. No whistle. Only the clatter. Distant, then close, then distant again."

Kurosawa was writing. Toshi did not ask whether he was writing.

"Did you see anything?" "Once." A pause. "I was eight. He untied the blindfold for a second so I could drink water. I saw the ceiling. A beam with a mark. Red. Three signs."

"Which."

"I do not remember the characters. I only remember—red. And—decoration. Shinto type. Not Buddhist."

"*Gobei*." "Yes. One. And a mark under it. A child's hand. Scrawls."

Kurosawa was writing. Toshi looked at the wall.

"And?"

"And—a city." Toshi paused, after which he would have added nothing if Kurosawa had been silent.

"Which."

Toshi looked at the cup.

"Kurosawa-san." "Yes." "All I know: Otaru."

Kurosawa laid the pen aside.



The word "Otaru" stood in the room—not loudly—with that particular weight with which the name of a city rises in a conversation when both sides have something lying in that city. Kurosawa had been born in Otaru. Kurosawa had buried his father in Otaru in two thousand and five. Kurosawa had buried Ren in Otaru in the twenty-second. In Otaru prosecutor Fujiwara had signed his first case. In Otaru Sato had married Michiko. In Otaru Yoshida Hiro had lived sixty-six years, in the same Temiya district Kurosawa used to come to as a boy to visit his uncle at New Year.

Kurosawa thought about this for five seconds. No more.

He set his palms on the table. Toshi did not move.

"You knew this from the start." "I knew from the day you came to me the first time." "Why did you not say." "You did not ask the right way."

Kurosawa nodded. Slowly—not to Toshi—to himself. To ask the right way meant to ask what Toshi could answer without betrayal. Otaru—that was not an address. That was a city of two hundred thousand souls. Toshi had given him what did not amount to direct betrayal of the Doll Maker—but that narrowed the search the way a funnel narrows a stream of water.

"The children's home," said Kurosawa quietly.

Toshi did not answer.

"The children's home in Otaru. Mori Katsuya. Director until nineteen ninety-eight. Yoshida—after."

Toshi looked at the cup. Kurosawa ran a finger along the edge of the notebook. He knew—when Toshi did not object like this, he confirmed slower than by an affirmative. Toshi had held the name

Yoshida on his tongue for years. Kurosawa heard it in the pause.

"Toshi." "Yes." "Yoshida is alive." "Yes." "He is in Otaru?" "Not always." "Where else." "In the mountains. A hermitage. Hidaka." "Genshō-an." "Yes."

Kurosawa wrote out the word. Did not show it.

"You saw him after?" "After—no." A pause. "Before—many times. The last time—two weeks before my arrest at Kamishiroi."

"He knew you would remain." "He knew I would remain." "He set you." "Yes."

Toshi's voice did not change. Kurosawa thought: seven months of silence at Tsukigata, and none of these phrases now sounds like a confession. It sounds like reporting the weather.



Kurosawa drank from his cup. Toshi did not drink from his.

"Toshi." "Yes." "I will stop him." "I know." "You understand that you are a witness." "I understand." "You understand that Fujiwara can open a review." "Yes." "Do you want that?"

Toshi looked at the cup for a long time.

"Kurosawa-san." "Yes." "I do not fear him." "I know." "I do not hate him." "I know." "Will they return me to Furano?" "Not in the coming years." "All right." "Toshi." "Yes." "Do you want to go back to Furano?"

Toshi did not answer at once. Kurosawa waited. Toshi looked somewhere at the ceiling—not at the lamp, but to the side of it—and said:

"I would like one day to see the forest again. Not now. Now the forest is not what I need." "Then what."

Toshi turned his eyes. Not to Kurosawa. To the side, the way one turns them when searching for a word.

"Kurosawa-san." "Yes." "I do not want anything." "Toshi." "I would like—" he corrected himself, slowly, "—for him to go not the way Sato went. And—for Ayano not to be left alone."

Kurosawa closed the notebook.

"Ayano is in Niigata. She is twenty. She is in the master's program, art history."

Toshi nodded. For the first time in the conversation his head lowered—briefly—not a bow—only a movement down—and rose again.

"Thank you."

"That is not a gift." "I know. It is—information. Thank you."



Kurosawa sat another twenty minutes. He asked no more. Toshi looked at the cup. The water in the cup had not gone down.

Kurosawa had thought before that he knew how silence held at Tsukigata: with the same weight as it held in Sapporo, only with the effect of a field around it—because there was empty land, not city. Now he thought otherwise. He thought silence at Tsukigata held slower—not because of the field—but because Toshi in seven months here had let go of one more skin. The one in which he came to meetings in Sapporo. In Sapporo Toshi had sat like a man who waits. In Tsukigata Toshi sat like a man who has already finished waiting.

At the forty-first minute Kurosawa screwed the thermos shut. Took the notebook. Stood.

"Toshi." "Yes." "I will come again." "Do come." "With tea."
"Thank you. Green."

Kurosawa nodded. Walked to the door.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*."

He stopped. Did not turn.

"Yes."

Toshi said quietly, in the voice with which he had spoken haiku on 5channel at Thursday eleven:

"Yoshida-sensei is warm. It is not a trap. It is the truth. Prepare for warmth."

Kurosawa was silent.

The door locked behind him. Kawaguchi-san walked him to the first checkpoint. Kurosawa took back his watch, pen, phone. He put on the jacket only at the exit.

The bus to Ebetsu left at two. Kurosawa sat on the bench at the stop, set the thermos between his feet. Took out the notebook. Wrote two lines:

Otaru. Roof of a freight train. Shinto gohei, three red signs.

Closed the notebook.

The field lay level, green. Wind passed through it—low, soft—and went on, into the forest.

Kurosawa waited for the bus. He did not smoke.



CHAPTER SIX

The Room—Michiko, 1988

"You must wait."

The children's room was long. Three tatami. One low bed with a checked blanket. One nightstand. One window, high, in a boxed frame. On the window—bars of four wooden slats, so no one would fall.

Michiko sat on the blanket. Seven years old.

She took each sock off slowly. First the right. Then the left. Folded one inside the other. Put them under the pillow—under the pillow they did not get lost.

The evening was quiet. The other children were having supper downstairs. She was not having supper. Her stomach ached. Kobayashi-san had given her a cup of warm water and told her to lie

down.

Michiko was lying down.

But sitting.

Someone went by in the corridor. Steps soft. Not Kobayashi-san—Kobayashi-san walked loudly.

Michiko listened.

The steps stopped.



The door slid open.

Yoshida-sensei stood in the doorway. In a gray suit. No jacket—only the waistcoat. Shirt sleeves rolled to the elbow. Hair short. He had washed his hands before supper—Michiko knew the smell of that soap. They sold it at the shop on the corner. Her mother used to buy that kind.

Her mother had died last year.

"Michiko-chan."

She did not answer. She folded her hands on her knees.

"May I come in?"

Michiko bowed her head. Once. Low. That was how Kobayashi-san had taught her—to say yes without words when the guest is older.

Yoshida-sensei came in. He closed the door behind him quietly. He did not sit on the bed. He sat on the tatami—on his heels—to be at her level. He set his hand on his own knee.

In his hand was a small box.

"You have a sore stomach."

Michiko bowed her head.

"It will pass."

Michiko bowed her head again.



Yoshida-sensei placed the box on the tatami between them. The box was white. With a paper ribbon. The ribbon light red.

"This is for you."

Michiko did not reach out.

"I am not hungry."

"It is not food."

Michiko looked at the box. The ribbon shone under the lamp. Michiko did not know what was inside. She wanted to ask. She did not ask. Kobayashi-san had said—when a grown-up brings something, first you bow, then you open.

Michiko bowed her head.

"Untie it."

Michiko reached out. Her fingers were small. The ribbon slipped. She undid the knot.

Yoshida-sensei watched. Did not help.

Michiko lifted the lid.

Inside—a small porcelain doll. Without a face. Head smooth. Body in a white kimono. Hands folded in front.

Michiko looked.

"This is—you," said Yoshida-sensei.

Michiko bowed her head. Not because she understood. Because she did not know how else.



Yoshida-sensei leaned toward her.

He placed his hand on her shoulder.

The palm was warm. Not heavy. Not holding—resting.

Michiko did not move.

"Michiko-chan, you are special."

She bowed her head.

"Do you know why?"

Michiko bowed her head. That meant no. It also meant I am listening. Yoshida-sensei understood.

"Because you ask for nothing."

Michiko listened.

"The other children ask. You—do not."

He kept his palm on her shoulder. Very quietly.

"You can wait. A long time. Can you?"

Michiko bowed her head.

"You waited for your mother."

Michiko did not move.

"How long."

Michiko counted on her fingers, on her knees. She did not show. She only counted. Three months. Mother had been in the hospital three months. Michiko had come every Sunday. She sat by the bed. She did

not talk. Mother did not talk. Michiko waited until the nurse said, "time."

"You know how."

Michiko bowed her head.

Yoshida-sensei took his hand off her shoulder.



"Michiko-chan."

"Yes."

The word "yes" she said aloud. Thin. One syllable.

"You must wait. A long time."

"Yes."

"When I call you, you will come."

"Yes."

Yoshida-sensei looked at her. Eyes dark. Calm. Not sad, not glad. Michiko thought—that is how a person looks who knows what he wants.

"Michiko-chan."

"Yes."

"Have you remembered?"

Michiko bowed her head. Then she said:

"I must wait. A long time. When you call—I will come."

Yoshida-sensei nodded.

Michiko bowed her head.

He placed the box with the doll beside her pillow. The doll looked at the ceiling without eyes.



Yoshida-sensei stood. His suit was slightly creased at the knees. He smoothed it with his fingers.

He went to the door. He did not turn.

At the door he stopped.

"Michiko-chan."

"Yes."

"Do not tell Kobayashi-san."

Michiko bowed her head.

"About what."

"About the doll."

"Yes."

"About our word."

"Yes."

Yoshida-sensei went out. The door closed. His steps went down the corridor. Quiet. Farther. Farther. Gone.

Michiko sat.

She lifted the doll to the window. The porcelain held the lamplight. There was no face. Michiko looked for a long time.

Then she put the doll into the box. The box—under the pillow, next to the socks.

She lay down.

The blanket smelled of soap.

Kobayashi-san came in half an hour later. Asked if her stomach ached. Michiko bowed her head. Kobayashi-san turned off the lamp. Went out.

Michiko lay in the dark.

Steps from the yard. Steps from the dining hall. Someone's voice. Someone's laugh. Then silence.

She took out the box. Opened it. Took out the doll. Put it beside her. The doll looked at the ceiling.

Michiko looked at the ceiling with it.



The next day Kobayashi-san did not notice the doll. Michiko kept it under her pillow. In the daytime she played with the others. In the evening she took it out. Held it to her cheek. Put it back.

Yoshida-sensei did not come.

Michiko waited.

One week. Two. A month.

Yoshida-sensei walked down the corridor every morning. Nodded to the children. Michiko bowed. He nodded to her the way he nodded to everyone.

Michiko understood. The word was theirs. No one had to know.

She waited.

Another month. Another half a year. Another year.

The years began to grow long.

Michiko grew. Learned to read. Learned to count. At ten—to write characters. At thirteen—to speak to adults without swallowing her words. At fifteen—the junior administration gave her the younger children, and Michiko led them to wash their hands before supper, showed them how to fold a towel, how to hold chopsticks.

She kept the doll in her desk. In a drawer behind the notebooks. Sometimes she took it out.

Yoshida-sensei became director. Walked the corridor less often. Now he had an office.

Michiko bowed. He nodded.

The word was theirs.



At eighteen she entered a nursing school in Niigata. Yoshida-sensei signed the recommendation.

He passed the paper through Kobayashi-san. Kobayashi-san did not read it—only brought it.

Inside the envelope, separately, was a small box. White. With a paper ribbon. Michiko opened it. Inside lay a second doll. The same size. Without a face. Michiko placed the first and the second side by side. The doll looked at the ceiling. The second—the same.

In Niigata Michiko trained as a nurse. Did not marry. Rented an apartment alone. Bought soap at the same shop—with the same smell she remembered from seven. In the apartment there was nothing extra. In the drawer—two dolls.

Yoshida-sensei did not write. Did not call.

She waited.

The years passed not fast. She did not add them.

Michiko-san. That was how they called her at the clinic. She kept her back straight. Head—a little down. Voice—level. The patients liked her. The management did not notice her. That suited her.

Time was soft.

Michiko-san came to work at seven. Left at six. Slept at ten. Woke at six. That way—for forty years.

Every weekend she washed the floor in the apartment. One room. One stove. One toilet. Rag wet. Cloth on the knee. Michiko-san washed the floor kneeling on the cloth—the way Kobayashi-san had washed it in seventy-one.

Every second Sunday Michiko-san ate lunch at a minimart. One serving of rice. One fish. One small glass of barley tea. In the minimart there was a table under the window. She sat so as to look at the glass. She looked at people—not at them—but at the way they passed.

On the thirtieth of every month Michiko-san transferred half her salary to the postal bank into an account "O"—Yoshida's account—the one he had opened in her name in ninety-nine and on which he was signatory to this day. Michiko-san did not know where the money went. She knew—it had to. She did not ask.

She never had a dog. Never a cat. Never a houseplant.

She had two friends. One nurse from Yokohama who came once a year. One widow on the floor below who borrowed sugar. Michiko-san gave sugar without words. The widow thanked her. Did not come in.

Yoshida-sensei called her the first time in two thousand and three.

Michiko came.

Yoshida-sensei called her the second time in two thousand and twenty-two.

Michiko came.

From the twenty-second—seven trips to Otaru, every five months. Michiko did not ask to whom. She placed the cannula. She prepared the injections. She went back to Niigata. In the apartment she washed the floor kneeling on the cloth.

Yoshida-sensei did not call again.

But Michiko waited.

The word was theirs.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Kenji—Doubt

"Yoshidas by the thousand. But—possibly."

Kenji's office was in the side wing of the unit—a small room with no window, with blinds no one bothered to close, and three monitors set parallel on a wide metal desk. Kenji liked his office. He said that without a window it was easier to concentrate; Kurosawa suspected Kenji liked the office because no one dropped in casually. People came only on purpose, with something.

At ten on Monday evening he was sitting alone. Coffee at the corner of the desk—the fourth. Glass of water—touched twice in the hour. One monitor turned off—Kenji turned the right one off when he was focused—that left a dark rectangular slab on the desk that narrowed the field of view.

On the middle monitor stood the list.

Forty-seven rows.

Yoshida—year of birth—prefecture of registration—last address per driver's registry.

The list was printed out in the format Kenji liked—plain text on a black background—no sorting, no colors. It scrolled with one brush of the mouse. Kenji did not sort—sorting was the next step.

He read.



Yoshidas in Hokkaido, per the driver's registry, aged fifty-five to seventy as of August of two thousand and twenty-eight—there were four hundred and twenty-three. Kenji cut those with registered addresses outside Hokkaido in the previous ten years. That left two hundred and ten. He cut those with steady work biographies at one firm over twenty years, on the grounds that the Doll Maker could not have been an office worker. That left one hundred and eighteen. He cut those registered permanently in Sapporo, Hakodate, Asahikawa—three large cities—on the grounds that Toshi had mentioned a freight train, a roof, a ceiling with red marks. That left eighty-three. He cut those with a living spouse—Yoshida, by profile, lives alone. That left forty-seven.

Forty-seven was still many. But it was already accessible to the eye.

Kenji went through the list a second time. Then a third. On the third pass he stopped on one row.

Yoshida Hiro—1962—Hokkaido—Otaru, Temiya, exact address not updated since 2019.

He looked at the row. Reached for the coffee.

The coffee was cold.

He set it down.

He looked at the row.



Every professional knows that feeling—that something is familiar—is bad currency. Kenji knew this better than most, because he had studied himself on it more than once: a computer face-recognition network confused a neighbor's face with a suspect's in three cases out of ten—and the human brain had the same error,

only with a longer memory. Kenji did not trust recognition. Kenji trusted documents.

But the word Otaru held him.

He opened his own drawer. Not the right one—there lay the USBs, disks, a clean folder. The left one—there lay an old notebook in a soft cover, with paper glued to the spine. On the paper, in a faded marker, "2008–2010." He had not opened this notebook since two thousand and twenty. He kept it because he never threw things away.

He opened it.

The first pages—notes from second-year university analytics. Further—salaryman lunch recipes. Further—telephone numbers, crossed out two or three deep. On the forty-fifth page—a page from July of two thousand and eight, brief: "*Otaru. OSINT club. Course. 1–29 July. Instructors: Honda, Takeuchi, Yoshida. Lunch—700 yen. Room—3200 a night, guesthouse Marumi.*"

Kenji looked at the word "Yoshida" in his own hand. His hand of eight years ago. Then—a little upright. Now he wrote at a slant.

He turned the page. On the fiftieth—"Yoshida-sensei cried at the farewell. Gave me a haiku collection. Did not remember the publisher."

Kenji closed the notebook.

Set it on the desk.

Sat.



He thought about Kurosawa.

Kurosawa was asleep at home. This was not the hour to call Kurosawa. Kurosawa had been sleeping badly for six weeks—since the day of Erimo—and Kenji knew this not from stories but from how Kurosawa spoke in the morning. Kurosawa had two registers of tiredness: the first—when he spoke in shorter sentences, and the second—when he spoke in the same sentences, only with longer pauses between them. The second register was a signal that he had slept less than four hours.

Kenji knew Kurosawa would come to him at seven thirty in the morning.

Before then—he had to decide.

He opened a new window. Typed the query: "*Yoshida Hiro, 1962, Otaru.*" Three hundred hits. Most—another man. Kenji sorted by registry number. Filtered out those with a permanent address outside Otaru. Two remained. One—the owner of a door-and-frame shop, still working. The other—"*former caretaker / educator, pension since 2019, no registered employment.*"

The second row had no photograph.

Kenji checked the local newspaper archive, *Otaru Nippō*. Over fifteen years—three mentions:

1. "*Honoring veterans of pedagogy ceremony, 2011: Yoshida Hiro, educator.*" No photo. 2. "*Summer seminar on information literacy for young people in 2008, the 'Otaru OSINT' circle, instructors: Honda Takashi, Takeuchi Hiroshi, Yoshida Hiro.*" No photo. 3. "*Farewell evening for the director of Jindai-en, 2019: Yoshida Hiro handed leadership over to Inoue Satoshi after twenty-one years of work.*" No photo either. Only text.

Three lines. The word "Jindai-en."

Kenji looked at the word "Jindai-en" for a long time.

He knew the children's home Jindai-en existed. He had once walked past it with friends, on the way to Pier Two, and had thought then that the Taishō-period building, wooden, with a well-kept facade, looked cared for—someone was tending it. He had not remembered the director's name then. He rarely remembered such things.

But that had been in the summer of two thousand and eight. He had come to Otaru for a month. He had been studying OSINT. Three instructors. One of them cried at the farewell.

He did not remember the face.

He remembered only how this man had stood on a small dais in the hall of the guesthouse Marumi on the second-to-last evening, talking about *reading memory through things*, and how at the end, when everyone was rising, he—Yoshida-sensei—had remained standing on the dais and looked silently at the room. And how there was water in his eyes. Kenji—that twenty-three-year-old Kenji then—had thought: *"this is not sentimentality, this is—something else."* He had not dug down to what, exactly. Now, twenty years later, in the night silence of the office, with the black rectangle of the switched-off monitor to his right—Kenji tried to dig it out.

He did not dig it out.

Memory gave the image of the back of a head. Narrow shoulders. Gray suit. Short hair. The face memory did not give.

Kenji closed the notebook.

He opened a very old folder. Photographs from the course. A group shot in the yard of Marumi, taken hurriedly—thirty-two people in three rows. Kenji found himself—second row on the right,

in a white shirt, thin. Found Honda Takashi—smiling into the camera, hand raised. Found Takeuchi—standing to the side, arms folded. Yoshida Hiro in the group photo was not there.

That is, he was. Kenji checked three times. It was the third row. But in the third row stood a man whose face was covered by the shadow of the canopy over the entrance. Only his shoulders, brow, and the angle of his chin were visible.

Kenji zoomed in. The pixels scattered. He zoomed out.

He compared the angle of the chin with dozens of chin angles that the police knew from various records of the Doll Maker. The records were of poor quality—fragments from public cameras—and in three of them one could see a fragment of the left side of a face. The angle of the chin—approximate. It might match. It might not.

Might does not work.

Kenji closed the window.



Kurosawa came in at seven twenty. He knocked once. Came in.

"Kenji-san." "Kurosawa-*keibu*." "You haven't slept." "Slept two hours." "The list?" "Here."

Kurosawa sat on the second chair—the one Kenji kept so that someone could sit—and looked at the monitor. Kenji scrolled.

Kurosawa was silent.

"How many," he asked. "Forty-seven." "Can you cut it down in a week?" "In a week I will have twenty. In two—eight. In three—five." "There are no three weeks."

Kenji nodded.

Kurosawa looked at him. Kenji held the gaze. Kurosawa read something in his face—Kenji did not know what—and said:

"You found something." "Not found. Saw." "Saw—what."

Kenji laid his palms on the desk.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*. In two thousand and eight I was in Otaru. A month. Summer OSINT course. Circle level, teenagers up to twenties. I came from Sapporo for a day or two, then stayed a month—my previous job let me. One of the instructors was named Yoshida."

Kurosawa did not move.

"Name?" "Hiro." "The same as on the list." "The name matches. But Yoshidas in Hokkaido are in the thousands. Yoshidas Hiro aged fifty-five to seventy in Hokkaido—forty-seven. In Otaru—two. One—a shop owner. The other—a pensioner, former educator. No photo. No active contacts. One line of mention in the paper—Jindai-en."

Kurosawa looked.

"You saw him?" "About four weeks. He came to the classes, taught, left. Cried at the farewell. Gave me a haiku collection."

"Do you remember the face?"

Kenji was silent.

"No."

Kurosawa waited. Kenji finished.

"I remember shoulders. Hair. The suit. The shadow he stood in on the group photo. Face—no."

"It is the same man." "I don't know." "Kenji-san."

Kenji lifted his eyes.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*. Yoshidas in Hokkaido are in the thousands. Yoshidas Hiro of the right age—forty-seven. Two in Otaru. But this—is not yet him. I could be wrong. I want to be wrong. I will not tell you it is him until I cross-check through the pension registry. That is three weeks."

"We have no weeks." "I know."



Kurosawa sat silent. He reached for Kenji's cup—only to occupy the hand. Did not drink.

"Kenji-san." "Yes." "You went to his classes." "Yes." "He knew your name." "Yes." "You had conversations." "Once. He asked where I was from. I said Sapporo. He said, *very good that you came to us*. Beyond that—nothing. He did not hold conversations. He held the course."

"You did not stay in his memory." "Him—I don't know. Me—yes."

Kurosawa set the cup back on the desk. With his fingers. Very precisely, onto the same ring he had lifted it from.

"Kenji-san." "Yes." "Do not get into a car with me for Otaru." "Kurosawa-*keibu*." "I will not take you. You are not a witness. You are—doubt. Doubt I need here. In Sapporo. With a keyboard."

"I understand." "You cut it to eight. In three weeks." "In two." "In two."

Kurosawa stood.

"Do you remember what he said on the dais?"

Kenji thought.

"Reading memory through things. That is a phrase." "The subject?" "Three sessions. On doing OSINT not through people but through their objects. Glass. Keys. Wrappings. He said: a man forgets to say, a thing does not forget to be."

Kurosawa nodded. For a long time.

"That—is him."

Kenji lowered his head. Not a bow—a little. The way one bows to oneself when confirming what one does not want to confirm.

Kurosawa went to the door.

"Kenji-san." "Yes." "You did not expose him. You only saw him." "Yes." "That—is not your fault." "I know."

Kurosawa went out.

Kenji sat. The right monitor—dark. The middle—with forty-seven rows. The left—with one row. *Yoshida Hiro. 1962. Otaru. Jindai-en. Pension since 2019.*

He opened a window. Wrote:

Cried at the farewell. OSINT course. Guesthouse Marumi. July 2008. "A thing does not forget to be."

Saved.

He put the notebook in the left drawer. Did not close the drawer. The coffee stayed cold. The glass of water—touched twice.

He looked at the middle monitor.

He thought about Kurosawa. Not today's—the one who had just gone out of the office and was walking the corridor now to the stairs. Kurosawa had not said either "thank you" or "shame." He had said "that—is him." That was the firmest thing Kurosawa had ever said to

Kenji. It was also the softest. Kenji knew the difference.

He did not want to be wrong. But he also did not want to be wrong in the opposite direction—did not want to be silent at eight percent certainty when at another twenty percent it was the hand that had crushed a pencil into his shoulder after the farewell session. Yoshida-sensei had touched his shoulder. Kenji remembered this. The hand had been warm.

He stood. Switched off the middle monitor. Switched on the left. On the left he had a plain text editor in which he wrote what he did not show. He wrote one line.

He touched my shoulder.

Did not save.

Closed the window.

Outside the window that was not there, dawn was coming.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Endo. The Grave

"The son—is alive."

Hiraoka Cemetery lay on the slope south of Sapporo—a place from which the city below seemed a chance occurrence among the hills—and Kurosawa had come here twice a year since two thousand and thirteen: once in spring, in the April week of remembrance, and again in August, when the heat held the cicadas in one long note. He came to his father's grave—not out of love—out of duty. His father's grave stood three rows from the road, beneath a small maple—the stone plain, low, the name carved in an inexpensive script. Kurosawa laid one branch of cypress, refilled the water in the bowl, and left.

Today he had not come to his father.

Ogawa Tatsuo's grave stood on the new side—the one opened in the twentieth—in the twenty-fourth row from the gate, under the plaque "*Ogawa, house in Sapporo.*" The stone was new, dark gray, not yet stained by moss. The name—fresh. The date—March of two thousand and twenty-eight. Five months ago.

He stood.



Ogawa had died under a tractor. It was a stupid death—the kind whose family does not know how to tell. He had gone to his nephew's, in a village outside Asahikawa, for the Saturday. The nephew was plowing a plot. Ogawa was walking the field, looking. The tractor was old, from the nineties. The brake failed, the machine

started down the slope. Ogawa stepped aside in the wrong direction. The wheel went over his chest. Fifty-three years old. A quiet man. He had wanted no harm.

Kurosawa had buried him in March. Then Tanaka Ryosuke had come from Tokyo—Tanaka had been a colleague of Ogawa's from the academy, had known him longer than Kurosawa—and by Tanaka's own account it was the one instance in which he had put off his own assignment. Tanaka had stood at the funeral beside Kurosawa. Silent. Kurosawa was silent. Ogawa's wife, Toshiko, held Ogawa's small son—eight-year-old Hiro—by the hand. Hiro did not cry. Toshiko cried quietly, into a white handkerchief.

A week later Tanaka received the appointment to Ogawa's post. He came from Tokyo temporarily. "*Temporarily*" was five months ago.

Kurosawa thought of Ogawa only when Tanaka came into the office. That was not fair to Ogawa. But it was fair to Kurosawa's head—it held the image of Ogawa only through the silhouette of Tanaka in the doorway.



He crouched before the stone. The water in the bowl—stagnant. Ogawa had a wife who came—Kurosawa knew that—but today was Wednesday, and Toshiko came on Sundays. Four days had been enough for the water to bloom.

Kurosawa unscrewed the cap of the plastic bottle—he had brought water from home—poured out the old, poured in the new. He laid one branch of cypress on the low shelf. He had cut the branch that morning, a block from the unit, from a live hedge—did not ask permission. Ogawa had loved cypress. Ogawa had once said his father kept one in the garden. Kurosawa had remembered—not

because he was planning to remember.

He set his hand on the stone. His palm was dry. The stone—cool.

Did not speak.

After a minute he took from the inside pocket of his jacket the sheet. The same one. Folded in three. Worn corners. "*Kurosawa*" written in the flourish he had known for seven months. Written on heavy paper the Doll Maker had used from some reserve lot of the two thousands—the paper still smelled of an old chest of drawers—and Kurosawa noticed the smell every time the sheet came near his face.

Kurosawa smoothed the sheet. Read for the twentieth time what he knew by heart. One line. One word. A name.

He laid the sheet on the stone.

Stood another minute.

Then lifted it—did not leave it—folded it—and put it back into the pocket. He spoke—to the stone, quietly, not for the stone's sake:

"Not yet, Ogawa-san."

An ant ran along the branch of cypress. Kurosawa watched until it was gone.



He walked to the road on foot. The car was outside the gate, beside two others—a silver sedan and a white minivan.

The phone vibrated in his pocket as he opened the door.

Kurosawa looked at the screen. A "03" prefix—Tokyo. Unfamiliar. He knew what it was.

He answered.

"Kurosawa." "Kurosawa-*keibu*." "Endo-san." "Do not interrupt, please. I am brief."

Endo's voice was the same as seven months ago—low, calm, with a minimal tilt at the ends of sentences. She spoke at the pace of a person for whom nothing falls out of the list.

"I am listening."

Kurosawa sat in the car. He did not start the engine. The air conditioning was off. Heat inside was rising. He did not notice.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*, the exhumation of Ren gave its answer. The body—is not Ren."

"I know."

"You are looking for a live man."

"I know."

Endo was silent.

"Then let me say one more thing," she said. "I have held this file for seven months. Since the day the exhumation gave its result. I did not show it, because it is not my jurisdiction. Tokyo put me on a consultative contract from January. I hold access to three databases I would not have in Sapporo. My contract ends in December. Then I will not see these databases."

"Say it."

"In my data," said Endo, "is the surname of the Otaru coroner who signed the body under Ren's name in April of two thousand and twenty-two."

Kurosawa waited.

"Kawai Tatsuya." Endo dictated slowly. "Kawai—河合. Tatsuya—達也. Born nineteen fifty-three, Otaru. Coroner in Otaru from nineteen eighty-two. Over thirty-seven years—more than four thousand certificates. Never charged. Never disciplined. Pension from the twentieth. Died in the twenty-fourth. Oncology. Natural death."

"Natural."

"Yes."

"You are certain?"

Endo was silent one second.

"Eighty percent," she said. "Twenty—I keep in reserve."

Kurosawa nodded to the phone, and said nothing. Endo went on:

"Kawai Tatsuya was in contact with Mori Katsuya, the previous director of Jindai-en, from nineteen eighty-six. This is known from letters in the Mori archive Kenji got into on Monday. Mori died in ninety-eight. Kawai went on working. Yoshida—the new director—inherited Kawai through the channels Mori had used. Yoshida and Kawai were in direct contact at least twice: once in two thousand and three, once in two thousand and eleven. In the twenty-second, when Yoshida falsified the body of Ren, Kawai signed the certificate. That is all I have on Kawai."

Kurosawa closed his eyes. Tired from the sun—the air in the car was already warm—he felt the heat pressing into his palms.

"Kawai is dead," he said.

"Yes. But—Kurosawa-*keibu*." Endo let a small pause hold. "The son—is alive."

Kurosawa opened his eyes.

"The son." "The son. Kawai Takehiro. Born nineteen eighty-four. In Otaru. Heir to his father's practice—private medical practice in Otaru, Temiya district. Alive. Forty-four years old. Not married. No children. Mother—Kawai Hatsuko, eighty-one, alive, in the Otaru-Kōeikai care home. Takehiro visits her."

Kurosawa was silent.

"Let me guess," said Endo. "His father's practice—is the same one in which Kawai Tatsuya signed the certificate of Ren's death in the twenty-second."

"Yes."

"Let me guess," said Endo again, "that Takehiro has inherited not only the practice."

Kurosawa sat. The water bottle on the passenger seat had sweated onto his palm.

"Endo-san." "Yes." "Thank you."

"Kurosawa-*keibu*." Endo did not change her tone. "This is not a gift. This is information. I ask only one thing of you."

"I am listening."

"Do not summon him today. He has a practice, a standing clientele. Yoshida will know within an hour. Watch a week. Give Kenji time to set surveillance. Then summon him—but with prosecutor Fujiwara, and with a search warrant on the practice simultaneous with the interrogation."

"I will do that."

"One more thing."

Kurosawa waited.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*. I have no jurisdiction in Otaru. I got a call today from Sapporo—about a new post. Tanaka Ryosuke wants to bring me back from Tokyo as a consultant for your unit."

"I know. He told me this morning."

"Are you—for?"

Kurosawa thought.

"Yes, Endo-san. I am—for."

"I will tell Tanaka yes, if you say yes."

"Say it."

"I will."

Endo was silent another second. Kurosawa waited—he knew—Endo was silent before saying the last thing.

"Kurosawa-*keibu*." "Yes." "You are—not alone."

"I know."

"Do not forget."

"I will not."

"All the best."

Endo hung up.



Kurosawa sat in the car another five minutes.

The air conditioning he did not switch on. The heat inside grew thick. He felt sweat at his temples. He pulled his tie loose—did not take it off—loosened it.

He took out the notebook. Wrote:

Kawai Takehiro. Heir to father's practice. Otaru, Temiya. Not married. Mother at Otaru-Kōeikai. Surveillance—Kenji. One week.

Closed the notebook.

He looked into the side mirror. In the mirror—Ogawa's stone, a square of dark stone among other squares. The cypress branch lay where he had left it. The ant, no doubt, had already passed and gone.

Kurosawa started the engine. Opened the window on the passenger side. Pulled out of the lot slowly.

On the road to Sapporo—two cars ahead, three behind. He held the middle speed.

Hills slid past the window. The city below began as a gray band—where the skyscrapers cut their notch. Kurosawa was not looking at them.

He was looking at the road.

The sheet was in his pocket. He did not take it out.

Ogawa remained where he remained. The place was new, not yet stained. Toshiko would come Sunday.

Kawai Takehiro sat in a practice in Otaru—Kurosawa had not yet seen him—and Kurosawa did not yet know what the son's eyes were like. He knew only that forty-four years, and that there was a mother whom he visited. That was already something. That was—a lever.

He turned on the radio. He was not listening. The radio was needed to keep from hearing the silence in the cabin.

The silence in the cabin that day was very dense.



Half an hour later the second phone rang in the car—the work one. Kenji.

"Kenji-san." "Kurosawa-*keibu*. Did Endo-san pass it to you?" "Yes. Kawai's pension, the son, the practice." "I have already set surveillance. One car by the practice, one by the mother's home. One passive—in Niigata, on Ayano—on Michiko just in case." "On Michiko?" "The name matches in two registries," said Kenji. "I checked again this morning. Michiko Takahashi, nurse, Niigata, forty-seven. Ward of Jindai-en, nineteen eighty-five through ninety-three. That is the same Ayano—from the clinic—who supplied the midazolam." "You are sure." "Endo-san's twenty percent reserve. I hold it."

Kurosawa was silent.

"Surveillance—passive." "Only passive," said Kenji. "We will not take her until we take him. Otherwise she warns him."

"Yes." "One more thing, Kurosawa-*keibu*." "Yes." "Tanaka Ryosuke wants a briefing at six." "I'll come."

Kurosawa hung up.

The road became uniform. Hills, then plain, then hills again, then field, then suburb. Kurosawa looked ahead.

The sheet "*Kurosawa*" was in the inside pocket of his jacket. He felt it in his shoulder when he turned the wheel. Not strongly. But—steadily.

He arrived at the unit fifty minutes later.

Tanaka was in his office. Door open. Kurosawa walked past, nodded. Tanaka nodded back. He asked nothing.

Kurosawa walked to his own office. Closed the door behind him. Turned off the phone. Sat. On the desk lay the Hiraoka Cemetery

visitors' log—he had not taken it that morning, had left it for later.

He opened the log. Wrote his name. The date. Entry time—09:47. Exit—10:22.

Closed the log.

He took out the sheet "*Kurosawa*." Set it on the desk in front of him. Looked. Did not read. He knew it by heart.

One name.

Not yet. But—soon.



CHAPTER NINE

The Room—Sato, After

"You have seen. That is enough."

The morning was high. The mountains stood beyond the window grayish-green. The air smelled of resin and wet earth.

Sato sat on the top step. Outside. The wooden porch was old. Boards washed by hundreds of rains. One board in the middle of the porch creaked—Sato knew which.

He held a cup in his palms. Empty.

He was smoking.

A pack of Peace lay by his hip. One cigarette—in his fingers. The second—in the pack. The third and beyond—already smoked.

He was not counting.



The house stood on the slope of Ashibetsu-yama. One story. A kitchen. A room for him. A room for Yoshida. A bath. That was all.

Sato did not know whose house it was.

He had come here on the third day. Yoshida had driven. Yoshida was at the wheel himself. The road wound. Sato had looked out the window and had not asked.

Second week.

Walking on the porch. Sleeping. Eating rice. Listening. Not thinking.

He was waiting.



The door behind him slid open. Sato did not turn. Steps soft—bare. Yoshida always walked barefoot in the house.

"Sato-san."

"Yoshida-sensei."

"You are early."

"Slept well."

"That is good."

Yoshida sat on the top step. One over from Sato. The board did not creak. He knew where to sit.

In his hands—a small tray. On the tray—two teapots. One—low, with a rust-green glaze. The other—clear, glass. The glass one was warm, with a small amount of tea inside. Sato saw the color—saturated, dark green, almost herbal.

"Gyokuro," said Yoshida.

"Gyokuro."

Sato set his own cup on the tray. Yoshida poured.

The tea came slowly. Very slowly. That is how gyokuro is poured—the bottom of the cup should hold a thin layer.

Sato lifted the cup with both palms.

He did not drink at once.

He looked into the tea.



Yoshida poured his own. Took the cup, also with both palms. Held it by his knees.

Sato sipped.

The taste was soft. Not bitter. Sweet, like young greens.

"Good."

"Yes."

Silence.

Sato looked at the mountains. The green of the mountains was the same as in the tea. He did not say it. That would be a metaphor. He had long stopped saying such things.

Yoshida was silent. Also looking at the mountains.

Two minutes.



"Sato-san."

"Yes."

"You came fourteen days ago."

"Yes."

"Is it easier?"

Sato thought.

"Yes."

"Kenta."

"What."

"Kenta. You saw him."

Sato nodded. Once.

"I saw."

"He is alive."

"In the room."

Yoshida was silent. Sato understood the silence as consent.

"He grew up."

"Yes."

"He was ten."

"Yes."

"In the room he was ten."

"Yes. In your room—as much as needed."

Sato nodded.

He remembered the room differently each day. Today he remembered it this way: old tatami, a lamp, a book about rabbits Kenta had not liked. Kenta had liked a book about ants. Sato had not bought books about ants—Michiko had said ants were frightening.

Now Michiko was long gone. Now Kenta too was long gone. But in the room Kenta was—with a book about ants in his hands. Sato sat opposite. Listened.

He knew this was not Kenta. Yoshida had told him this beforehand. Yoshida had said: "You see what memory will do when you let it." Sato had agreed. Sato had wanted to see.

Sato had seen.

Now it was easier.



Yoshida sipped.

"Sato-san. You saw how he would have gone on living. That is enough."

Sato was silent.

Then he said:

"Yes."

"You must go."

"I know."

"Where—is your choice."

"I know."

Sato sipped again. The cup was still warm.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"May I ask."

"Yes."

Sato did not look at him. He looked into the tea.

"You—are not Genshō from the monastery, are you?"

Yoshida waited. He did not take offense. He did not smile.

"No. I am the keeper of Genshō-an hermitage in Hidaka. That is different."

Sato nodded.

"Different."

"Genshō from the monastery—is a different person. He is older. He is in Sōunkyō. He and I have never met. The name is close. Not me."

"I understand."

Yoshida sipped.

"You asked because someone told you."

"One man said it. In Furano. He said Genshō from Reisen-ji. I thought—that was you."

"That one—is not me."

"I understand."

Sato sipped.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"Thank you for the tea."

"Please."



Silence again.

A bird sang beyond the trees. Far. Silence again.

Sato set the cup down. Empty.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"What next."

"You say."

Sato looked to the side. At the board that creaks.

"I want to go home."

"To Kingyo."

"Yes."

"That can be."

"Can be?"

"Yes. You are free."

Sato nodded. Then said, quietly:

"I thought not."

"You thought wrong."

Sato turned his head. Looked at Yoshida for the first time. Yoshida sat straight, holding the cup with both palms. His face—warm—not saccharine—with a warmth that had no hurry in it.

"You are not a prisoner, Sato-san. I do not hold you."

"And the room."

"The room—by your consent."

Sato was silent.

Yoshida waited.

"Sato-san. Say the word and I will drive you to the station."

Sato looked.

"But."

"But?"

"I have one question."

"Yes."

Yoshida waited.

"You—visit others."

"Yes."

"How many."

"Those I chose—not many. Those who chose me—also not many."

"Nine."

"You have heard this."

"Yes."

"Yes—nine. Now—yes."

Sato nodded.

Then said:

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"How did you choose me."

Yoshida looked at him. For a long time. Sato did not look away.

"Sato-san. Every morning at forty-two you went out to the pier. Held one cigarette. Looked at the water. Stood twenty minutes. Went back to Kingyo. Drank coffee. Cut fish."

"Yes."

"That was not life. That was a form."

Sato did not object.

"I could not give Kenta back to you. I could only let you see what he would have grown into. Now—you know that you did not kill him. You did not pull him out of the water—that is not killing. That is a form of grief. You can live on without that form."

Sato sat.

"Do you understand, Sato-san?"

Sato nodded.

"I understand."



Yoshida poured again. The glass pot was empty. Sato drank the second cup slowly. Taste soft. Mountains the same.

Sato said, to no one:

"Kingyo has to be opened."

"It does."

"Someone tidied for two weeks."

"No one. It is waiting."

"It is waiting."

Sato finished.

Set the cup down. The board did not creak. He was sitting straight.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"One more thing."

"Yes."

"Kurosawa-keibu."

Yoshida waited.

"What of him."

"He is looking."

"I know."

"He is a good man."

"I know."

"Sato-san. You love him."

"Yes."

"That—is his matter. Not yours."

Sato nodded. Then:

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"I never saw him. Did not see him in the room. Did not see him here."

"No."

"He did not come."

"He will come. Not to me—to himself. That is another road."

Sato was silent. For a long time.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"I will leave today."

"All right."



Yoshida stood. Not quickly. Took the cup with both palms. Went into the house. The door slid. Soft steps on the floor. He set the cups on the kitchen table—Sato heard.

The door slid shut.

Sato sat on the top step. Smoked one more. Did not read. The mountains stood green-gray. The bird sang again—further.

He thought of Kenta. Not of the room. Of Kenta once—on the pier, with a paper airplane in his hands—a year before he drowned. The airplane was yellow. Kenta had made it himself. Kenta had launched it. The airplane flew for two seconds and fell into the water. Kenta laughed. Sato laughed too. Once. Then.

Sato smiled faintly.

It was the first time in many years.

He finished the cigarette. Put it out in a tin of water at his feet. Smoke went up in a white thread into the morning air.

He stood.

He went inside to gather his things.

Behind him on the porch board lay a pack of Peace. One remained. It could stay. Sato did not take it.

He would go back to Kingyo.

He would open the doors.

He would pour himself green tea.

He would cut fish.

Yoshida-sensei would go back to his Genshō-an. Sato would not see him again.

That is another road.

The mountains behind the house stood green-gray. The bird did not sing again.

The morning was gone.



He gathered his things simply. One shirt. One trousers. Slippers. Two books that Yoshida-sensei had given him—Notes of Solitude and A Small Anthology of Bashō. Sato took only the second. The first he left on the low table. Yoshida-sensei would see, would understand.

He came out of the room. Yoshida-sensei stood in the kitchen. Making himself tea—different this time, barley. He did not look up when Sato came in.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"I am ready."

"The keys are on the table."

Sato took them. Put them in his pocket. In the pocket, besides the keys, was a pack of Peace. Yoshida-sensei had put it in earlier.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"Thank you."

"For the tea."

"For everything."

Yoshida-sensei turned his head. Looked at him for the first time that morning.

"Sato-san."

"Yes."

"You are a good man."

"So are you."

Yoshida-sensei smiled. Very faintly. At the corners.

"Go."

Sato nodded. Went to the door.

At the door he stopped. Did not turn.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes."

"If he comes—Kurosawa-keibu—will you pour him tea?"

Yoshida-sensei was silent one second.

"Yes."

"Gyokuro?"

"Yes."

Sato nodded. Went out.

The door slid shut behind him softly. The board on the porch creaked—the same one—as he stepped on it.

He went down the path. Long. The trail wound. One hour to the road. Two hours to the bus. The bus to Ashibetsu. Then the train.

He came to the first bend of the trail. Turned. The house stood on the slope. The roof was not visible past the trees—only the chimney.



Nothing came from the chimney. Yoshida-sensei was not lighting a fire that morning—it was warm.

Sato turned back to the trail. Farther. Farther. Farther.

The mountains held silence at his back.

He did not look back.



CHAPTER TEN

Kamishiroi ryokan

"The ryokan was bought in the tenth. Through a firm the dead man had closed."

Kenji came in at seven in the morning—earlier than the unit itself was awake—and was sitting in the corner chair with a laptop on his knees when Yukio and Sasaki walked into the office at the same time, from the corridor, from two sides. Miso in the carrier lay with his nose to the radiator and did not lift his head.

"You slept," said Sasaki.

"Five hours," said Kenji. "That is standard."

Yukio hung his coat. He noticed that Kenji had switched off the desk lamp and left only the monitor. That meant one thing: Kenji had found something, and did not want the cleaner who came in at

six forty to read it.

Yukio sat. Sasaki brought three paper cups of coffee from the corridor vending machine and set one in front of Kenji. He nodded, did not look.

"Show me," said Yukio.

Kenji turned the laptop screen toward the desk. On the screen—a gray scan of an old paper registry. Characters photocopied, the line a little crooked. Stamp of the administration of Akaneko-mura, September of two thousand and ten.

"Ryokan Kamishiroi," said Kenji.

Yukio did not move. Sasaki set her cup on the corner of the desk, slowly.

Kamishiroi. The first "room" they had found. Sato-san in a small two-story house on the side of the mountain, with a wooden bath, with a view over the bay, with a portrait of the owner from twenty years ago on the entrance wall. The ryokan in which they had thought they saw the edge of the network—and had turned out to see its entrance.

"Go on," said Yukio.

"The ryokan was bought in the tenth. Not by Yoshida personally—" Kenji opened a second scan, "—by a firm. Yuki-Kōgei LLC. Restoration of traditional architecture. Head office in Sapporo Chūō—I showed it to you last year."

"That is the same network firm from our map," said Sasaki.

"Yes. But—here it becomes more interesting."

Kenji laid an index finger on the name of Yuki-Kōgei's director in the scanned deed.

"Tanaka Hideo. Died in Otaru, September of two thousand and eight. Renal failure."

Yukio nodded. He remembered that.

"The deed is dated the twentieth of September, two thousand and ten. That is, two years after the director's death. Signature on the deed—Tanaka Hideo. Stamp—Yuki-Kōgei."

Sasaki set the cup flat on the desk. Did not drink.

"A dead man signed."

"A dead man signed," said Kenji. "Formally. On paper. In reality—the firm still existed, because no one had reported the death to the tax office. Tanaka-san's son did not report it, because he did not know his father was director of anything. The daughters did not report it, because they had not seen their father for fifteen years before his death. The firm became 'dormant.' The death certificate did not reach the tax office until the twelfth. Only then did the firm move to 'undergoing reorganization.' That is—between two thousand and eight and two thousand and twelve, Yuki-Kōgei was alive on paper, with a dead director who kept signing documents."

"Who signed?"

"The one who had the stamp."

Yukio reached for the coffee—did not take it—and set his hand on the corner of the desk. Sasaki knew this movement. She stood and was silent.

"Mori Katsuya," said Yukio.

"Mori Katsuya," Kenji confirmed. "Director of the children's home in Otaru, died in ninety-eight. Yoshida—his student and successor. Mori, before his death, registered Yuki-Kōgei through the nominee director Tanaka. The stamp remained with Yoshida. The

Kamishiroi deed in the tenth—his signature under Tanaka's name, with Mori's stamp. He bought the ryokan with money that lay in the firm's account from Mori's old period."

"How much lay there."

"Twenty-two million yen. The deed—eighteen point seven. The difference—for renovation. Renovation was done in the eleventh. Through Kita-Michi Zaimoku KK, out of Ashibetsu—the same on our map—cedar, Japanese larch. Interior partitions. Plus materials for the bath. Plus roof."

Yukio nodded.

"So the whole network," said Sasaki slowly, "did not grow from a network. It grew from a children's home in Otaru. Through one firm Mori created three months before his death. In ninety-eight."

"Yes," said Kenji.

Sasaki sat. For the first time that morning.

Yukio was standing. He did not sit. He looked into the laptop screen and past the laptop screen at the same time—the way a man looks through glass and through his reflection in the glass—and sees two things, and cannot choose which one to see next.

"Kenji-kun."

"Yes."

"The name of the children's home."

A pause.

"There isn't one."

"How 'isn't'."

"The NGO registry of Hokkaido from nineteen ninety-eight burned in two thousand and two. Fire in the archives of the Otaru administration. There were—paper files. Backup on film—did not survive, the equipment was old, the film had yellowed to unusable already in the nineties. Digitization began in the two-thousands, but without this part. I have only what is in later registries: in Otaru in two thousand and two—seven children's homes. Mori was director of one of seven. Which one exactly—needs either a person who remembers, or a document from another archive—tax, medical—and those are from other years. I am working. Give me three days."

Yukio was silent.

Seven children's homes. One of the seven. Mori—findable by name in retrospective medical declarations—but that is six weeks through the Sapporo state archive, and the state archive works like a state archive—not faster and not more accurate.

"We do not have three days," said Yukio.

"I know," said Kenji. "But this is what I can do. I do not make false promises."

Yukio nodded.

Sasaki lifted her head.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"So we do not have a network. We have an **origin**. Yuki-Kōgei is the bone from which the whole network grew. Kamishiroi is not the edge. It is the continuation. Mori prepared this by ninety-eight, and Yoshida carried it out."

"Yes."

"The children's home he grew up in—that is his frame. That is why Otaru."

"That is why Otaru," said Yukio.

Kenji half-closed the laptop—so the screen would not go out but would not shine in the eyes. He noted aloud:

"Kurosawa-san, I have one more sheet."

"Show me."

"Yuki-Kōgei in two thousand and eleven—besides Kamishiroi—bought three more objects. One in Memuro. One in Shiretoko. One in Hidaka."

"Hidaka."

"Yes. Mountain cottage. One story. One hectare of land. On paper—*dacha for the firm's staff*. Real staff at Yuki-Kōgei—two nominal ones, both puppets of Tanaka. That is, no one ever came out to the dacha as *staff*."

"Who pays the electricity."

"Ainu-Tabi Hoshō. Small payment, roughly eight thousand yen a month. That corresponds to one permanent resident. In the cold period—fifteen. That is, someone lived there."

"Since what year."

"Since the twelfth. Permanently."

Yukio nodded.

Genshō-an.

He did not say it aloud. Kenji did not know the word—it was not on our map. Sasaki knew: it had been in one report of the abbot of Reisen-ji in December of the year before last—the report Endo had

taken with her to Tokyo—and in it the abbot had noted that in the mountains of Hidaka there was a small hermitage, "*Genshō-an*," not officially registered, to which once a year an old monk walks with a letter. The abbot had written it as an aside, without explaining why.

Yukio had marked it for himself then. He had not returned.

Now he did.

"That is his place," he said. "Not Otaru. Hidaka."

"The place he lives in—yes," said Kenji. "But the place where he keeps others—Otaru. Or nearby. A children's home we do not yet know."

"Yes."

Yukio turned to Sasaki. She sat with the tense calm she had before going out into the field—when she already knew where to go and was waiting for him to say it aloud, so as not to run ahead.

"Sasaki-san."

"Yes."

"Where do we go."

Sasaki thought one second.

"To Otaru. The children's home. Through Inoue, if he has access; through Yasuko, if he does not. Through medical exam archives. Through anything."

"No," said Yukio.

Sasaki lifted her eyes.

"To the lighthouse first," said Yukio. "He wants this."

Sasaki did not answer at once. Kenji set the coffee mug on the desk—now he was drinking—and turned his head to Yukio. He did

not ask aloud. He asked with a posture.

"That sheet from Erimo," said Yukio, "which only Sasaki-san knows about, because I showed her after I came back. It is addressed to me personally. He expects me to come there. The children's home—that is what I will find after the lighthouse. He plans it that way."

"Kurosawa-san," said Kenji, "this is a trap."

"Yes."

"And you are walking into it."

"Yes."

Kenji laid his forefinger on the edge of the desk. Silent. Then:

"Then the children's home I prepare for your return. By Sunday you will have an address. Yasuko-san—I have already started looking through the Otaru pension registry. That is faster than through the administration."

"Thank you, Kenji-kun."

"Not 'kun,'" said Kenji. "I do not mind 'kun.' I only noticed. You sometimes use '-kun,' sometimes '-san.' It is not important. Go on."

Yukio was silent.

Sasaki stood.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"We must prepare for the lighthouse. And this evening I have to go to my sister in Niigata. It cannot wait. Nao has one thing I must check with my hands."

"One night."

"One night. I return Monday morning."

"All right."

Sasaki nodded. Walked to her desk. Yukio did not ask what the thing was. He knew something about Sasaki and Nao from earlier years. He knew that when Sasaki said *one thing I must check with my hands*, it meant she had already checked it with her head and did not like what she had found.

Kenji stood in the corner.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"One more thing. Ryokan Kamishiroi—bought in the tenth. Renovation in the eleventh. But the furnishings—not from the eleventh. One board on a panel in the tea room—I checked through the restorer Komatsu-san from Sapporo, he did the report for Book One—dates to somewhere between nineteen ninety-eight and two thousand. That is, in Kamishiroi there is one board brought from some house dismantled between ninety-eight and two thousand. Not from the open market."

Yukio did not look at him.

"From what house."

"I don't know. I thought you might guess."

Yukio did not say it. He knew. The annex of ninety-eight—when Yoshida became director, and *reconstruction* of the annex began in one of the seven children's homes. He had not yet seen it. But he had seen the board that had been pulled from it and carried ten years later to Kamishiroi and set as a panel in the tea room, where Sato-san then sat.

These people saved everything. Nothing was thrown away.

"All right," said Yukio. "Kenji-kun. Continue on the children's home. Sasaki-san—today to Niigata, Monday morning here. Me—the lighthouse. Departure—Tuesday morning."

"Five days," said Sasaki.

"Yes."

Yukio looked at the corner of the desk, where Sasaki had set her cup and had not drunk. Two swallows of coffee remained. It stood cold now.

He took it and drank it in one go.

Outside the window the August rain was falling—thin as a thread—and Yukio thought about one board from an unknown children's home that had held the wall of the tea room in Kamishiroi twelve years after it had been pulled from there.

He did not know from which children's home.

He knew only that he would find it faster than the man hiding it would want.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Nao

"Don't go to Otaru. Not this Saturday."

Nao opened the door at six forty-five—without asking who—because she knew one thing: when Yuri came to Niigata unannounced, she stood on the landing exactly the pause with which she listened for whether the television was on inside. Nao switched it off. Nao waited.

The door was old, wooden, with a brass handle, like most first-floor buildings in Minami-Shiomi. Yuri took off her shoes, set them straight, toes to the wall. Hung her coat on the single nail by the entrance. Nao took her bag, set it on the low chest, and looked at her sister's face once—that short attentive look Yuri had once given her at fourteen, when Nao came home for the first time with a broken knee.

"There is onigiri," said Nao. "I'm putting the miso soup on now."

"Thank you."

"You are for one night."

"For one night."

Nao nodded. Did not ask why exactly.

The apartment was one room and a kitchen, as always in Niigata for a graduate student on the minimum stipend with a parental supplement on the rent. On the kitchen table—an open catalog. Nao closed it in a hurry when she saw Yuri's glance—but Yuri had

already seen.

An ichimatsu-ningyō. Small, porcelain, in a blue kimono, without a face. Photograph—old, on matte paper. Underneath—a caption in Japanese: *"Original from a private collection, Otaru. Exhibition 'The Body and the Form: The Japanese Doll in the First Half of Shōwa,' Otaru Museum, August 14–28."*

"You're taking me with you," said Nao.

"I am not taking you."

"You said 'one night.' That means you did not come with her."

Yuri was silent.

Nao set the miso soup pot on the stove. She noticed there was a little too little water and added from the kettle. She sliced leek slowly and evenly with the knife Yuri had given her two years ago. Behind each slice a small wet crescent remained on the board. Nao, when she concentrated, did not look at her hands. She looked at the wall above the sink.

"Nao."

"Yes."

"Tell me about work."

Nao had no time to understand how Yuri had understood—and did not want to, and started. She spoke calmly, with the slow clarity of a twenty-four-year-old telling of her first major research to a person she loves.

"I am writing my master's thesis on ichimatsu-ningyō of the first Shōwa period. Twenty-eighth to forties. Not about the dolls themselves—about their bodies. About proportions. About how proportions changed after the Kantō earthquake. Bodies became

heavier. Heads—a little smaller. As if before then dolls were held by the head, and after—began to be held by the hips."

"Does it have an explanation?"

"It does. The explanation is collective trauma. It is said that people after Kantō held children on their arms differently, and the masters saw this and applied it. But that is, of course, a hypothesis. No one has proved it."

"You are proving it."

"I am collecting. The exhibition in Otaru—fifty-eight dolls from private collections. There has not been anything like it since the nineties. I bought a ticket last week. For Saturday. I want to take you."

Yuri was silent.

"You pay, I accept," Nao said with a thin smile. "That is a rare gesture on my side. Take advantage."

Yuri did not smile. She set her elbow on the corner of the table, propped her forehead on her fist. That was how she did when she was thinking how to say. Nao knew that. Nao put the leek into the pot and turned the heat down a little.

"Nao."

"Yes."

"Don't go to Otaru. Not this Saturday."

Nao set the ladle in the bowl. Not at once. She turned her head to Yuri. Did not ask.

"Do not ask," said Yuri. "Please."

Nao looked at her. One second. A second.

"You are on work."

"Yes."

"It is serious."

"Yes."

"All right."

Nao turned back to the stove. Stirred. Yuri saw her cheek in profile—the cheek that did not tremble. Nao had this capacity: if someone important said *do not ask*, she did not ask. It was not obedience. It was trust, and Yuri knew that trust was what she was obliged to guard precisely because Nao did not ask the price of it.

"Nao."

"Yes."

"I will tell you everything. Later."

"I know."

Nao ladled rice into two small ceramic bowls. On top—one onigiri each, the ones with umeboshi that Yuri liked. She poured miso into two smaller bowls from the wooden ladle. She set everything on the low table in the corner of the room. She sat on a cushion opposite.

They did not speak for fifteen minutes.

Nao ate slowly. Yuri ate the way she always did—fast, focused, without pleasure. The onigiri was soft inside and level at the sides. Nao, among other things, shaped a good onigiri. Yuri had never said it aloud.

After supper Nao left the bowls in the sink—did not wash at once—turned off the overhead light and left only the desk lamp by

the window. The same yellow circle in which Yuri, when she visited, would read the paper before sleep, and Nao would work.

Nao opened the laptop.

"I will show you three pages from my master's," she said. "Only three. I will not tire you."

"Show me."

Nao turned. On the first page there was a large photograph of one doll in a blue kimono with a bow at the waist. A porcelain face, fine. Glass eyes, dark.

Yuri looked.

"This one," said Nao, "is from the Otaru collection. Nineteen thirty-four period. Master unknown. Believed to be a private commission. The body is unusually heavy—two hundred eighty grams for a height of twenty-two centimeters. That is an anomalous ratio. As if she is held in the ground."

"How many like this in the exhibition."

"With heavy bodies—eight. With truly heavy—only this one."

"From a private collection."

"Yes. The owner's surname is not given in the catalog. Only 'private collection, Otaru.'"

Yuri was silent.

Nao turned to the second. The photograph was contemporary: a shelf in some unfamiliar interior, three dolls in a row, under soft light. The second—not porcelain, you could tell by the texture. Composite. There was no face.

"And this one?"

"This one is not from the exhibition. This is from another chapter of mine. Reconstruction of dolls to the traditional recipe, but without a face. These are being made now, in some workshops in northern Hokkaido. These are not antique—they are modern. But by an old method."

"Who makes them."

"Names not given. One workshop—in Otaru. One—in Hidaka. Another—near Asahikawa. It is not banned. It is simply rare."

"Hidaka."

"Yes."

Yuri turned her head to Nao. Nao did not notice the pause—she scrolled on.

"The third."

This was not even a page of the master's. It was a screenshot of a museum database. Nao switched to the adjacent window.

"Here is the inventory. I have access through my department. This is not public. In Otaru, in the depository, lie twelve faceless dolls from the early nineties. Recorded as *donation of anonymous donor*. The donor gave them in three lots: nineteen ninety-three, nineteen ninety-six, two thousand and one. Four each time."

"Nao."

"Yes."

"Let me scroll."

Nao gave way. Yuri slowly scrolled the record. Doll size—twenty-two centimeters. Material—porcelain plus wooden armature. Face—absent. Clothing—dark blue. Date of manufacture—not established. Author—not established.

Yuri scrolled to the last accession date. Two thousand and one.

Two thousand and two—fire at the archive of the Otaru administration.

She set the laptop on its side. Did not close.

"Nao."

"Yes."

"Who runs this database."

"One senior curator. Yamamoto. He is sixty-three. He knows me. Well disposed."

"Do not ask him anything extra."

"I won't."

"I am not joking."

"Yuri—" Nao for the first time said her name, without "-nēsan,"
"—I know. I hear you."

Yuri nodded.

Nao closed the laptop.

Yuri sat in the yellow circle of the desk lamp and thought of one thing she did not intend to say aloud, not today or ever in front of Nao: that twenty-two centimeters, two hundred eighty grams, a dark-blue kimono, and an absent face—that is exactly the figure Kurosawa-san Yukio kept on his kitchen sill from that winter. He had taken it from Toshi's hut and he did not know himself why.

He had not thrown it out in two years.

—

She had begun then to understand that Kurosawa had a life before her—not one life, but several, layered one over the other, like the transparent films of an old slide projector, she was thinking now, as she wiped her hands on the towel in the corner of the kitchen. Nao in the other room was laying out the guest futon—Yuri could hear the sound of her movements through the thin partition.

She remembered one winter night—after Ogawa's death—when Kurosawa had been sitting in his office on the small settee and did not want to go home, and she had brought him coffee from the corridor vending machine, and had sat on the settee opposite, and he had been silent, and silent, and silent, and then said, without lifting his head:

"I had a brother. I did not tell you about him. He died six years ago. I thought so then."

Yuri had not asked *and now?* then. She took her coffee and drank, and let him go on.

Kurosawa had not gone on then. He had gone on a week later. He had told her about Otaru in two thousand and five, when he had gone on his father's case—and when his elder brother Ren was already teaching at an art school—and how Ren, in the conversation in a café, had said something about *one person who knows too much*, and how Kurosawa had not caught the name. Had not thought of it for twenty-two years. Had not held it as information.

He was telling me that then not because, Yuri thought, it made things easier for him. He was telling me because he knew: I had to know. I am his partner. I have to know why he does not sleep at three in the morning. He was not making me his listener—he was making me his witness. And that is different.

She came back from the memory when Nao came into the kitchen, took a glass from the sill, poured water from the kettle, and went silently back to the room. Yuri noticed that Nao had not asked whether Yuri would sleep—Nao knew Yuri would sleep—and had not asked whether Yuri would turn off the light in the kitchen—Nao knew Yuri would.

—

The package came thirty minutes later.

The Yamato courier, in a black cap, quietly, without a knock, left a small cardboard box by the door and went. Yuri met him in the corridor, signed, took the box. The name on the slip—"*Sasaki Yuri, temporary address.*" Sender—"*Ayano, Niigata clinic, hand delivery.*" Stamp—Niigata, that same evening. Time—seventeen forty-two.

Ayano the nurse. From the Niigata clinic. From the fall in Ashibetsu. Now—here.

Yuri did not go into the room to Nao. She went into the bathroom, closed the door behind her—Nao would hear the water in the pipe and think that her sister was washing her hands after the road—and opened the box on the lid of the laundry basket.

A small porcelain ichimatsu-ningyō. Twenty-two centimeters. Two hundred eighty grams by weight—she put it on her palm; she felt the weight. Dark blue kimono with a thin white edge. Face—none.

Inside—a small piece of paper, folded in two. Handwriting thin, calm, female.

"For elder sister."

Yuri stood over the basket for a minute. She did not move.

Then she folded the paper, put it into the inner pocket of her jacket, the one she had come in. She wrapped the doll in the same paper wrapping in which it had arrived, and put it back in the box. The box—under the sink, behind the basket. Nao did not look there.

Yuri turned off the light in the bathroom and went out.

Nao from the room:

"Yuri, the futon is ready."

"Thank you."

"I put out water for you."

"Thank you."

Yuri went into the room. Nao was already lying on her side, shoulder covered by the blanket, reading a book—small, paper, from a shop in Asakusa she liked. Yuri sat on the futon on the other side of the room. She took off her coat. She set the holster on the low chest.

Nao looked at her once. Saw the holster.

"You have a weapon."

"Yes."

"Yuri."

"Nao. Do not ask."

Nao nodded. Went back to the book.

Yuri lay down. She looked at the ceiling—the ceiling was white, with one stain from a leaking roof—and heard Nao turn a page. One—then a minute later a second.

Yuri set the phone on the nightstand beside her, silent, with vibration on. She looked at the screen for one second—expecting something—and expected nothing in particular.

The doll in the bathroom she decided to take with her to Sapporo in the morning. Not to throw away. To show Kurosawa after the lighthouse. Not sooner.

Nao closed the book five minutes later. Turned off the light on her side.

"Nao."

"Yes."

"You are a good onigiri master."

Nao laughed quietly in the dark. One short sound.

"I know," she said.

Yuri closed her eyes.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Lure

"It can be put together only at the lighthouse."

The letter lay on the kitchen sill.

Yukio did not notice it at once—he had come home from work at twenty fifty, taken off his coat, set the thermos on the sideboard—and then, when he was going to the kettle, he saw the white corner between the curtain and the glass. The curtain shifted slightly in the draft from the fanlight—and the corner emerged, and stayed standing. Yukio had not closed the window earlier. Whoever had placed the letter knew there would be no need to lock behind him.

He stood for two seconds, looking. Then he pulled a latex glove from the inside pocket of the coat still hanging on the chair. He took the envelope with two fingers—by the corner—and carried it to the kitchen table. He raised the shade of the desk lamp. One lamp, the way he liked it when he ate.

The envelope—plain, white. No stamp. No postage. No address written. Only one word in the middle, in pencil, small: "*Kurosawa*." The same hand that had been on the sheet from Erimo.

Yukio laid the glove on the other side and looked at the kitchen clock. Twenty-one oh two. He allowed himself ten seconds of silence—not because he was hesitating, but because he wanted to remember what he had done in those ten seconds—and then he opened the envelope.

Inside—two things.

The first—a photograph. Old, black and white, with serrated edges as they used to be trimmed by lab scissors. The Erimo lighthouse, shot from the sea, from a boat, at a small distance—three hundred meters—in a light that was either very early or very late. The rotating optic on the drawing of the lighthouse was not on. No people on the platform. No gulls in the sky. Only the concrete of the tower and a small rock behind. By the grain of the film—sixties, with certainty. By the type of paper—Fuji of that time, lab print. On the back—no inscription.

The second—a thin strip of paper cut from something larger. Width—about two and a half centimeters. Length—twelve. Printed on it in an old machine typeface, without punctuation, three words and two numbers:

"Seven days. One. Or two. No more."

Yukio laid the strip on the corner of the table, parallel to the photograph. He looked. He did not move anything. He did not read a second time—once was enough.

Then he reached for the phone.

One ring. Two. On the third Sasaki picked up.

"Kurosawa-san."

The tone of her voice was the one with which a person answers a call after nine in the evening: quiet, ready.

"Sasaki-san. Are you still in Sapporo?"

"I came back at six. I have been home."

"Come."

The pause was short. Exactly one breath.

"I'm on my way."

He put down the phone. Did not say anything more. He knew she would not ask aloud. He knew she would come in forty minutes—Sasaki's apartment was in Higashi-ku, two bridges and one overpass away, and she drove evenly and quickly.

Yukio returned to the table.

He set beside the photograph of Erimo another—from the inside pocket of his coat. The one he had carried these last six weeks and had not shown to Sasaki or to Kenji: a small cut-out fragment from the old school album of Otaru, which Endo had handed him before leaving for Tokyo. In the photo—the class of the children's home in nineteen seventy-five. Back row, fourth from the left—Yoshida Hiro, thirteen years old, thin, with a shaven head (for some childish reason, not by tradition). His face clear. His gaze straight.

Yukio set this photograph to the left of the lighthouse.

Then he took from the side pocket a second—from the same batch of Endo's. Misako Yoshida, eighth class, nineteen seventy. A girl with two small braids. Taken two weeks before her death. Yukio had not known that. He knew only one thing: the face was the same as her brother's—and not the same; the cheekbone the same, the lips different; he now knew they were twins, and he saw in that face a trait of Yoshida's—but so far he could not find, exactly, which. He had kept this photo in his coat for no reason—he could not throw it out.

To the right of the Erimo lighthouse he set the sheet "*Kurosawa*" from the eighth column. The same one. The one that had brought him here.

Further—three contemporary photographs: —Kurosawa Ren, two thousand and sixteen, at Chitose airport, laughing (the same one

that stood on the desk in his home office); —Kurosawa Ayano, Ren's daughter, twenty years old, from the Niigata passport system, taken in December two years ago; —One small porcelain figure without a face—a digital photograph, taken by Yukio on his phone in his kitchen last week, when he had for the second time in half a year taken it from the sill and turned it over to see if there was a maker's stamp on the bottom. There was none.

The eighth photograph—was not a photograph. It was one sheet from Kenji: a list of four firms from their map, now widened by one row—"Yuki-Kōgei LLC—Kamishiroi deed 2010—signature of a dead director." Yukio added it to the right of the others.

Eight elements. A rectangle on the table. Like a tarot layout, like a mosaic, like—it turned out in the pit of his stomach when he looked at it from above—both at once.

He stepped back one pace. Pulled out from under the sink a stool, set it by the kitchen window, sat. He drank cold tea from a glass that had stood there since morning. Not hungry. Did not want to move his hand.

He knew he knew a lot. He knew he lacked one thing.

—

Sasaki arrived thirty-six minutes later.

She had a key—Yukio had given her one back in November, after the night when he had caught cold and she had brought a doctor at four in the morning—and she came in without knocking. He heard the lock turn—and heard the front door close behind her—and heard her take off her shoes and set them down neatly—and walk down the corridor to the kitchen without hurry.

Yukio did not stand.

Sasaki came into the kitchen.

She saw the table before she saw him. She stood three seconds—exactly the pause with which people begin to understand when they are shown not a separate scene but a laid-out game. Then she set her bag on the corner of a chair. Did not take off her coat. Did not take off her scarf.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

He indicated the envelope with the corner of his chin.

Sasaki came closer. She took—she had gloves too, she pulled them from the side pocket of the coat and put them on—the photograph of Erimo. Looked. Did not ask. Then put it down. Took the strip with the words. Read. Put it down.

"Seven days."

"Yes."

"One. Or two. No more."

"Yes."

Sasaki looked at the table. Her gaze went left, then up, then right, the way the gaze of a person who has been trained to read a crime scene systematically moves. Yukio noticed she had switched off one extra emotion—the one she had had at the entryway—and was now working.

"Yoshida," she said. "Misako. Erimo. The sheet 'Kurosawa.' Ren. Ayano-the-daughter. The figure. Yuki-Kōgei."

"Yes."

"Eight."

"Eight."

Sasaki slowly nodded. Then dropped onto the chair opposite him. Did not take off her coat. Did not take off her scarf. The way one sits down when one has come not as a guest but on the job.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I don't know how to put this into one picture."

Yukio was silent.

He did not notice that he had said the same thing he had been about to say—but she said it first, with the even clarity with which she had spoken about Nao in the winter office five months after Ashibetsu. Yukio only repeated aloud:

"I don't know how to put them into one picture."

Sasaki raised her eyes at him.

"It can be put together only at the lighthouse."

Yukio did not answer at once. He looked at the table. At the strip with four phrases. At the photograph of Erimo, the sixties, taken from the sea, from a boat, at the distance from which a person shoots who is going to sail back. Whoever had taken this photograph—perhaps Yoshida himself, at thirteen or fourteen—had sat in a boat and looked at the lighthouse knowing he would come here at seventy to call his man here.

He had known it already then.

"Yes," said Yukio. "It can be put together only there."

Sasaki nodded.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"We do not ask Tanaka-san for permission."

"No."

"We do not write an official route plan."

"No."

"We do not take a team."

"No."

"We take only the two of us."

"Yes."

Yukio noticed that on "only the two of us" she had for a second covered with her voice the pause in which she might have added "and Kenji." She had not added. Because she already knew that Kenji would not go. Kenji had to hold the center while they were on the periphery. That was how this team had always worked, from the first day.

Sasaki set her fingers on the strip with "seven days."

"The seventh day is the seventh of August."

"Yes."

"We leave Tuesday morning."

"Tuesday morning."

"The drive—five hours, with a stop. Arrival at the dawn of Wednesday."

"Yes."

"That is 'one' day of the seven. We enter the lighthouse on 'one.' We will not stay there longer."

"Yes."

Sasaki nodded.

Yukio for the first time since she came in noticed that she was holding, in her left hand under the coat, the edge of something hard. The holster. She had not taken it off, because she was not going to sit long.

"Sasaki-san."

"Yes."

"Thank you for coming without asking."

"Not 'thank you.' It is simply work."

"All the same."

Sasaki was silent.

Yukio turned back to the table. He had wanted to ask one thing—about Nao, about the trip to Niigata, about that *one thing* she had had to *check with her hands*. He did not ask. He knew: if Sasaki had wanted to say aloud, she would have. She had not—so she was keeping it, and had reason to keep it. He was her partner. He would not draw out of her what she was not ready to place.

He looked at her briefly. Sasaki held the gaze.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"You are not showing me something."

Yukio did not answer at once. Then:

"You are not showing me something either."

Sasaki nodded.

"Then," she said, "after the lighthouse we will each put one more thing on the table."

"Agreed."

"Agreed."

Yukio took from the lower drawer of the chest under the sill a small cardboard box. Inside—three postal envelopes in which he kept documents prepared just in case. In the first—a will (drawn up a year ago at the Maruyama notary's office, short: apartment—to his aunt Kiyoko, photo archive—Endo, documents—Sasaki, cash—a charitable fund for the families of those whose loved ones did not come back from the taiga). In the second—pension data and the notary's phone. In the third—one sealed letter addressed to "Kurosawa Ayano, Niigata," no stamp. Yukio had never shown it to anyone. He had written it in January two years ago, when he had come back from Ashibetsu and could not sleep for two months.

He put all three envelopes back into the box. Did not take them out. Did not show them. But set the box in a visible place, on the upper shelf above the sink, on the right side—so that Sasaki, if needed, would know where to look.

Sasaki noticed the movement. Did not say anything.

"All right," she said. "I'll go."

"Yes."

"I'll come by tomorrow at seven."

"All right."

She stood.

Yukio stood too. They did not shake hands. That was not their custom. Sasaki went to the door. In the corridor—she put on her

shoes, neatly again—and set her hand on the door handle.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I have one thing I must show you. Not today. In the car on the way."

"All right."

"Good night."

"Good night."

She went out.

Yukio heard the front door close behind her. Then—heard steps along the corridor. Then—the entry doors open and close. Then—her car start below, on the street, and go.

He came back into the kitchen. He stood over the table. He looked at the eight elements.

He knew there would not be a ninth.

He knew that the ninth had to become himself.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Kenji—Does Not Go

"Not one confirmed. Will continue overnight."

Monday. Twenty-seven hours before departure. Yukio called Kenji into his office at eight in the morning—not seven forty, as usual—and not from the corridor but through the phone, because he did not want Tanaka Ryosuke behind the glass to see him get up in his booth and walk to Kenji's corner desk. Tanaka had noted every route Yukio took inside the unit over two weeks of observation; he knew which corner was five minutes without him, which was thirty seconds. So Yukio had rebuilt the routes.

Kenji came in a black hoodie, laptop under one arm, a can of Boss Coffee in his left hand. Miso in the carrier stayed at his own desk—Miso was sleeping today.

Yukio closed the office door. Not the blinds.

"Sit."

Kenji sat on the visitor chair to the right. Set the laptop on the corner of the desk. Did not open it.

"Kenji-kun."

"Yes."

"You are staying."

Kenji did not react at once. He, as always, took five seconds—not from not understanding, but from some inner processor Yukio had noticed a year ago. Then he nodded. Once.

"I knew you would say that."

"Keep contact with both Ayanos, with Otaru, with Endo, with Tanaka."

"With the two Ayanos—differently. With Ayano-the-nurse—I watch the mailbox at Niigata-Minami-Kunigi that appeared at hers on the seventeenth. I did not put a picket, that is not permitted, but there is a camera across the street, I have access through the housing complex. I know her schedule through Friday. With Kurosawa Ayano, your brother's daughter—I do not watch and will not. That is not my line. If needed—either Sasaki-san or you speak with her."

"Yes."

"With Otaru—Yasuko-san. I have her son's phone, he lives in Sapporo. He says she is mostly home, goes to the supermarket on Wednesdays and Saturdays. Yoshida has not visited her in the last six months. The son knows this because the mother said so herself."

Yukio nodded. That was new.

"With Endo—I passed it last night. She will make a call from Tokyo on Friday. Tanaka will not know about it."

"With Tanaka?"

"With Tanaka I keep formal contact. I give him reports on *methodological support*. Five pages a day, ten on Friday. He does not read more than half. He reads only when there is a number that seems to him wrong. I give correct numbers."

Yukio smiled slightly.

"You have learned to handle him."

"He underestimates me. That works both ways."

"Yes."

A pause.

Kenji opened the Boss Coffee can. Took one short swallow. Set it back on the corner.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"This is a trap."

"I know."

"Yoshida is waiting for you at the lighthouse. Not Yoshida—whoever he will call himself. He is there alone, or almost alone. He wants a conversation. He does not want shooting. But he has one exit and one insurance, and we do not know which."

"I know."

"Then why go."

Yukio did not answer at once. He knew the answer. He did not like to say it aloud, because it sounded simpler than it was.

"Because he said so."

Kenji was silent.

"Kurosawa-san," he said after a minute, "I know you know this. But I have to say."

"Say."

"If at the lighthouse you remain without Sasaki-san or without yourself, the team falls. Not because we do nothing without you—but because we built this operation from you. Endo has Tokyo, I have this desk, Sasaki—a sister. Each of us is held by something of our own. But what holds us together is you. If you are not there—Sasaki-san will pick up my half, I will pick up hers. But

that is another team, and it will work differently."

Yukio nodded.

"I know, Kenji-kun."

"Then," said Kenji, "let me hand you one thing."

He opened the laptop. Took from the inner pocket of the hoodie a small gray flash drive. USB type A. Unmarked.

Set it before Yukio.

"Here is everything I have for six weeks. Forty-seven Yoshidas. Career sheets. Last known addresses. Scans of registries. Medical exams where they exist. Pensions, where there is half of it. Transcripts of phone calls I could listen to—that is sixteen of the forty-seven. Nothing confirmed. Not one Yoshida of these forty-seven is the one we are looking for—I say that responsibly. None of them."

Yukio looked at the flash drive. Did not take it at once.

"None."

"None," said Kenji. "I checked. Not the age, not the geography, not the year in Otaru, not the profile. I lay the forty-seven as cover. If Tanaka asks—I show him this flash drive. He will read for three days and find nothing, because there is nothing there. This is my camouflage."

"And the real Yoshida," said Yukio, "is not among the forty-seven."

"Not among the forty-seven. He is among the non-Yoshidas. That is—Yoshida with an archive entry *release from post for reasons of health, 2019*, but with no pension trail in Hokkaido—did not make it through my first filter—I saw him yesterday in a passive

sheet where the Yoshidas were not entered because they are formally *not active*. I have him. Not yet confirmed—I need the pension registries 1998–2019, which come in Wednesday morning—but I have him."

"Yoshida Hiro," said Yukio quietly.

"I will not say," said Kenji. "Not today. Not until there is pension confirmation. I do not give you names without confirmation, Kurosawa-san. That is what you taught."

Yukio nodded. He looked at the USB for a minute.

"Kenji-kun."

"Yes."

"Continue through the night."

"I will continue through the night."

"On Wednesday morning," said Yukio, "when the pensions come in, you write an SMS to Sasaki-san. Not to me. My phone is in a state the Doll Maker may be able to track. You write to Sasaki-san on her personal number, not the work one, with confirmation or denial. Three words is enough."

"Understood."

"You write at four in the morning."

"At four I will already be asleep. The pension registries come in at three forty."

"So much the better. Do not write from a code we use in the team. Do not write key names. Only what is needed."

"Understood."

Yukio took the USB. Did not put it in his pocket—put it in the central drawer of his desk, locked it, put the key in his wallet, the wallet into the inside pocket of his coat—the one he would go out with on Tuesday morning.

"Kenji-kun."

"Yes."

"You did this alone for six weeks."

"Alone."

"I have not thanked you aloud once."

"There was no need."

"Thank you, Kenji-san."

A pause.

Kenji lifted his head. He did not look Yukio in the eye fully—he had no such habit—he looked at the corner of the desk beyond the interlocutor's shoulder, where Yukio had a small porcelain figure he had brought into the office from the apartment last month. But this time—after "san"—he raised his gaze for one second to the bridge of Yukio's nose. Not into the eyes. At the bridge of the nose.

One second—and back.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I have prepared one more thing for you," said Kenji. "For the evening."

"Which."

"My number. Direct, not through the switchboard. From this moment—twenty-four seven. If at the lighthouse you have a chance

to dial one digit—dial one. Automatic call to Erimo fire station through my server. That is a fifteen-minute delay, but faster than without it. I tested it."

"All right."

"And one more."

"Yes."

"The holster. You have it on your right. I know you carry one spare magazine. Take two. Not because you will need the second, but because I ask you. One magazine—by protocol, two—by me."

Yukio looked at him.

"All right, Kenji-kun. Two."

"Thank you."

Kenji closed the laptop. Took the Boss Coffee can in his palm. Stood. Then, still not moving:

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"If at the lighthouse it happens that you come back without Sasaki-san."

Yukio did not answer.

"I want," said Kenji, "you to know. She went not because you took her. She went because she chose. That is different."

Yukio nodded.

"I know, Kenji-kun."

"All right."

Kenji stood up. Walked to the door. On the threshold—he turned briefly.

"And," he said, "if you both come back—I am ordering both of you sushi-maki with tuna from Kyoto. The shop by the station you both like. That is my promise."

Yukio smiled at the corner of his mouth—the rare movement Kenji had already seen once or twice a year.

"All right."

Kenji went out.

Yukio remained at the desk. For a minute he did not move. Then he took out of the inside pocket of his wallet a small piece of paper—a receipt from the Maruyama notary's office, received a year ago—unfolded it, laid it before him, looked at it for one second.

He did not tear it. Folded it in two. Put it back in the wallet.

Outside the window the August morning was going on—the cicadas had not yet started—and Yukio thought about that one second when Kenji had raised his gaze to the bridge of his nose—not to the eyes—and said *san* back to him.

He knew Kenji would remember that.

He knew he would remember it too.

The Road to Erimo

"If something goes wrong—say I decided myself."

They left at twelve forty-five in the morning.

Sasaki at the wheel. Yukio in the passenger seat. The car—a dark gray Nissan Skyline from the administrative pool, whose plate Kenji had reissued to a different series that morning—not for evasion, but through a standard documentary procedure—so that patrols on the road, checking against the database, would see the series *"service, on rotation,"* and not *"Missing Persons unit."* Evasion of the Doll Maker's number cameras, if they existed—Kenji did not know whether they did.

The route—the Dōshin Expressway to Chitose, then Erimo highway south. Five hours with one intermediate stop. Arrival—around five forty in the morning. Sunrise in these August days—at four forty-five. That is, they would arrive by daylight.

Yukio had planned it that way. He was not going to walk into the lighthouse at night. He needed daylight to see a person.

For three hours they did not speak.

Sasaki drove evenly, holding a steady ninety—the speed at which she would not attract the attention of speed cameras or patrols on the night Dōshin. She had a habit of keeping her left hand in the lower corner of the wheel and her right on the shift lever—the way old-school detectives had done—and Yukio had never asked where

she got it. She did not drink coffee on the road. Did not listen to the radio.

Yukio looked out the window. Forest on both sides of the road—dark, tall, in places lit through by the moon. Once a small billboard from some Asahikawa sanatorium flashed past—a red crane on blue. Yukio remembered that crane from childhood. He had thought then it meant the sanatorium was good. He did not know why he still thought so.

At four oh eight they pulled off at a Cosmo filling station by the Hidaka-Yūbari pass. They filled up. Yukio went out for coffee to the thin metal booth in which two vending machines stood—one for hot drinks, one for cold. He bought two. One—with milk, for Sasaki; one—black, for himself. Sasaki stood by the car. Did not go into the booth.

Yukio came out and handed her a cup. She took it.

They drank standing. Coffee from the machine was not good—it had never been good on this stretch of road—but it was warm. That was enough.

The sky to the east was starting to unfold—a thin strip of gray over the dark blue—and Yukio saw the strip through Sasaki's silhouette, standing to his left, with coffee in her right hand, in a North Face down jacket, with short-cropped dark hair—Sasaki had not changed in two years, and Yukio had not noticed until this moment.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I have a sister."

"I know."

"Nao. Twenty-four. Niigata master's, art history. Lives alone in Minami-Shiomi, third floor, corner of the building. Parents in Komagata—that is Niigata prefecture—not close to Nao, but in the same prefecture. They come see her once every two months."

"Yes."

"I want to tell you," Sasaki set the cup on the top of the fuel pump, slowly, "if something goes wrong—you will find her. Tell her I decided myself."

Yukio did not look at her. He was looking at the strip of sky.

"I will tell her."

"Thank you."

Sasaki did not add anything. Did not explain what *something wrong* meant—because both knew—and did not explain why *decided myself*—because both knew that too. Between them it was not work and not friendship. It was something between a work oath and something they had never named, because they had no word for it.

Yukio slowly finished the coffee. He crumpled the cup in his palm. Threw it into the bin by the booth. Sasaki threw hers as well.

"All right," said Yukio. "Fifteen minutes."

"Fifteen."

They got into the car.

—

Erimo Highway was narrower than the Dōshin. In places two-lane, with an interrupted line. On the right—forest, tall cedar and larch, which Kita-Michi had once transported into the network. Yukio thought of that and did not think of it at the same time.

At five oh two they passed a small Shinto *torii* on the shoulder—old, with peeled red paint—with the inscription "*Kamishiroi-mura*" on the side post. Two hundred meters further, an exit into a small village where five years ago the ryokan Kamishiroi had been. Sasaki held the right turn. Yukio in the side-view mirror saw her cheek in profile—the same cheek that had not trembled at Nao's in Niigata—and thought that now, with that same look, she was passing the place where it all began.

He did not say it aloud. She did not either.

Fifteen minutes of silence.

—

At five twenty-seven Sasaki slowed at the entrance to Samani. The town was asleep. On the main street—yellow lamps, three of ten lit. Yukio noticed the ENEOS station they had driven past ten years ago on a case still stood in the same place, with the same sign and the same small rubber hose insufficiently coiled at the second pump.

Beyond Samani—a narrow road up, to the cape.

Sasaki reduced speed to forty. The road—with turns, with paint worn away in places. The wind—already different. Yukio heard it through the seal of the window—that low humming with which the Atlantic wind on Erimo turned into the other, from the Kurils side.

At five forty they came to the last turn. The lighthouse was beyond it, three hundred meters ahead, over a low ridge.

Sasaki stopped the car.

She switched off the headlights. But not the engine—she left it on idle—so all electrics would work, and so it could be killed instantly.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"Five more minutes."

"Yes."

Yukio took from the inside pocket of his coat the elastic band in which he carried the second magazine, and slipped it into the right pocket of his trousers—easily reachable, as Kenji had promised. The main magazine was in the holster. He checked the safety—on.

Sasaki kept both hands on the wheel. Did not move.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"Thank you for taking me."

Yukio was silent.

"Not for the trip," said Sasaki. "For everything."

Yukio turned to her. He looked not into her eyes—but at the spot under her right eye, at the mark where she used to put a cosmetic dot when she did not have one—that is, at a neutral place on her face she knew—and said:

"You are not 'taken,' Sasaki-san. You are—a partner."

Sasaki nodded. Once.

Then she opened the glove compartment. She pulled out a small black flashlight—tactical, narrow beam, battery for nine hours. She set it between the seats. Pulled out a second—the same—set it there too.

"One for you, one for me."

"Yes."

"We go in together," said Sasaki. "We come out together."

"Yes."

Yukio nodded. He took from the breast pocket a small card—a slip with the Erimo fire station's phone number and one number of Kenji's—and set it on the dashboard, under the sun visor. If something happened to him, Sasaki-san would know what to dial.

Sasaki did not say anything. But noticed.

She pulled from the inner pocket of her jacket a thin strip of paper and set it under the same visor, on the right side. On the paper—in an even hand: *"Sasaki Nao, Niigata, Minami-Shiomi 3-14-2, apt. 306, +81 25 2XX XXXX. Key at the downstairs neighbor's, Tanaba-san."*

Yukio nodded.

Then she pulled from the same pocket a small bundle—of soft paper, the size of a child's fist—and set it on the dashboard next to the slip. She did not explain. Yukio did not ask. He knew: the same "one thing" she had spoken of in his kitchen two days ago. Later. If they came back. If not—he would find it himself.

"All right," said Sasaki. "Let's go."

She turned the key. Turned the headlights to low. Put it into gear.

The car rolled to the last turn.

Above Cape Erimo the sky was already gray. Gray with that thin pink at the very eastern edge—the color of blood dissolved in water—which Yukio had once seen on a Kuroshio children's excursion steamer at seven, and had thought it was not a color but a mistake of the sky.

He held the holster with his right hand—the sleeve did not press on it—and thought of one second, in which he would say to someone at the lighthouse *you*.

Sasaki parked the car behind a low ridge, in a blind zone from the sea. She killed the engine.

The wind came into the car from below, through the crack of the door. It was loud.

Sasaki looked at him once. She did not speak.

Yukio nodded.

They opened the doors at the same time.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Room—Michiko, 2003

"Time."

The Abe Clinic stood on the corner of Higashi-Sanchōme in Niigata—a small private general-practice clinic on the ground floor of a five-story residential building from the sixties. Three examination rooms, one reception, one pharmacy behind double doors.

Tuesday, October, two thousand and three. Autumn came early that year.

Michiko opened the pharmacy at seven ten. The key on a soft leather cord under her uniform white blouse. Abe-sensei had entrusted her with this key since April. No one else on the junior staff had such a key.

Checked the expense log. Locked the door. The lock clicked.

At eight forty-three Abe-sensei came out of the first examination room into the corridor.

"Michiko-kun. You have a guest."

"Who."

"He didn't say. Says he's known you a long time. In the waiting room."

Michiko looked at the appointment log. Next patient—nine fifteen. Thirty minutes.

She took off her coat, straightened the collar of her blouse, went out to the waiting room.



A man in a gray suit sat by the window. Forty-one years old—she could tell by the hair: short, dark, with the first threads of gray at the temples. A worn face. Thin lips. Long fingers rested on his knees, backs up.

She recognized the voice before the face.

"Michiko-san."

"Yoshida-sensei."

He placed a copy of the Coastal Herald of Niigata on the low table. Did not move it—only placed it.

She sat opposite.

"Time," he said.

"I am ready."

The words came evenly. She had not prepared them. They had waited inside her since the autumn when she was seven years old, when Jindai-en was her home.

Yoshida nodded. Looked at her calmly.

"I need the key to the pharmacy," he said. "Once a quarter. Propofol. Two twenty-milliliter ampoules. Not from the batch used to write off invasive sedatives. You'll understand which ones to take."

"I'll understand."

"I'll come myself. Or a person I send. You'll know them by one word."

"Which."

"They'll say Memuro."

"Yes."

Yoshida held the pause.

"And one name," he said. "When they ask you, you'll say Ayano."

Michiko looked at her hands.

"Ayano."

He repeated the name as if placing it in her palm—and she took it.

Yoshida stood. Straightened his jacket with two motions along the edges, from bottom to top—and picked up a small brown bag from the floor. Michiko had not seen it when she came in.

"Goodbye," he said. Did not add a name.

"Goodbye, Yoshida-sensei."

The clinic door clicked shut behind him. Through the glass of the waiting room she saw his back—gray suit in a thin rain—and how he opened a small black umbrella, and how he disappeared around the corner of Higashi-Sanchōme toward the bus stop on Funagaya.

Michiko sat for another minute.



Then she stood. Returned to the pharmacy. Opened the lock. Took the inventory log from the shelf.

"Propofol—20 ml, ampoule." Remaining today—forty ampoules. Written off in October—three. Each with a batch number, with the clinic's internal series number. She ran her finger down the column of numbers. Reached the ninth from the bottom: the batch from the second-to-last restocking, clinic number three hundred forty-five, series V. Ampoules from this batch were written off irregularly. Last write-off—September. Before that—July. Before that—May.

These were the ampoules whose write-off troubled no one.

She closed the log. Locked the pharmacy.

At nine forty-seven she took a spare badge from the lower drawer of her desk—the one that had been lying in a plastic sleeve since April, made at her request at the workshop across the road—and swapped the badge on her chest.

On the new badge, in white kanji on dark blue plastic, was one name.

Ayano.

No one at the clinic noticed.

Michiko walked to reception, took the card for the next appointment—a woman of forty-three, elevated blood pressure—and called the patient in her usual tone, the same voice with which she had called patients three years running.

The voice did not change either.

Only on the badge under her throat was a different name now, and the clinic did not notice, and Niigata did not notice—and



Michiko, from this morning on, no longer wore her own.



CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Lighthouse

"Not now."

They arrived ten minutes before dawn.

The last five kilometers of road to the cape ran along a narrow asphalt switchback that held the edge of the cliff on the seaward side and went up and down without dividing lines. Sasaki drove slowly—forty-two kilometers per hour—with the caution people in Hokkaido use when they know a road only from traffic-accident reports, not from their own driving. Kurosawa sat to the right. He looked through the side glass. The wind held the car with a short pressure from the side—steady, not in gusts. The speedometer showed twenty-two meters per second of wind. Higher it could not read.

Sasaki cut the headlights of the *Corolla* three hundred meters short of the lighthouse—on the brief straight where the road came out from behind the last outcrop of the cliff and spilled onto the plateau—and drove the rest of the way on running lights. The sky to the east was beginning to pull away from black—that slow transition that came early over Erimo—and the headlights no longer had a function.

The parking pad by the lighthouse was empty. Three concrete slabs, gravel, a metal post with a placard "*Erimo-misaki. Autonomous lighting since 2013.*" The post leaned slightly to the north. Beyond the post—the sea. Sasaki parked the car under the east wall of the keeper's cottage, on the side the wind could not reach.

The clock on the dashboard read five seventeen.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"I go first."

"No. Together."

She did not argue.

They got out of the car one at a time—Sasaki on the driver's side, Kurosawa on the passenger's. She held her door with a hand so it would not be torn out. Kurosawa stepped out—the wind took him from the sea side—and thought, briefly, that twenty-three meters per second could be held, but had to be held. He buttoned his coat to the top. Raised the collar.

"I'm behind you," Sasaki said quietly. "One minute."

Kurosawa nodded. Walked to the door of the cottage. Kept his back straight. Right hand on the holster. Did not look back.

—

Sasaki lingered by the car.

Thirty seconds. She closed the driver's door—pressed with her shoulder so the lock caught evenly—and kept her palm on the handle another half second. The wind held her down jacket from the side. She did not move.

In that second the phone in the inner pocket of her jacket vibrated once, short.

She took it out. One glance at the screen.

"Pension registry gave a match. Yoshida Hiro 1962, director of Jindai-en Otaru 1998–2019. Cleaner Yasuko-san, 78, alive. It's him."

Kenji. Time—five eighteen. He had worked through the night, she knew.

Sasaki stood with the phone in her hand. Three seconds. Inside those three seconds two things held in her. One: catch up to Kurosawa—he was still fifteen meters from the door—and say it aloud. Two: not catch up.

She knew which she would choose.

Yoshida was not the kind who meets an investigator with a ready-made name. Yoshida was the kind who gives the name himself. If Kurosawa walked into the lighthouse with Yoshida's name on his lips, he would take Yoshida's moment from him—and Yoshida would do something else, something she could not predict. Sasaki was not ready to take Yoshida's moment from him. Not here. Not today.

She would play the name after.

Sasaki put the phone in the side pocket—not the inner one—so she could pull it out with one motion when it would be needed. Walked after Kurosawa.

The gravel creaked under her boots. The wind held its note from the sea side.

—

She caught up to him at the door.

They walked to the tower.

The Erimo-Misaki lighthouse, rebuilt in the fifties after the typhoon, stood at the very edge of the plateau—a round stone tower forty meters high, with rotating optics at the top and a gray concrete base at the bottom. Last painted in two thousand. The paint had come off in patches on the sea side. North of the tower stood the former keeper's cottage—a squat building with two windows, faced with gray stone, roofed with sheet copper that had darkened to black.

The cottage door—metal—was not locked.

Kurosawa saw this from twenty meters out. The spring of the upper lock was set half a turn, the way doors are set by people who know guests are being waited for inside. He did not tell Sasaki. She did not tell him either.

They approached from different sides. Sasaki raised her hand to the holster—and did not draw. Kurosawa gave her a sign with his palm turned down: *not yet*. She nodded.

He opened the door with his shoulder.

The wind came in ahead of him. Went through the entry hall, knocked a small tin can off the shelf on the left—it struck the concrete and rolled—and quieted somewhere in the depth of the

two rooms. Kurosawa stepped in after it.

He did not use his flashlight. Five minutes before dawn the entry hall was already gray enough to see the walls. The shelf on the left, empty. The clothes hook on the right, empty. Further—two doorways. The right led to the first room. The left—to a corridor to the second.

Sasaki came in after him.

"I take the right." Quietly. "You the left."

He did not argue. It was correct—he had the side on which a promise was being awaited.

The first room was empty.

He saw it from the threshold. Bare concrete walls, plank floor, one curtained window on the sea side, an old tin heater in the corner, disconnected since twenty-thirteen. On the floor—a thin layer of dust. In the dust—no trace. No one had entered this room in the last several weeks.

He closed the door.

From the corridor Sasaki said nothing. That meant: she had nothing yet either.

He went down the corridor to the second room. It was at the far end—around a turn to the left, under the wall that gave on the sea. The door was open a hand's breadth. He pushed it with the tips of his fingers. The door yielded evenly, without a creak.

Inside a lamp was burning.

One. A small desk lamp on a low concrete pillar by the far wall. The cord ran into the wall to a socket at shoulder height. The lamp shone toward the desk—an old low wooden desk, worn to

gray—and on the desk something lay.

Kurosawa stepped into the room.

It was clavicles.

Six.

They lay in a half-circle, with the convex side toward him—with that verified regularity of intervals with which things are arranged by people who have practiced arrangement for a long time. Each small, a child's. Each with a thin crack through the center, old, calcified. Each in its place—at a slight angle to its neighbor—so that the whole composition resembled an opened fan, or an unclosed ring, or an arc that waits to be closed.

He stood in the doorway. Did not step further in.

He was counting.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five. Six.

There had been nine columns on Erimo. In the eighth—the one he had taken last July—there had been one. It now lay in the department safe with the tag *Erimo-8*. He had not brought it. These six—not from Erimo. These six—from Memuro. Three earlier ones. Three more from those he did not know—that had not yet risen onto the map—that the Doll Maker had kept for himself longer.

He looked. Very quietly. Very long.

Then he raised his eyes to the wall behind the desk.

On the wall was one phrase. Not a phrase—one word. Written in a plain gray pencil, soft. Size—of a palm. Slight rightward slant. The strokes confident—not fast, not slow—with that barely perceptible pressure at the ends of each stroke that people use who have known this kanji from childhood and never stopped drawing it.

美佐子

He did not know how to read it. The first kanji—*"beauty"*—that he recognized. The second—*"assistant,"* or *"from the side"*—he was not sure in which reading. The third—*"child."* But their combination did not give him a word. Surname or name—he did not know.

He looked at the wall.

Behind him, from the corridor, Sasaki came up. Stopped by the jamb. Did not enter the room.

"Sir."

"Yes."

"On the desk—six."

"Yes."

She did not say *Erimo-8 in the safe, seven together*. He knew she had thought it.

Kurosawa turned back to the desk. Came two steps closer. Did not touch. Just looked at them from above. The arrangement—the intervals—the corners. The smallest clavicle was on the left, with the convex side turned toward the north window. The next in size—to its right, with the convex side turned the same way. And further—by size—to the largest.

He calculated to himself: children, from four to nine years old. Not older.

He knew that Endo, when she reached these bones, would sign exactly that. He knew this not because he knew the bone—he knew it because he knew Endo. She went around clavicles in a spiral, from the convex side—he had seen her do it in Obihiro in

twenty-five—and she was silent for half a minute before writing down the year. Here she would be silent longer. Here there were six.

"Memuro was four," he said quietly. "Erimo-8 was thirteen. These six are from other years. We'll need to cross-check with the Hokkaido missing-persons registry between ninety-eight and ten."

"Yes."

"Endo will say in a week."

"She will."

Kurosawa raised his hand. Did not touch the clavicles. Ran his fingers through the air above them, ten centimeters up—the way one runs a hand over writing one does not want to smear. Then lowered his hand.

He turned back to the wall. He looked at 美佐子 longer than he had looked at the bones.

Outside the window it was beginning to grow light. The sky over the sea was slowly pulling away from black to blue—that slow transition Erimo makes early, because the sun rises here from the sea with nothing between. The two terns he had seen on the pier last July were now sitting on the north sill—not the same ones, of course, but their descendants, or their neighbors—and looked at the glass sideways, with that short, focused look with which gull-birds evaluate whether you have something for them in your coat.

Kurosawa saw this and did not remember it.

Sasaki took a step back from the door. Drew the phone from her inner pocket. Kurosawa saw this with his side vision and did not turn.

She did not look at the screen for a long time.

Then, quietly, she said:

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"There's an SMS. Kenji. Just sent."

Kurosawa did not turn from the wall.

He knew she had received it out there—by the car, in that minute when he went in first. He knew this by the short pause before "There's." He knew she could have spoken sooner—before he entered—and had not spoken.

"Not now," he said.

"Yes."

She put the phone back in her pocket. Did not press. He knew Sasaki never pressed—and that when she pressed, she pressed only when she thought it necessary—this was one of those constants he had carried for her in his head since January of two thousand, when she came into the department.

He looked at 美佐子 one more second.

Then dropped his eyes to the desk. The clavicles lay as they had lain.

Outside the walls of the lighthouse the wind held its note. Did not tear, did not release. Twenty-three meters per second from the southwest—the same one that had held the pier.

Kurosawa turned to her.

"Is there a door in the back wall?"

"Yes, sir. Another room. The door is closed. Not locked—I checked the handle, did not enter."

"He is here."

"Yes."

Kurosawa nodded.

He stood one more second in front of the desk. Then unbuttoned the top button of his coat, took from the inner pocket the small folded sheet of paper—the one from Erimo cape, signed with one word *Kurosawa*—and placed it on the desk beside the clavicles. Not on them. Beside.

He did not explain to Sasaki why.

She did not ask.

He turned toward the back wall. The door to that room was in the right corner behind the desk—old, wooden, with a brass handle.

Behind it—a step.

Not fast. Not quiet. That even step with which people walk when they know you are waiting.

The lamp on the pillar kept burning evenly.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Conversation

"I preserved him."

The door to the back room opened from within.

Not sharply, not slowly. With the motion of someone who has been holding the handle for a while, deciding when. Kurosawa heard the handle slip in its socket, the bolt come out of the mortise, the hinges creak once on the upper axis. Three sounds. Each separately.

A man stood in the opening.

Thin. Not tall—one meter seventy, thereabouts. A shaved head—not smoothly shaved, but slightly grown back, with that gray stubble sheen left by scissors, not by a razor. A worn face, without sharp features—with the kind of face that laid poorly in the memory, that a man passed with in a crowd and no one turned to look after.

Dark eyes, deep, clear. Thin lips. Long fingers. On the right index finger—a small old scar under the thin skin, half a centimeter long—the kind of scar left by wood shavings during carving, when a child does not yet know how to hold a knife.

Clothing—a gray wool coat below mid-thigh, buttoned to the top, beneath it a dark gray suit jacket, and a dark sweater with a high neck. The coat was dry—not recently dried, but long dry—with that faded gray into which good English wool passes after fifteen years of wearing without cleaning. Nothing in the right hand. In the left—a small gray umbrella tube, the length of a forearm—the kind sold in stationery shops in Otaru in the eighties.

He was not holding a weapon.

Kurosawa saw this before he began to look—because he began by looking at the hands.

He was sixty-six years old. He looked older. He read as seventy-two, as a ribbon from a monastery, as a long cellarer who had kept silent more than he had spoken.

Kurosawa knew this about him now. Five minutes ago—had not known. Now knew.

Yoshida stepped over the threshold of the back room into the second. One step. Did not hurry. Closed the door behind him with his elbow—did not push it to the click, only closed it.

He stopped at a distance of three meters from the desk.

Sasaki stood half a step behind and to the left of Kurosawa. Kurosawa heard her coat brush against the doorframe when she shifted her weight. Her right hand rested on her holster. He knew this without looking.

He gave her the sign with his palm—the same one as at the entrance: *not yet*.

She did not take her hand off the holster. Simply waited.

Yoshida looked at Kurosawa.

"Kurosawa-san," he said quietly. "Thank you for coming."

The voice was as Toshi had described. Quiet, warm, restrained. Did not lift, did not stay silent long. That voice teachers use to set a class in place—not because they know how to speak loudly, but because they have never needed to.

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

He looked at him for a long time. He looked the way investigators look who have studied a biography by paper for many months and now for the first time see the face—and at the same time the way people look who have long carried an empty form inside them, and in this second someone puts content into it. Two things happened together. He did not separate them.

He had a first surmise about this face—the one that would be needed later, in Jindai-en—but now he did not have it, and did not have how it would turn out. Now he had before him a man in a gray coat. Now he had only what he stood with.

Then he did something he had not done in any interview across twenty-three years of service. He did not take out a notebook. He did not turn on a recorder—there was one running in his chest pocket from the first minute he entered the entry hall, and that recorder captured the conversation evenly—but Kurosawa was not thinking about it in this second. He made no gesture of fixation. He held his hands along his body. He looked. He knew—and knew evenly—that this would be the only conversation, and that the

fixation of it would be himself.

"You killed him," he said.

It came before he had time to think from what place in himself he was saying it. He had not meant to open with this. He opened.

Yoshida looked at him as if a cup had been passed to him with the wrong tea poured in.

"Whom," he said.

"Ren."

Pause. In it the wind outside the walls held its note.

Yoshida blinked once—slowly—and lowered his chin. Did not object with his voice. Objected with the motion.

"No," he said. "I did not kill."

Pause.

"I preserved him."

He said it evenly. Without emphasis. The way people speak who know a phrase will pull the whole conversation after it, and do not want to spoil it by pressure.

Kurosawa did not move. He felt behind him Sasaki breathing shallowly—with the rhythm people breathe with when they are holding something at gunpoint that they do not yet intend to shoot.

"You told my mother," Kurosawa said, "that he was dead."

Yoshida lifted his gaze slowly. There was neither surprise nor reproach in it. He looked at Kurosawa the way old Japanese schoolteachers looked at a teenager who had said something aloud that did not fit the timeline—kindly—with that particular kind of kindness that never crossed into condescension.

"Your mother," he said, "was dead before I met him."

Kurosawa did not object.

He had known this before he said the first phrase. His mother had died in childbirth in seventy-seven. He had known it since he was four, from a photograph in the family album, from his father's account, who would drink and start talking about it one or two times a year—from his father's voice, which never added anything new, and from Ren's silence beside him when the father spoke. He knew this. He said the phrase for something else. He said it to see—and saw—that Yoshida would not confuse the chronology. Yoshida did not confuse it. That said something more about him than the next four minutes could have said.

In that same second he saw one more thing. Yoshida had said *before I met him*. Not *before he was born*. Not *before your birth*. He had said *I met him*—and into that phrase two things entered. First: a meeting had happened. Second: it had happened in a particular year, which Yoshida kept for himself as a meeting. Not as observation, not as contact. *A meeting*. That was a day Yoshida remembered and dated. That was a day Yoshida had carried across twenty-three years and placed before Kurosawa in the second room of the lighthouse on Erimo, in the morning.

Kurosawa did not know the date. He knew there would be one.

Kurosawa nodded once—small, barely perceptible.

He knew, in that same corner, that Yoshida had seen it. Yoshida saw everything Kurosawa showed, and saw a large share of what Kurosawa did not show. This came to him evenly—without satisfaction—the way it comes to people who for many years have listened to others without intending to interrupt.

"Where is he," said Kurosawa.

Yoshida held the pause.

He did not look at the wall with the word 美佐子. He did not look at the clavicles on the desk. He did not look at the sheet of paper "Kurosawa" that Kurosawa had put there a minute ago. He looked only at Kurosawa—directly—with the calm of a man who had prepared this second for twenty-three years for a person, and that person had finally arrived.

"You will find," he said.

Pause.

"If you have the strength after today."

Kurosawa did not understand at once.

He felt—with that quiet corner that knew about the future half a second before the rest of him learned it—that Yoshida had said not "if you stay in uniform," not "if you do not stop," not "if you hold up," but *if you have the strength after today*. The word *today* carried weight. The word *today* meant a day in which something would happen. The word *today* meant it had already happened in plans—Yoshida was only sharing what was known to him.

Kurosawa heard it. He did not show he had heard.

Kurosawa looked at him one more second. He felt—as a man feels the pressure of air before a storm—that Yoshida had said about *today* something that had not been planned to be said. In Yoshida something ran briefly for that half second—a small inward turn of the fists—and passed.

"You came here without a weapon," he said.

"Yes."

"You came without escort."

"Yes."

"You came to leave."

Yoshida smiled for the first time in the conversation. The smile was brief—corners of the mouth lifted by two millimeters—and faded. In the eyes it held longer.

"Kurosawa-san," he said, "I came for you to see me. You see me. That is all I had to do here."

"You will tell me one more thing."

"I will."

Kurosawa waited.

Yoshida looked at him one more second.

"The name on the wall," he said, "you can leave as it is. You are not reading it yet. You will read it later."

He looked briefly at the word 美佐子 for the first time—only briefly—and turned his eyes back to Kurosawa.

"It is not a trap for you," he said. "It is a record. One of mine."

"For whom."

"For a person who will no longer hear."

Kurosawa was silent.

"One clavicle in your department's safe," Yoshida said. "Six here. Two more in places I will not lead you to. Nine in all. You will return them to the families. That will be good."

Pause.

"Yamagata," he said. "The last two. Ninety-eight and ninety-three. I do not give surnames. You will get them from the archive. The

families are alive—both fathers still alive—you will find them in two weeks. Give them what you no longer need to hold."

Kurosawa did not understand at once why Yoshida was saying this.

He understood half a second later. Yoshida was saying it because he no longer needed to hold it. He was handing it over the way one hands papers from one pair of hands to another when clearing a drawer.

"You will say this to a court," Kurosawa repeated.

"I will not say this to a court."

"Why."

Yoshida lowered his gaze.

"Because there will be no court."

He did not say it with defiance. He said it the way a doctor tells a patient the analysis shows something that will not be good—evenly—with that professional warmth in which there is no self-pity.

Kurosawa looked at him for a long time.

"You came to say goodbye," he said quietly.

"No."

Yoshida raised his eyes. There was no defiance in them. There was that brief shine that sometimes appears in people who have long lived with an unsaid thing inside them and in this second speak it, not thinking whether the listener will understand.

"I will say goodbye to him," he said.

Pause.

"You will see him," he added. "That is my promise. It is not for me to keep—for you. You will come and see him. I will not be with you at that. That is important. You will come alone. He is your brother. Not mine."

Kurosawa was silent.

He was not thinking. He was holding his body in the position it had stood in—heels level, weight slightly shifted onto the left foot, hands along his sides—and waited for the second to pass in which one word wanted to be said. The second passed. The word he did not say.

Kurosawa did not ask with whom. He knew. He had known from the minute Yoshida had said *I preserved him*.

Outside the walls of the lighthouse the wind held its note. In the small interval between him and Yoshida—across the desk with six clavicles—two people who did not move—three things stood. The word 美佐子 behind Yoshida's back. The sheet of paper "Kurosawa" under his right hand. The clavicles laid out in a half-circle.

Kurosawa looked at him half a second more. Then—because in this second it became important to him—he asked:

"Misako."

Yoshida raised his eyes.

It was the first time in the conversation Yoshida changed expression. Not in voice—in face. The corners of his eyes dropped by half a millimeter. In his right hand, in the fingers that held the gray tube—for half a second—a tremor appeared, small, the tremor with which one holds an object one has held for twenty-three years running and has forgotten one is holding.

The tremor passed.

"You remember this name," Yoshida said quietly. "That is good."

"I do not remember it. I read it from your wall."

"You read it."

Yoshida looked at the word behind him—a longer look than the brief nimble check before—and turned back to Kurosawa.

"Misako," he repeated. "You will remember it. Not today. Later. You will hold it in you the way I held it. Not so it will be easier for you. So it will be honest."

Kurosawa was silent.

Yoshida held the pause.

"I am arresting you," Kurosawa said.

"Not today, Kurosawa-san."

"Today."

"No."

Pause.

"You think you can walk out of here now," said Kurosawa. "Because I will not shoot you. You are right. I will not shoot you. But I will not let you out of here."

Yoshida nodded—a small nod, with the respect one shows to a reasonable position one does not intend to agree with.

"Kurosawa-san," he said. "You will not let me out—that is true. But I will leave."

"How."

Yoshida held the pause.

He looked at Sasaki for the first time.

Looked at her for half a second. No longer. In that half second he weighed something—weighed it in himself the way one weighs a precious thing when it must be placed in a pocket not one's own for a few hours. Then he turned his gaze back to Kurosawa.

"I am sorry," he said. "For this."

Kurosawa did not understand at once what for.

He understood a second and a half later—through those second and a half when he understood that Yoshida had shifted his weight from his right foot to his left—that his left foot had come half a centimeter closer to the back door—that with his right hand he had let go of the small gray tube, holding it with only two fingers—and that this meant that the tube in the next minute would no longer be needed by him.

Yoshida looked at Sasaki for one more brief moment.

"Sasaki-san," he said. Quietly. "Not after yourself."

Kurosawa did not manage to understand what that referred to.

He opened his mouth to say "stop."

He did not manage.

Yoshida took one quiet step back—unhurried—toward the back door. A second. On the third Kurosawa moved after him.

Sasaki moved in the same second—from the other side of the desk—her right hand already drawing the pistol.

Yoshida disappeared, back first, into the back room. The door closed behind him.

Outside the walls of the lighthouse the wind held its note at twenty-three meters per second from the southwest, and on that note—embedded in it—half a second before Kurosawa reached the

back door—another sound rang out.

Short. Metallic. Quiet.

A click.

Kurosawa heard it.

He knew what it was.

He had time to think one thing—one—brief—not about
Yoshida.

Sasaki.

He turned his head.

The Explosion

A second of inattention.

The back door exploded.

Not all of it. Only the lower half—the one where an oil lantern from old fishing gear had stood, with a brass reservoir and a cotton wick, which Yoshida had set an hour before their arrival with a small clockwork mechanism. The mechanism was simple—of the kind sold in Sapporo in radio-parts shops until the nineties. It had been set without an igniter. The igniter was a valve that closed the moment the door opened a second time—that is, the moment Yoshida stepped out.

Forensics would later find three components. A brass fragment of the reservoir, ten centimeters long, in the northeast corner of the room. A wooden splinter from the inner planking of the door, with thin gray paint, in the crack between the desk and the wall. A thin steel band from the housing of the clockwork mechanism—four centimeters long—lodged in the soft fibers of Sasaki's coat, in the left shoulder blade, from the back. It was that shard. Kurosawa would later hold it in a plastic bag on his desk in the department for three days, and would not place it in the file until the third.

Then, in the second of the explosion, he did not know this.

The valve closed. The wick took. The brass reservoir went on the side.

Half a second—for heating. Half a second—for the rupture.

The door flew into the second room by its lower edge.

Shards came from two sources—from the lantern itself, brass and glass—and from the wooden plank of the lower half of the door, splintered into slivers—and from the metal facing, hurled diagonally to the northeast corner of the room. Speed—forty to eighty meters per second, depending on mass. Kurosawa did not know that then. He read it in the forensic's protocol two weeks later—read it—and laid the protocol on the corner of the desk—and picked it up again—and laid it down again. Many times.

In that second he knew something else.

He knew he had turned to Sasaki.

He knew that his eyes had made it to her—to her face, to her right hand, to the pistol in that hand, to her left shoulder—and had also made it to a small detail behind her: the word 美佐子 on the wall, lit by the lamp on the pillar.

The word was where it was. Three kanji. Plain gray pencil.

He saw it—and his eyes lingered on it—and into that lingering entered—before he had realized he was lingering—a small questioning sound in his head: *"beauty-assistant-child"*?

He did not have the word. He had only three kanji.

He held his eyes on them half a second.

In that half second Sasaki moved.

He did not see her move. He saw only the end of her motion—a body in a black coat passing through the space between him and the wall with the writing. Her left shoulder was lower—she had tilted her torso—and her right hand with the pistol was going up—not to shoot, but for balance. Her head was turned toward him. She was looking at him.

The shard passed through her left shoulder blade.

Kurosawa did not see it. He felt the air push against his own left shoulder—short, sharp, with a pressure he knew from the range—and understood that something had pierced what stood in front of him. He fell to his right knee—not by will, but because the knee gave way—and with his hand in his coat, in the inner pocket, he grabbed to the left—and did not find—and understood he was searching not his own pocket.

He was searching for Sasaki.

He found her on the floor.

She had fallen face down—with the short cornering motion with which people fall whose body has just lost its weight along with one main nerve signal. Her pistol had flown from her right hand half a meter forward. Her left arm remained under her, twisted. Her left cheek on the concrete—not on tatami; there was no tatami here—only concrete, covered with a thin layer of dust and shards.

Kurosawa turned her onto her back.

He did this with hands that did not tremble. He understood that later. Then he was not thinking about his hands. He made the motions his hands made—and his hands knew—made them the way they would not have made them if he had thought.

He put his left palm under the back of her head. With his right he unbuttoned the top button of her coat. The second. The third. Opened the coat. Under the coat was a dark blue uniform jacket. Holster on the right side. Pistol—not in the holster. The pistol lay on the concrete beyond the edge of his right field of vision. He left it there. The pistol was not needed. In that second he did not need any object other than the one he was holding.

On the jacket—on the chest at the left—a dark wet patch, from which air was coming out. Not blood. Air. He heard it.

Pneumothorax.

"Sasaki," he said.

She opened her eyes.

Not at once. The pause was—a second—maybe two. Then she opened them. Looked at him. Calmly.

"Sir."

"Do not move."

"I am not moving."

It seemed to him she smiled—faintly—at the corners—not for him. For something between them.

He drew the phone from his chest pocket. Held it in one hand. With the other he held her head. With the fingers not holding the phone he unbuttoned one more button of her jacket—to find the edges of the wound. Found them. The shard had passed obliquely—entered the left upper part of the chest cavity, in the eighth intercostal space from the back, exited the front wall—with the small exit that punched skin like a stiletto—and lodged somewhere on the concrete three meters behind. Kurosawa did not look for it. That was for forensics.

"Sasaki-san," he said. "Breathe slowly."

"Yes."

He dialed 110. Then 119. Then—with the same finger that had dialed—he took a handkerchief from his inner pocket. It was white, linen, with a monogram *K.Y.* in the lower corner—a gift from Ogawa's wife for New Year twenty-five, three years ago. He pressed

the handkerchief to the exit hole of the wound on her chest. Did not seal it tight. Left one edge lifted—as they showed on the courses—so that air could come out but not go in.

He held it.

Behind the shattered back door he heard a thin metallic rustle. It was the sound of a rope going through an iron ring on the outer wall of the lighthouse on the sea side. Yoshida was descending. Beyond the wall, below—where the cliff went south to the water—there stood a boat. Kurosawa knew this because he ought to know it, and because it was the only thing that made sense. He did not stand up to check.

The rope creaked another twenty seconds.

Then—quietly, very quietly—from below, from beneath the cliff—a short sound of an engine. Small outboard. Eight-horsepower, ten. It started on the first pull. Stalled. Started again. Ran evenly. The sound went south—to open water—to that side of the sea Erimo always looks at.

Kurosawa later knew that the boat was small—metal, a Yamaha, six meters—and that it did not go far: it kept to the cliffs, rounded the cape from the west, and in a little over an hour put in at one of the fishing coves at the foot of the Hidaka, from which a footpath led up into the mountains—to Genshō-an. Beyond that the way was overland. Kurosawa knew this two hours later from a coast-guard radio broadcast he listened to at the end of the third half-hour in the entry hall with a walkie-talkie in his left hand and a towel one of the paramedics had thrown him onto his thigh in his right. Then he knew only that the engine was going south along the shore. That was enough. He understood.

In a minute the engine could no longer be heard.

Kurosawa did not turn toward it.

He held the handkerchief on Sasaki's wound and looked into her eyes.

She was breathing.

The inhale was short and high. The exhale was longer. The right side of her chest rose half a centimeter—no more. The left did not rise at all. Kurosawa saw this by the collar of her jacket—by the way the fabric moved above the right clavicle and did not move above the left.

Her lips grew paler with each inhale. He knew this too. He did not move the handkerchief.

Outside the walls of the lighthouse the wind held its note. Twenty-three meters per second from the southwest.

In the back room, behind the shattered door, the wick of the oil lamp burned down. It had another ten seconds. Then nobody's.

On the wall above the desk, lit by the lamp on the concrete pillar, stood the word 美佐子—three kanji, plain gray pencil.

The word had gone nowhere.

Kurosawa would return to it later. He knew.

He knew one more thing—with that same quiet corner into which things folded before he had time to think them through. He knew what he would be given for this at the department. Tanaka Ryosuke would hear him out under protocol. The internal investigation would last thirty days—after the death of an officer—and Kurosawa would give testimony three times—twice orally, once in writing. He knew what would be said to him, and what would not be said. He knew that in part of the testimony he would keep silent—and that this silence would be entered into the



"conclusion regarding further service" line. He knew.

He set it aside.

Now he was holding a palm.



CHAPTER NINETEEN

Sasaki

Six breaths.

He held the handkerchief.

With the right palm—pressed to the exit of the wound—not by pressure, by weight. With the left—he held the back of her head. The fingers of his left hand found the short hair at the base of her neck that had always been a little longer for her than at the ears—because she cut it herself—because she said once that going to a hairdresser was an hour spent on foolishness for her.

He knew this about her. Many things about her he knew.

He knew that she drank her coffee without sugar. Knew that in winter the left corner of her mouth grew dry and she kept a small tube of medical Vaseline in her desk. Knew she kept a white towel in

the glove box of the car for him. Knew she had a sister in Niigata. Knew she wrote her a letter by hand once every two weeks, on light paper—from the stock people buy in Otaru at the shop on Denuki Boulevard. Knew she fired from the right—short—with that short bracing of the shoulder with which instructors fire, not cadets.

He was leaning on these now. In order.

She was looking into his eyes.

One.

The inhale was shallow, short—with that whistle in the upper part a lung makes when one air goes out and a different one returns. The right lung was working. The left—no. He heard it. He knew how many air volumes she had left. He was not counting them in metric units. He was counting them in breaths.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I will tell you."

"I know. Do not hurry."

"I must."

He held her head level. He knew this too—that the head had to be held level—that it must not be lifted, must not be lowered—because each shift of a degree shifted the lung, shifted the middle. He held it.

Two.

She held the pause. He saw by her throat—by the thin movement of skin above the right clavicle—how she gathered air. She was not gathering to breathe. She was gathering to speak.

"Kurosawa-san. Yoshida. Jindai-en. Yasuko-san. Kenji just sent."

One sentence. Delivered evenly—with the quiet professional tempo with which Sasaki once read long lists at briefings—with a half-second pause between each name, in which she took a small inhale and went on. Her voice did not tremble. She looked into his eyes as she spoke.

"I know," he said. "Hold on."

He said it evenly. He said "I know" because he had taken all five words into himself. He said "hold on" because that was all one could say to a senior—to a junior, or a junior to a senior, when between them lay what lay between them.

He held the handkerchief.

Three.

Kurosawa heard it. He knew this was the third. He knew how many were left.

He did not ask her how she knew. He knew this had been in the SMS Kenji had sent her by the car—half an hour before this minute—that she had kept in the side pocket of her jacket without drawing it out through the whole conversation in the second room. Kenji's pension registry. Yoshida Hiro, sixty-two. Director of Jindai-en, ninety-eight to nineteen. Cleaner Yasuko-san, seventy-eight, alive. That was what Sasaki had not managed to show him before the door exploded. That was what she had held inside her for thirty minutes.

That was what she had just given him.

She blinked. For the first time since opening her eyes.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I'm sorry."

"No."

He said it faster than he had time to think. It came from the same place *you killed him* had come from—when he had entered the second room. He did not have time to track these places in himself. He simply spoke.

"No," he repeated. "Not I'm sorry."

She did not object.

Four.

He felt—under his palm, under the handkerchief—that the rhythm of her breathing had begun to change. The inhale was becoming half a second shorter. The exhale—half a second longer. This was the normal course in pneumothorax. This was what the instructor had shown on the course. It meant the right lung was not enough. It meant the mediastinum had begun to shift.

He knew that with this he could do a countershift puncture with a needle in the second intercostal space along the midclavicular line. He knew how to do it. He had a needle—thick—in the medical kit of the car. He knew he needed forty seconds to run to the car.

He did not run.

This decision came not as a decision. It came as a fact. He knew that *110* was already on its way—twenty minutes—and *119* was already on its way—twenty minutes—and that the puncture, if he went for the needle, would be made in ninety seconds—and would be made on a mediastinum that had already taken a place not its own—and would not return.

He did not run.

He held.

She saw this in his eyes.

Her eyes did not reproach him. In that second they said to him: *right*. She had the right to say it. He had the right to hear her.

They did not hear anything else.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"Hold on."

"I'm holding."

He said this for her. He said it the way a senior says to a junior when something is hard—not adding how exactly one holds. One holds with what one has.

Five.

She smiled.

The smile was brief—corners—not for him, and not for her—for something between—the same something she had returned the smiles from the department to over the last three years—when Ogawa joked quietly, when Kenji complained about the processor, when Kurosawa looked at her longer than he needed to, when he took from her hand the bento she had put on to warm for him, because she knew—because she knew many things.

"Tell Nao."

It came quietly. She said it with the air that was left.

"I will."

"Only tell."

He nodded.

She breathed.

Six.

The last inhale was the same as the fifth. It did not announce itself. It entered and did not come out to the end. It began in the right part and stopped in the middle—with the small hold with which a clock chain holds when the spring is no longer giving it anything.

She did not finish the word.

Her fingers on her right hand, which lay along her body, made a thin motion—not a grasp, not a reach—a small finger motion with which a person closes an invisible tap.

Then did nothing.

Kurosawa looked into her eyes.

The eyes did not close. She had not had time. She saw him. He saw her.

Outside the walls of the lighthouse the wind held its note. Twenty-three meters per second from the southwest.

Kurosawa did not move for one minute.

Then—carefully, with both hands—he lowered the back of her head to the concrete. He placed under the back of her head his own coat folded in four—having taken it off in three motions, without looking around—and placed the coat exactly where it needed to lie. He straightened the collar of her jacket—the same one he had once straightened on Ogawa—and closed the lower button of her coat. One. He did not fasten it to the end. He did not have the right.

Then he sat on the concrete beside her.

Not on his heels. Not beside her at half a step. Simply—sat—on the concrete, fully. Back to the desk with six clavicles. Face to her face.

The handkerchief with the monogram *K.Y.* lay on her chest—damp—the same one Ogawa's wife had given him for New Year twenty-five.

He did nothing more.

Beyond the second door, in the entry hall, the wind held the tin can he had knocked to the floor when he entered. The can did not move. It lay on its side. Kurosawa had known this in the morning when he entered, and knew it now. It was the same can. One detail in the room in which nothing had changed in this time—except one.

In the back room the wick of the oil lamp burned down. It had another ten seconds. It had zero. It burned down. In those same ten seconds Kurosawa did not look at it. The wick went out without a witness.

The wall lamp on the pillar kept shining evenly.

On the wall above the desk stood the word 美佐子. Three kanji. Plain gray pencil.

Kurosawa sat.

Outside the door of the lighthouse the wind held its note.

110 was forty minutes out.

119 was forty minutes out.

The SAT unit from the Obihiro precinct—forty-five minutes—because they came from a base at Hidaka-West through the crossing near Samani, because on the direct road under the

Erimo ridge heavy transport from the Japan Sea side was not let through at night—and Kurosawa knew this from the twenty-three protocols, and knew it now.

He did not move for forty minutes.

He did not look at the watch. He did not look at her hand. He did not look at the word on the wall. He looked at her face—at that small area between the right temple and the edge of the hair—at the place where a fine pulse used to beat when she was concentrating—and where now nothing was beating.

He held his eyes there.

He knew—with that quiet corner in himself that knew about time before the rest of him—that in forty minutes the first SAT would come in from the entry hall; that he would have to rise; that he would have to unclasp his hands; that he would have to say three things—his surname, rank, and what was behind him. He knew these three things.

He would say them.

He did not move.

Beyond the wind—not far south of the lighthouse—the small outboard was going along the cliffs to one of the fishing coves of the Hidaka. Kurosawa did not think about it.

He thought about a few things. In an order not of his choosing.

He thought about the first morning Sasaki came into the department. It was January of two thousand. Ogawa was not yet senior inspector—he was a regular investigator on the second floor. Kurosawa himself still wore the dark blue tunic without a shoulder chevron—with the shoulder boards of *keibuho*—not full *keibu*. Sasaki came in a uniform blouse and gray skirt, from the lower floor,

with a paper folder in her left hand and a coffee cup in her right. The coffee was for Ogawa. Kurosawa had remembered it then, because he had thought—briefly—that she was not one of those who in the first week guessed who in this second most needed to be warmed.

He thought about the day she first went with him to a site alone. It was June of twenty-two. The clavicle from Memuro. He remembered her steps behind him—even—not fast, not slow—with the tempo people walk who are not afraid.

He thought about the evening when she put a bento on the corner of his desk and did not say anything. That had been many evenings. He could have named each one separately—and could not have—because they were different evenings with one silence.

He thought about Nao. In Niigata. About how he would enter her apartment in two days. About what he would say to her, and in what order. About how long he would be there. About whether she would cry at once or after a day. About whom she would call afterward—and about the fact that he would have to call Kenji first—and Nao from the door of home. This he now knew.

He thought about the fact that he would not tell her one thing. He would not tell her that Sasaki had jumped. He would say that the shard had gone through the room and there was nothing to be done. He would say it the way it would be said in the protocol. He knew Nao would take this. He knew Nao would take this because that was how Sasaki had taught her—earlier—by the same fine method with which she had taught him many things he had absorbed without noticing.

He thought about Ogawa. About how if Ogawa had been here, Ogawa would have looked at him and said *Kurosawa*—and would have added nothing—and Kurosawa would have heard everything

he needed to hear. Ogawa had not seen him for nine months now. Kurosawa began to feel the lack of his warm silence.

He took this away from himself at once. Not now. This would come later.

The wind over Erimo held its note.

Kurosawa sat on the concrete beside her.

He did not wipe the blood from the left corner of her mouth—a thin strip that had appeared on the fifth inhale—not because he could not, but because it was there, and to move it he had no right. It was hers. He left it.

Twenty minutes after her heart stopped, his right leg began to hurt—the one on which he sat on the concrete with the heel bent under him. He noticed the pain and forgot it.

Seven minutes later he felt his shoulders drop. There were no shoulders. There was a frame in which he sat. In the frame there still fit: the desk with the clavicles, the word on the wall, the lamp on the concrete pillar, the wind outside the walls, and Sasaki's body before him. Together five objects. Together one frame.

Ten minutes later he began to drip in the chest—not in the eyes—precisely in the chest—with that slow dripping motion of water dripping from the eaves at the end of March. He set that aside too.

At forty minutes the first steps from the entry hall came in. Two. Ambulance—paramedics—low rubber soles. Kurosawa heard. Did not turn.

He knew he would stand now.

He stood twenty seconds later.

The handkerchief with the monogram *K.Y.* remained on her chest. He did not take it.

The paramedics from Obihiro—two of them—came in with a radio and a stretcher. Kurosawa raised a hand. Palm down. They stopped. He gave his surname and rank, and stated the time breathing had stopped, and said that he had not moved the body. The younger paramedic nodded. The older knelt beside her. Kurosawa stepped back. Then one more step. He stood by the desk with the six clavicles and watched them do what they had to do.

Behind them, three SAT came in from the entry hall.

Kurosawa turned his head. Saw them. Gave a hand sign toward the back door. One of the SAT moved that way. Two remained in the first room.

That was all he said.

The word 美佐子 on the wall behind his back stood as it had stood.



CHAPTER TWENTY

The Funeral

"Yukio-san. Yuri said you are a good person."

The funeral hall stood in the east wing of *Ichikawa-sōsai-jō*, in the suburbs of Sapporo, past Nakanoshima Park. Kurosawa arrived forty minutes before the service began. He took from his pocket the *fusa-nenju*—a black rosary, bought yesterday at the shop near the Hodaiji temple, with two knots and one bead of bone. He had not held rosary beads since his father's funeral—and his fingers did not remember how to arrange them between thumb and index finger.

Beyond the glass facade of the hall lay a gray December afternoon. Snow was not falling—only the cold stood level—and the sign above the entrance (white on black, with the inscription "佐々木家告別式") reflected matte.

He entered.

In the entry hall were three staff in black with "受付" on their chests. He signed the book—hand steady, the name "黒澤 雪男" slow—and placed the *kōden* in a white envelope with a double black-and-white cord. Thirty thousand yen. He did not know if that was the right amount for a partner—there were no rules—and he placed what he placed.

He was handed a program of the service. One page. On it—the family name, place, time, name of the *sekiheku-sōryo* from Eshō-ji temple, Kita ward. In the lower corner—the *kaimyō*, five kanji:

清蓮綾心尼

He held the program between two fingers. Looked a long time.

Sei-Ren-Aya-Shin-Ni.

Pure lotus. Pattern of the heart. Nun.

"Aya"—from her name. "Shin"—from her line of work. "Ren"—the symbol of Buddhist mourning. Purity is chosen by the family. He knew there was no one in this family to choose purity; Sasaki's father had died six years ago, her older sister too, and the decision had been made by the *hōji*-abbess of Eshō-ji, with Nao entitled to one word.

He put the program in his chest pocket.

Walked into the hall.



The hall was white, with a high ceiling of undisturbed plaster board. At the far end—an altar. In the center—the *ihai* with the same *kaimyō*, carved on dark lacquered wood. Before the *ihai*—Sasaki's photograph. Not from the field. In the uniform she rarely wore. She was smiling—not with the smile he knew—not the working, thin,

short one—but a longer and softer smile, at the moment when someone had said something amusing off-camera. Kurosawa looked. Turned away.

Chrysanthemums stood around. White. Not one—forty, fifty, sixty. In a half-circle. A wall of flowers behind which the altar was as if behind a curtain.

On either side—rows of black chairs. People were already seated, quietly. Three of her former classmates from the academy. Chief Tanaka Ryosuke, in the first row on the left, with his wife. Endo, in a black coat, stood by a column. Kenji was in a black suit that clearly did not belong to him—with sleeves slightly too long—and stood by the exit like a man ready to flee.

Kurosawa nodded to Endo. She nodded back briefly.

He walked deeper in.

Nao sat in the first row on the right. Alone. Relatives on the mother's side were in Niigata and had not made it in time. She was in a black coat one size too large—old, probably her mother's—and in a black dress. Hair gathered in a low ponytail. Face quiet. In her hands—a photograph in a black frame. Not the one on the altar. Smaller. Worn at the corners. With a thin black ribbon across the upper left corner.

He studied it across two rows. Sasaki in it was in civilian clothes—a green windbreaker—standing on the pier of Otaru harbor with a fish in her hands. Summer. Before everything. Probably Nao had taken it herself.

Kurosawa sat across the aisle from Nao, two rows back. Did not go to her at once. Right so.



At two o'clock the priest came out through the side door. Small, thin, in a brown *kōromo* with a silk *kesa* over the left shoulder—and with a whistle-*rin*-cup in his hands. Walked slowly to the altar.

Sat. Placed the *rin* on a cushion.

Silence settled of itself.

He struck the *rin*.

A thin, long note went vertically.

Then he opened a small book and began reading *Han-nya Shin-gyō*—the Heart Sutra—in that special monotone voice which in Japan belongs neither to singing nor to speaking—and behind which Kurosawa repeated in himself three or four lines he had known since childhood from his mother.

Kan-jizai bosatsu, gyō jin han-nya haramita ji, shōken go on kai kū, do issai kuyaku.

He knew the words. He did not know the meaning. His mother had once explained, once: "*All things—form and emptiness—are one.*" He had not understood then. He did not understand now.

The whistle of the *rin* did not interrupt the reading.

The reading went for twenty-three minutes.



Then came the *shōkō*. The incense.

The participants approached the altar one by one. Family first.

Nao rose. She held the photograph with both hands, the way one holds a child—and walked to the altar slowly. Stood. Bowed before the *ibai*. Took from a small wooden bowl a pinch of dark powder, raised it to her forehead, sprinkled it into the metal *kōro*. A thin blue

thread of smoke rose. Nao repeated. Three times. Bowed.

Kurosawa looked at her back. It did not tremble. She was walking her own—the one she had chosen herself.

Then went Tanaka. Then Endo. Then colleagues.

Then he.

He rose. Walked slowly. His left hand held the *nenju*. His right took a pinch. He raised it to his forehead. Did not sprinkle at once—held it two seconds. Looked at the altar. At the photograph. At the *ibai*. At the *kaimyō*.

Sei-Ren-Aya-Shin-Ni.

He read the five kanji slowly—with his lips, without sound. One by one.

Sei.

Ren.

Aya.

Shin.

Ni.

Then sprinkled the powder into the *kōro*. Took again. Sprinkled again. Bowed his head. Two bows—deep, slow. Removed his hands.

Walked back.

To his place.

Sat.

The reading ended with one more note of the *rin*.



The service lasted an hour and a half. At the end the priest stood, looked over the hall and said one sentence quietly: "*Aya-Shin-Ni is now on the other side, in the Pure Land. We who remain, we continue.*" Nodded. Left.

People began to rise.

Kurosawa remained sitting for a minute. Looked at the *nenju* in his palm. Then rose.

Walked to Nao.

She stood to the left of the altar, still holding the photograph with both hands, and waited while Endo and Kenji came up in turn. Endo said something brief to her—Kurosawa did not hear. Nao nodded. Kenji approached, laid a palm on her shoulder—for a second—and stepped back. Nao looked at him directly: "*thank you, Yamada-san.*" Quietly.

Kurosawa came up last.

Stopped half a step away. Did not want to stand too close.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Nao-san."

"Thank you for coming."

"I had to come."

She looked at him. For a long time. The way Sasaki looked when she wanted to say something and could not bring herself to. That look passed down in families.

"Yukio-san," she said.

He nodded.

"Yuri said you are a good person."

Kurosawa was silent a second.

Then he went down on one knee—slowly—so as to be on her level. The photograph in her hands began to tremble. Nao pressed it tighter, with both palms. The tremor dropped.

"Yes, Nao-san."

"Yuri isn't coming back, is she?"

"She isn't coming back."

She held the photograph.

"But I will come," said Kurosawa. "If you allow it."

Nao nodded. Once.

Said nothing more.

He stood.



At the exit from the hall—a small table with *kōden-gaeshi*—little chocolates in black-and-white wrappers with the monogram "佐々木." Kurosawa took one, put it in his chest pocket, not for eating—so as not to insult the family with a refusal.

On the sidewalk in front of the hall a black sedan was waiting. The driver was a young sergeant from the department whose name Kurosawa did not remember—he took him by his position. Nao was to go to the cremation directly: Hiragishi crematorium, half an hour's drive. Kurosawa offered to accompany her there.

She nodded.

He opened the rear door for her. She got in. He went around the car, got in on the other side.

The sergeant pulled onto the highway without a word.

Nao placed the photograph face down on her lap—so that no reflections from the windows fell on it.

Kurosawa looked ahead.

The Kannon-neiyu highway hummed under the wheels. The sky gray. Streetlamps already on, though it was three.

He wanted to say something. Did not say it.

Nao looked out the side window. Did not cry. Looked at something beyond the glass—at a filling station going by, at trees, at the metal fence of a cemetery on a bend. Her palms lay on the photograph. Fingers thin, with short-clipped nails—the same as Sasaki's—but Nao wore on the middle finger of her right hand a thin silver ring Sasaki had never worn.

Kurosawa noticed the ring.

Did not ask.

A kilometer on, Nao pressed her forehead to the glass. Briefly—for a second—and straightened again. Kept looking out the window.

Around the bend came new cable poles, then a longer row of low residential buildings, then a park belt without fences, with the bare skeletons of trees. Nao did not try to follow them with her eyes. They passed beyond the glass on their own, and she let them.

At an intersection the sergeant braked. A young woman was pushing a child in a stroller across the road. The child was asleep. No one in the car said anything. The yellow light turned green. The sergeant moved off.

Kurosawa looked at Nao. She was still at the window.

The crematorium appeared around a bend.

A plain building of gray concrete. A wide arch over the entrance. Two chimneys on the far side. Japanese sign, white on gray. He had been here once—when they buried his father—but remembered nothing except that it had smelled of hot concrete.

The sergeant stopped the car.

Kurosawa opened Nao's door.

She got out. Turned out to be a head shorter than him. The photograph again in both hands, face up.

Looked at the building.

"Yukio-san."

"Yes."

"You'll stay to the end."

"Yes."

She nodded. Went ahead.

Kurosawa went after her—half a step behind and slightly to the left—the way partners walked when they did not know what was waiting inside.

He knew.



In the entry hall of the crematorium they were met by a staff member in gray uniform. He led them to a small waiting room—narrow, with a dozen wooden chairs, a coffee machine, and one low table with a popular magazine two months out of date. Endo and Kenji arrived ten minutes later. Tanaka with his wife too. Silent.

The cremation lasted an hour forty. Kurosawa sat upright, hands on his knees. In the chair beside him Nao held herself the same way. Once she placed the photograph face down on her lap—and Kurosawa looked at her briefly—and she caught his glance—and nodded, and turned the photograph face up again.

He knew it was not right to turn it back. That had been her choice, and he should not have intervened. He looked away.

An hour and forty minutes later the staff member returned.

"Family of Sasaki-san. This way, please."

Nao stood. Kurosawa stood. He let her go ahead.

They entered the hall of farewell to the bones. *Kotsu-age*.

In the center of the room stood a low metal table. On it lay bones. Cremation in Japan does not burn to ash—a skeleton remains, brittle, white, with that particular tint a stone has after frost. The bones lay in their order—legs at the bottom, then the pelvis, then the spine, then the shoulders, then the head. All familiar.

The attendant gave Nao and Kurosawa each a pair of long chopsticks—of two different materials (one wooden, one bamboo—so the pair would not match; a tradition Kurosawa remembered from childhood without explanation). Nao took her pair firmly.

The attendant indicated the first bone—small, from the right foot—and said: "*We go from the bottom.*" Nao served first. The attendant helped her lift the fragment with the chopstick; Kurosawa caught it with the second from the other side; together they placed it in the covered urn—small, smooth, porcelain, white.

Nao held her chopstick level. Did not tremble. Kurosawa felt his chopstick slip for a second—and corrected.

Foot bone. Femur. Several ribs. Spine. Shoulders.

Last was the *nodobotoke*—a small bone from the second cervical vertebra, of a shape the Japanese read as "seated Buddha." The attendant showed it separately. He said: "*This is the one who sat within him.*"

Nao nodded. Took with her chopstick first. Kurosawa from the other side. Together they lowered it into the urn.

The attendant closed the urn. Wrapped it in white silk cloth. Handed it to Nao with both hands.

Nao took it. Looked at it.

"This is her."

"Yes, Nao-san."

Nao did not cry.

Held the urn.

Kurosawa stood.

He felt—from this moment on—that he no longer had a partner. He had had her—up to this moment, while her bones lay on the table, while they laid them out with their hands. Now she was in porcelain. Now as a witness.

He placed a palm on Nao's shoulder. Not hard. For a second.

Removed it.

"Let's go," he said.

Nao nodded. Walked to the exit.

He followed.

Toshi Comes Out

"Where?"—"Otaru."—"I knew."

Prosecutor Fujiwara's office was on the fourth floor of the *Chihō Kensatsu-chō*, with a window on the parking lot and on the low gray roof of the fire depot across the road. Walls—light gray, with a single calendar—a court calendar, with dates of hearings underlined in red. The desk—dark, long, almost empty: a thin lamp, a black pen, a black cup with black tea, and one folder Kurosawa had brought an hour ago.

Fujiwara sat at the desk.

He was sixty. He always wore a black suit and the white cuffs of a shirt, with two simple silver cufflinks at the wrists. Hands—thin, with long fingers, no ring (he had divorced long ago). Hair combed back, parted on the left. Face—dry, very calm.

Kurosawa sat opposite. Hands on his knees.

Fujiwara was reading the folder slowly. He was not a man who read fast.

"Kurosawa-san," he said at last. "I have a question."

"Yes."

"You understand what you are taking on."

"I understand."

"This will not be an expert consultation on paper. It will be grounds against you personally, if he escapes."

"He will not escape."

"You have this on paper?"

"I have only Nakamura's word."

Fujiwara nodded. One palm turned a page. He read on.

Kurosawa looked past him at the calendar. At the date—the sixteenth of December—when the first hearing on the Takada case was scheduled (not his case; he knew only that it existed). The red underlining was thin, neat.

"Kurosawa-san. One time aloud," said Fujiwara. "This is not a reversal of the sentence. Nakamura has served twenty-two years. This is a temporary reclassification as an expert consultant in an active investigation, article 168 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, with an electronic bracelet and assigned convoy. Legally he is in transfer between institutions. A motion to review the case you and I will submit no earlier than six months from now, and not from this desk. You understand this the way I have just said it."

"Yes."

"The deadline is the first of February," said Fujiwara, without lifting his eyes.

"The deadline is until there is a finale."

"That is not a deadline. That is a wish."

"I know."

"Kurosawa-san"—Fujiwara raised his eyes. "I am signing this not because you are right. I am signing this because I knew Ogawa, and Ogawa would have signed it first."

Kurosawa was silent.

"And one more thing," said Fujiwara. "If Nakamura steps off the step he cannot step off, you will have to stop him. Not me and not the leadership. You."

"I understand."

Fujiwara held his pen a second over the page. Then lowered it and signed. His signature was narrow, vertical, without flourishes—three vertical strokes and one horizontal.

Set another stamp. Red.

Closed the folder.

Reached it across the desk.

"Go."

Kurosawa nodded. Took the folder. Stood.

"Thank you, Fujiwara-san."

"Do not thank me," said the prosecutor. "Go."

Kurosawa went.



The *Tsukigata* correctional facility stood forty kilometers north of Sapporo, in the Ishikari valley, past a stretch of rice fields flooded in winter and locked in thin ice. The facility walls—gray concrete with two towers. The interior courtyard—paving, a small garden on the left, with two pines and low stones, in Japanese style—not for the inmates but for inspectors who come from Tokyo.

Kurosawa parked in the outer yard. Took the folder. Went through the checkpoint.

At the duty officer's post in the second zone he showed his document. The duty officer looked slowly. Read. Raised his eyes.

"One?"

"One."

"Transport?"

"Mine."

The duty officer nodded. Picked up the phone. Dialed the internal line.

Kurosawa waited. In the reception was a low plastic sofa, brown, with a scratch in the middle of the seat. He did not sit. He stood by the window, looking at the empty parking lot.

Twenty minutes later the doors from the internal block opened.

They brought out Toshi.

He was in gray civilian—a plain coat, dark trousers, dark shoes without laces. Hair short-shaved, as always. Face yellow from prison food. Thinner still since their last meeting. Kurosawa noted to himself: roughly two or three kilograms.

On his wrists—electronic cuffs, thin, with a blue indicator on the inside. One guard held the key. The other—the folder with the description.

Toshi looked at Kurosawa. Once. Did not say anything.

The duty officer signed one more paper. Handed the folder to Kurosawa.

"He's yours, Kurosawa-san," he said. "For everything that follows—you."

"Yes."

The guard removed the cuffs from the anchor bar, leaving only one bracelet on Toshi's left ankle. He did not offer his hand. Simply

lifted his leg when it was needed, and lowered it when it was needed.

He walked through the checkpoint.

Through the doors of the outer vestibule—to the parking lot.

Kurosawa opened the right rear door of his SUV. Toshi got in. Did not ask whether he could sit in front. Kurosawa did not offer.

Sat behind the wheel.

The engine warmed for half a minute.

He pulled out of the facility.



The Ishikari valley ran flat on both sides of the highway. The rice fields were under ice. Straw goose decoys stood alone on the side roads, without geese. The sky low.

Twenty minutes they were silent.

Kurosawa looked ahead. Toshi sat in the back, behind his right shoulder. Kurosawa saw in the mirror the upper part of his face—eyes, nose. Toshi did not look at him. Looked out his window, at the fields.

At the twenty-first minute Toshi said:

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I am sorry about Sasaki-san."

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

He had known this phrase would come. Had known since yesterday, since the day before, since the time he filed the motion. Had known Toshi would say it himself, without a question.

"Thank you," he said at last.

"I underestimated her."

Kurosawa was silent.

"I thought," Toshi said, slowly, "that she needed no protection. Because she knew how to hold herself. That is a mistake. Everyone who walks beside you needs protection."

"You think it is I who lost her."

Toshi did not answer at once.

Kurosawa looked in the mirror.

Toshi answered evenly:

"No. I think it is he."

"You are sure."

"Yes, Kurosawa-san. I am sure of that."

Kurosawa nodded. Said no more.

The Ishikari valley ended. The outskirts of Takikawa began. The sky was the same.



For a few minutes they were silent again.

Kurosawa glanced at the fuel gauge—half a tank remained. He would not refuel at the nearest station—the timing was not right. In Takikawa he turned off onto a side road—he knew this loop from several previous operations—and came out onto a secondary road that ran parallel to the highway, with less traffic.

On the shoulder stood a kiosk with boxes in black bags—a small shop selling *saman* and coffee from a machine. Kurosawa did not

stop. Toshi looked at the shop briefly—and turned back to the window.

Ten minutes later Toshi said:

"Where?"

"Otaru."

Toshi nodded. Once.

Was silent.

Then said:

"I knew."

Kurosawa looked in the mirror.

"You knew."

"Yes."

"Since when."

Toshi looked out the window. A long time. Then:

"Since the time I was a ward."

"Jindai-en."

"You already know."

"We know it is in Otaru. We found out the institution's name yesterday."

Toshi nodded.

"I was there from ten to seventeen. Then I left."

"You knew he was there now."

"I knew he was there until nineteen. I did not know he was there now."

"You did not know."

"He does not hold one room long, Kurosawa-san. I thought he had moved long ago. I was mistaken."

Kurosawa was silent.

He knew how Toshi used words. He knew that "*I was mistaken*" was not an apology. It was a fixation. Toshi never apologized.

"One more thing," said Kurosawa.

"Yes."

"Inoue Satoshi. You know him."

"Yes. He is two years older than me. He was also a ward."

"He knows."

"No."

"You are sure."

Toshi looked out the window. The road ran now past low fish drying-racks raised on piles—a summer zone for fish, empty in winter.

"Inoue is an orphan, like me," said Toshi. "The difference is that Yoshida chose me, and did not choose Inoue. Inoue he kept as the facade. Inoue does not know because it was not for him to know. He is a good person, Kurosawa-san. He loves Yoshida."

"This will be hard."

"Yes."

Kurosawa was silent.

"You are coming with us," he said, "because I want you to come."

"I know."

"You are coming because you can confirm what I cannot confirm."

"I know."

"But one more thing, Toshi."

"Yes."

"If you step off the step you cannot step off, I will stop you."

Toshi looked at him in the mirror.

It was the first time in the hour he had met his eyes.

"I know, Kurosawa-san," he said quietly.

Kurosawa nodded.

The road came out onto the highway that ran to Otaru. The sky was still the same—low, gray.

Kurosawa gave gas.

Toshi looked out the window.

Kurosawa heard his breathing behind him. Even.



Half an hour later Toshi said:

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"One question. Not for the record."

"Go on."

"Sasaki-san told me once—at one of the interviews when you had gone out to drink water in the corridor—that you drink green tea only from a thermos. That you never take it in bottles from a

vending machine. Why?"

Kurosawa thought.

"Because from a thermos it is warmer," he said. "And from a machine it cools before I can open it."

"That is an answer."

"Yes."

"And the truthful one?"

Kurosawa was silent.

"Because I bought the thermos with her," he said. "In the third month of working together. We went into *Tokyū Hands* by Odori—and she held two, gray and black. I took the black. She took the gray. Since then I drink from it."

Toshi nodded.

"Thank you," he said.

"For what."

"For answering truthfully."

Kurosawa looked in the mirror. Toshi was looking out the window, just as before.

"Nakamura-san."

"Yes."

"You did not ask that out of curiosity."

"No. I asked because I wanted to show you," said Toshi, "that you can answer such questions now. Five days ago you would not have answered. That matters for where we are going."

Kurosawa was silent.

He knew Toshi was right.

He held the wheel steady.



The landscape past Takikawa slowly changed color. The rice fields ended—there began small rises planted with low conifers, and behind them—the first outskirts of Ishikari. The sky held the same gray density. Roads on this stretch were dusted with salt in winter, with a thin scrape under the tires; the engine ran evenly.

He saw in the side mirror the trailing car—Kenji—a kilometer behind them. Kenji kept his distance professionally. Kurosawa noted to himself: tell him the distance is right.

"One more thing," said Kurosawa.

"Yes."

"In Otaru. When we arrive. You speak only when I ask you. Not before."

"Yes."

"Inoue-san will recognize you."

"I know."

"It will be harder for him than for me."

"I know, Kurosawa-san. I will not hurt him."

Kurosawa nodded.

"One more."

"Yes."

"If Yoshida is not at Jindai-en, I will ask you to say where else he can be."

"I will say."

"You know."

"I don't know exactly. I know possibilities. I will say."

"Good."

Toshi looked out the window.

Kurosawa looked ahead. The sky and the road merged into one gray line on the horizon—and on that line the first outskirts of Otaru gradually appeared, white and thin under the low sky.



CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Inoue

"Yoshida-sensei is a holy man."

Otaru lay under a low sky, with the port on the left and the Temiya slope on the right. Kurosawa turned off the highway onto a narrow road that climbed between two rows of old wooden buildings—former warehouses from the Meiji era, now converted into ceramic workshops and shops for tourists. It was past four in the afternoon. The streetlamps had already gone yellow. Kenji drove in the second car, half a kilometer behind; Toshi—with Kurosawa.

The children's home *Jindai-en* appeared around the bend. Kurosawa recognized it from the photograph Kenji had sketched last week—but on site the building was longer and darker than he had remembered from the shot.

Wooden, two-story, Taisho style, with a wide overhanging eave and black tile. The main building stood deeper on the lot, behind a low stone enclosure. To the right of the main block—an annex from 1972, concrete, simpler, without exterior windows. On the facade—one small enameled plaque with the black inscription "神代園," without any image.

Kurosawa parked by the fence. Kenji's car pulled up behind. Kenji got out, closed the door softly, came over.

"Sir," he said.

"We're going in."

"Toshi?"

"With me."

Toshi got out of the rear door. The cuff on his ankle was concealed under his trouser leg. He stood evenly, without tension.

Kenji looked at him briefly. Did not greet him.

They walked to the main entrance.



The entry doors were wide, wooden, with two glass panels in the upper part and a metal handle in the form of a ring. Kurosawa rang the side bell.

Half a minute later the door opened.

A middle-aged man opened, in a gray cardigan and an apron over a shirt. He was about fifty-two—with thin round glasses, smoothly combed dark hair with two white threads at the temples, and a gaze Kurosawa noted from the threshold as kind. Not perceptive. Kind.

"Yes?"

"We are from the prefectural police," said Kurosawa. "Kurosawa Yukio, Missing Persons unit. This is Yamada, consultant. This is Nakamura. We come without appointment. My apologies."

The man looked at him for a long time. Then at the credentials Kurosawa held out. Then at Kenji. Then at Toshi.

Looked at Toshi a second longer.

"You are Inoue-san?"

"Yes. Inoue Satoshi. I am the director."

"We would like to speak with you. It concerns your predecessor."

Inoue nodded slowly. Did not ask which predecessor. He knew there was only one who mattered.

"Come in," he said. "It is not the best hour—the children are just coming back from school—but I will take you to my office."

He stepped aside.

They entered.



The *genkan* was wide, with two rows of cabinets for children's shoes along the wall. In the first row of cabinets were twenty or so pairs of small slippers, winter boots—all standing evenly, with tags with names written in careful, childish hand. In the second row—adult staff shoes.

It smelled of linseed oil and, faintly—probably from the kitchen deep inside—of boiled rice.

Kurosawa took off his shoes. Kenji too. Toshi—with Kurosawa's help—crouched, took off his shoes, placed them evenly, like the children. The cuff was visible now. Inoue saw and held his gaze on it

for a second—then turned away—did not ask.

Inoue led them down the corridor—wooden floor, worn, warm to the touch through socks. They passed the kitchen (a woman in a white apron looked out from it, nodded to Inoue, disappeared); passed doors from behind which someone could be heard playing the first bar of *Sakura Sakura* on a piano—and stopping, and starting again; passed a wall with old photographs in black frames—graduating classes of wards, rows of children in front of the main building, each shot with a small metal plaque below it giving the year.

Kurosawa noticed: in the 1993 graduation photograph, in the second row, was a girl with hair combed back, with a thin serious face, thirteen or fourteen years old. He recognized her from another source, from another photograph of an older age, in a white medical cap. He did not stop. Did not point.

Kenji noticed that Kurosawa did not stop. Kenji also did not stop. But when they had passed, Kenji briefly touched Kurosawa's wrist with his left elbow. Not as a gesture. Simply as contact. Kurosawa understood: Kenji had recognized her too.

Toshi passed without looking at the wall.

Inoue's office was at the end of the ground-floor corridor, with a view of a small inner garden with one low maple. Desk—dark, old, with a new computer. Two cabinets—with paper files. Walls—with two children's drawings in frames and one photograph.

Kurosawa looked at the photograph.

Inoue, about twenty years younger, in a white shirt, stood next to an older man in a gray suit. The older man—short, thin, with a shaved head, thin features, dark deep eyes. He was resting his hand on Inoue's shoulder. Neither was smiling. Photo—approximately

2005–2007.

Inoue saw where Kurosawa was looking.

"That is Yoshida-sensei," he said.

"I know."

Inoue looked at Kurosawa for a long time. Then nodded. Pointed to a low table in the corner with four chairs. All sat. Inoue brought from the kitchen a black tray with four cups of *hōjicha* tea, set it down, sat opposite.

"I will not go around in circles," said Inoue. "You have come to me about Yoshida-sensei. What has happened."

Kurosawa was silent. Held the cup in his hands, did not drink.

"Inoue-san. We have grounds to believe Yoshida Hiro is implicated in a series of crimes in Hokkaido. Over the last six years."

Inoue looked at him.

Said nothing.

Then laughed briefly. Not loud. Not rough. Simply with one exhale, with his head turning to the side—to the window—and back.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"Forgive me. That is not the laugh of disbelief. That is—I simply do not know how otherwise. You are saying such a thing about the man who raised me."

"I know."

"Yoshida-sensei is a holy man."

Kurosawa nodded.

Did not argue.

"Let me explain why I say that," said Inoue. "I was received into this home in 1985. I was eight. My mother had died. My father was alive, but he was not there. You understand."

"I understand."

"Yoshida-sensei was then a teacher. Junior. He was twenty-three. He noticed me in the first week. I had clothes from the previous home that were small for me—the sleeves ended at the elbows—and Yoshida-sensei brought me his own sweater. In the evening. Quietly. Without witnesses. Simply put it on my bed and left."

Kurosawa was silent.

"He did that always. Not for me. For everyone. Only in such a way that no one saw. He did not like being seen. And he did not like being thanked for it."

"You believe him."

"Kurosawa-san. I do not believe him. I know him."

Inoue looked into his cup.

"He raised me. He taught me. He put me in this position when he left. I will not hold you by the hand. Say what the suspicion is. I will hear it."

Kurosawa looked at Kenji. Kenji nodded imperceptibly.

"Inoue-san. We have every ground to enter your archive now. I have a prosecutor's warrant. I have brought it with me. But I do not want to enter without your permission. I know your permission matters more than paper."

Inoue looked at him.

"Kurosawa-san. I will not refuse you. I only want to understand why you have come."

Kurosawa was silent a second.

Then said:

"I am looking for my brother."

Inoue did not reply.

Not at once.

He put the cup down slowly on the table. Did not look at anyone. Looked into his cup.

Was silent for thirty seconds.

Then raised his eyes.

"Your brother."

"Yes."

"You think he is here."

"I do not think. I know."

Inoue looked at Toshi. For the first time since the start of the conversation.

"Nakamura-san."

Toshi nodded.

"It is so."

"You know this."

"I know."

Inoue looked into his cup again.

For a long time.

Kurosawa waited. Kenji also waited. Toshi sat evenly, with palms on his knees.

Finally Inoue said:

"What do you need."

"Permission to go down to the basement. The archive. The medical journal. The ward records from 1980. And—the keys to the 1972 annex."

Inoue did not respond at once to this.

To the basement and the archive he nodded. Nodded once. Then longer.

To the annex—he did not nod.

"The 1972 annex has been under reconstruction since 2005," he said. "I do not have keys. Yoshida-sensei always kept them himself. He told me, when I took over the home, that the keys would turn up later. I did not press. I had no reason."

Kurosawa nodded.

"I understand."

"You think that in there..."

Inoue did not finish.

"That is what we are going to find out," said Kurosawa.

Inoue placed his palms on the table.

"Kurosawa-san. I trust you because you came in yourself and told me about your brother. I do not trust you because you are a policeman. These two things are different inside me."

"I know."

"Go down. I will give you the basement key. I will inform the staff you are conducting an archive audit of the last decade. I will not tell the children about you."

"Thank you, Inoue-san."

Inoue nodded.

Stood.

Went to a cabinet. Took a set of keys from the lower shelf, three on a fob. One—long, brass, with a small brown leather tab. Second—flat, iron. Third—with a red tag.

Held them out to Kurosawa.

"The long one—basement door. The flat one—iron cabinet with the medical journal. The red—the box with personal files up to 2000."

"Thank you."

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

Inoue looked at him.

"If you find your brother," he said, "I want you to know one thing."

"Yes."

"I did not know."

"I know, Inoue-san."

"And one more."

"Yes."

"If you do not find your brother, but find something else about Yoshida-sensei, I will not ask you for leniency. I only ask that you remember that he was my one. And that otherwise I would not have lived."

Kurosawa was silent.

Then nodded.

"I will remember."

Inoue nodded.

He pointed at a door in the corner of the office. The door was small, wooden, with a bolt.

"The basement is that way."

Kurosawa rose.

Kenji rose too.

Toshi remained seated.

"Nakamura-san will stay with me," said Inoue. "I know him. I am not afraid of him."

Kurosawa looked at Toshi.

Toshi nodded.

"All right," said Kurosawa.

He walked to the door in the corner.

Slid the bolt back.

The door opened.

Behind it a staircase went down.



Kurosawa lingered on the threshold for a second. Looked back—Inoue stood at his desk, hands at his sides, looking at Toshi.

Toshi sat evenly, with the same palms on his knees.

"Inoue-san," said Kurosawa. "One more thing."

"Yes."

"The kitchen. Who works there?"

"Suzuki-san. Our cook. In her thirties. Since 2015."

"Can we ask her not to ask about anything?"

"I will tell her."

"Thank you."

Inoue nodded.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"If I need to tell the children something after you leave, I will say you were archive auditors. Is that acceptable?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Kurosawa looked at him longer than he needed to.

"Inoue-san."

"Yes."

"I will not ask you to forgive me when this is over."

Inoue did not reply at once.

He looked out the window at the maple in the inner garden. The maple was bare, with a thin layer of snow on the lower branches.

"I will not forgive you," said Inoue at last. "Because you have nothing to be forgiven for. You are doing what you must do. These are different things—doing what you must, and what has to be forgiven."

"I understand."

Inoue nodded.

Kurosawa turned back to the door in the corner.

Kenji stood beside him. Held the backpack in his left hand, the flashlight in his right. The flashlight was small, thin, with a double battery—the thing Kenji never parted with.

Kurosawa nodded to him.

Kenji nodded back.

They went down.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Archives

"This is the body Kurosawa-san signed for in 2022 as Ren."

The stairs were steep, wooden, with wide treads that sagged in the middle from seventy years of walking. Kurosawa went down first. Kenji after him. The beam of the flashlight found on the first step below a switch—old, rotary, with a bakelite knob. Kurosawa turned it. Two bulbs under the ceiling lit up yellow.

The basement was low. Ceiling—one meter eighty. Kurosawa tilted his head ten degrees and walked. Kenji—straight.

The space extended deeper under the main block. Shelves stood perpendicular to the stairs—eight rows, of wood darkened by dust, with metal corner braces. On each shelf—folders. Not cardboard boxes—operational folders with muslin ties, with stickers of years and codes.

Here lay all the paper memory of Jindai-en, since 1970. Fifty-eight years.

Kenji placed his backpack on the floor in the central aisle. Took out his laptop—not to work with now, but for the scanner he intended to switch on later. Took out a pair of thin cotton gloves. Handed one pair to Kurosawa.

"Yoshida first," said Kurosawa. "Personal file."

"Yes."

They went to the fourth shelf—by year of appointment as director, 1998. Kenji knew the layout from the inventory Inoue had shared last month (he had thought then that this was a routine check). Personal files of administration ran on the left, in alphabetical order.

Kurosawa ran his fingers along the spines. Found: 吉田 博.

Thin folder. Two centimeters. Pulled it out.

Placed it on the low working table by the stairs. The table was old, with two hanging lamps. Kurosawa switched one on.

Opened.

Here lay forty years of service. First was the position card of 1986, when Yoshida was taken on as a teacher of the younger classes. Photograph—Yoshida at twenty-four, in a black suit, with short hair and the gaze of one who had not yet decided whether he was a person or a habit. Second—a copy of his diploma from *Kyōiku Daigaku Hokkaidō*, faculty of pedagogy. Third—a stack of pages with an internal filing: a copy of the graduation thesis of 1986.

The Restoration of the Personality of a Traumatized Child Through Role Therapy.

Kurosawa read the title page three times.

Academic supervisor—Mori Katsuya.

Date of defense—the twenty-eighth of March, 1986.

Grade—*shū* (highest).

He turned the page.

The work was long—forty-nine pages. He did not read. He glanced through.

Three things caught his eye.

First—chapter three, *"Methodology of Reproduction."* Yoshida described how, for a child who had lived through traumatic loss, it was possible to reconstruct *"the key moment at which the child got stuck"*—and to lead them through it once more—*"with a different ending."* He wrote that this was *"not therapy in the medical sense."* *"It is the actualization of a choice that was not made."*

Second—page thirty-nine, *"Example from personal experience."* Yoshida, at twenty-four, in his graduation work, wrote about his own *"key sticking place"*—*"at a pier at the age of eight."* He named neither the place nor the event. Only—*"the pier, morning, water, and a sister who did not come up."*

Third—the epigraph. At the very end, after the conclusions, in hand, in the same restrained script with which he wrote phrases in the rooms:

*There is nothing more terrifying than a moment that does not end.
Restoration is not about beauty. Restoration is about the edge.*

Kurosawa closed the thesis.

Kenji stood beside him. He had been reading over his shoulder. Said nothing. He did not need to.



"Medical journal," said Kurosawa.

Kenji nodded. Went to the seventh shelf—there stood an iron cabinet, locked with a flat iron key. Kurosawa opened it. Took out a thick journal in a black cloth cover.

Jindai-en Staff Medical Journal, 1985–2019.

They opened it on the page where names ran vertically, and years and license categories horizontally.

Yoshida Hiro.

Far right column—*sanitary license*, obtained 1990. Kurosawa ran a finger along the row.

License to work with narcotic preparations—not obtained. *Sanitary veterinary access*—not applicable. *Medical license (rin-i)*—not obtained.

"No access to propofol," Kenji said quietly.

"Yes."

"He did not obtain it through himself. Never applied. He did not enter through the entry point of the system."

"Then through someone."

"Then through someone with access. A nurse. A clinic. Niigata."

Kurosawa nodded.

Wrote the date of the medical license in his notebook. This could be cross-referenced with the health department's registry—but it was already clear.

He put the medical journal on the working table.

He opened Yoshida's personal file further. Inner page—work history:

- 1986–1998—teacher of the younger classes. -
1998–2019—director. - 2019—application for retirement "*for reasons of health*." - 2019—appointed honorary consultant (unpaid, without duties). - 2019—forwarding address for mail: *Gensbō-an, Hidaka, PO Box 7*.

Kurosawa looked at the address for a long time.

"He has been there the whole time," he said.

"Yes."

"Hidaka."

"Yes."

Kenji was silent, then added:

"And he comes here when needed."

"Yes."



They moved on to the wards' personal files.

Kenji knew what to look for. He was laying out the alphabet: Japanese, by surname.

K—Kurosawa.

Kurosawa Ren.

Thin folder. Half a centimeter. Sticker: "*Kurosawa Ren, b. 1977.*"
Date of admission—not 1985, as with the others. Date of admission—April 2022.

Kurosawa opened it.

First page—not a ward's card in the usual sense. It was a form of a different type: *ward-patient of the psychiatric wing, distance form of care*. Kurosawa had never seen such a form before. It had space for a doctor and a guardian, not for a child and parents.

Patient's surname: Kurosawa Ren.

Date of birth: 3 November 1977.

Condition: *long-standing major depressive disorder with elements of catatonia, post-traumatic reaction.*

Date of admission to distance care: 1 April 2022.

Guardian: *Yoshida Hiro.*

Kurosawa turned the page.

Second page—quarterly medical reviews. Entries in Yoshida's hand.

July 2022: "Condition stable. Patient calm. Takes food unassisted. Quiet-register communication."

October 2022: "Patient chose physical activity—15 minutes per day. Sleep normal. Conversations—about his sister."

Kurosawa stopped at "*his sister.*" There had been no sister. But with Yoshida, from childhood—Misako.

"He was writing about himself," said Kurosawa.

"This is his doctrine," Kenji said quietly. "The patient is himself. Ren is restoration."

Kurosawa nodded. Continued.

January 2023: "Condition improved. Patient draws."

April 2023: "Patient asked about his younger brother. It was explained that the brother is not ready."

Kurosawa felt something in himself stop quietly. Not his heart—not his heart "*pounding*"; he had long been from the profession in which such combinations of words did not exist. Simply quietly stopped.

He read the line once more.

Patient asked about his younger brother. It was explained that the brother is not ready.

He placed his palms on the table.

Kenji watched him. Said nothing.

Kurosawa continued.

July 2023: "Condition stable." October 2023: "Condition stable." January 2024, April 2024, July 2024, October 2024: "Condition stable." January 2025: "Patient asked about his daughter. It was explained that the daughter is safe."

Kurosawa turned to the end.

Last entry—October 2025. *"Condition stable. Patient reads."*

There were no entries for 2026, 2027. None for 2028.

"He stopped keeping the journal in 2025," said Kenji.

"Which means Ren was no longer '*stable*.'"

"Or he knew he had entered a phase where the entries would be different."

Kurosawa was silent.

He looked at the registration form once more. At the date—the first of April 2022. And—at the stamp at the bottom of the form: the stamp of the chief physician of the psychiatric wing of Jindai-en, with a signature.

Jindai-en had no psychiatric wing.

Kurosawa knew this from familiarity with the institution's registry. Jindai-en had a children's ward, and a small medical station, and an isolation room in case of illness—there was no psychiatric wing.

"This is a forgery," he said.

"Yes," said Kenji. "He backdated the file when Ren was already with him. So that in case of a check—if someone came with a question—there would be a form. '*I care for him at a distance. Patient of the psychiatric wing.*' There was no wing. There was a form. The form is paper."

"He had this in the second week after Ren disappeared."

"Or the third. No later."

Kurosawa closed the folder.

Placed it on the table beside Yoshida's personal.



Kenji had already moved on—to the letter *M*.

Pulled out a second folder. Thicker.

Mizuki Michiko, born 1978.

"That's her," said Kenji.

Kurosawa came over.

They opened it.

Date of admission—1985. Date of departure—1993. Niigata Medical School, 1993–1998. Specialization—nursing.

Further—a clipping from the graduates' journal of 1998, with a photograph. In the photo—Michiko, twenty years old, in a white nurse's uniform, with hair combed back, with a thin serious face.

Kurosawa looked. The face was the same as on the wall in the corridor—in the row of graduates of 1993—only older.

Kenji turned further.

The last official entry—2002. "*Employed by the Niigata Woman's Clinic, third point of psychiatric support.*"

Further—blank.

But at the bottom of the page, in pencil, in fine writing, in Yoshida's hand:

Ayano—from 2003.

"Michiko became Ayano," said Kenji. "He renamed her."

"When."

"In 2003. That is when he first '*called*' her. From the thesis theory—'*role therapy*.' The name—also a role."

"Then this Ayano is not Ren's daughter. It is she."

"Yes, Kurosawa-san. It is she."

Kurosawa nodded.

He knew now that he had separated the two Ayanos even earlier—but only now was he holding paper confirmation in his hands. This was the woman from the Niigata clinic. Not the twenty-year-old daughter of Ren. This—a fifty-year-old nurse, with a double name, with two lives folded one into the other.

Kurosawa placed the Mizuki folder beside the two others.



Kenji went deeper into the shelves.

He knew he was looking for one more thing.

He pulled from the second shelf on the right edge a folder—thin, with a sticker "*Takahashi Yuji, b. 1999, incomplete graduation.*"

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

Kenji placed the folder on the table beside the others.

Opened it.

Takahashi Yuji—22 years old. Ward from 2010 (age ten) to 2017 (age seventeen). After 2017—wardship at distance by Yoshida on "*temporary-transitional status*." Last entry in the folder—April 2021.

Takahashi left home on a tour bus to Kushiro. Did not return. Missing report filed 3 May 2021.

Added in pencil, in the same terse hand of Yoshida:

Found 6 June 2021. Sea. Identified by dental chart 15 August 2021.

Kurosawa looked at the date.

He knew what would come next. Did not want to know.

Kenji turned the page.

On the reverse a copy of the identification protocol was inserted. Body of a man, age approximately 20–25, height 174, thin build, heavy decomposition (two-three months in the water), identification impossible by appearance. Identified by dental chart.

Copy of the dental chart, overlaid on a diagram of the dental arch.

Kurosawa looked at the chart.

Did not understand at once.

Then understood.

This was the dental chart he had signed in 2022—when they had come to him from the Otaru morgue and shown him a copy of the card—and said that it matched Ren's dental record. And he had

looked once then, and seen that it matched—and signed. Had not paid attention that it was that particular card—only that it matched.

Now he was holding the original in his hands. Not a 2022 copy. The 2021 original, from Takahashi's October file.

It was the same card.

That is.

That is, in the Otaru morgue in 2022 they had shown him not Ren's card. They had shown him Takahashi's card—with a new label pasted in the upper corner, "*Kurosawa R.*" He had looked then. He had signed then.

Coroner Kawai Tatsuya—the same one who had died in 2024—had stood beside him and said that "*dental match high.*" Kurosawa had believed him because he had no reason not to believe him. He had not examined the card himself then.

The body in the sea—was Takahashi.

Yuji, twenty-two years old.

Thin. Light-haired. Approximately the same build as Ren.

Died alone somewhere in early 2021, at sea. Body incidentally washed up in Kushiro. Decomposed. Identified by teeth with a swapped label—a year later, released to the Kurosawa family as their brother.

Buried in Ren's grave.

Exhumed in 2027 by Endo.

Kurosawa did not move for a long time.

Kenji stood beside him. Kept a hand on his shoulder. Said nothing at first. Then said quietly:

"Kurosawa-san. This is the body you signed for in 2022 as Ren."

"I know."

"It is Takahashi."

"I know."

"And this means one thing."

Kurosawa looked at him.

"Yes," he said. "It means Ren was already at Jindai-en in 2022. That he has been alive for six years."

"Yes."

Kenji opened his backpack. Pulled out a thin blue folder—with Endo's sticker, with a red diagonal band.

"One more, Kurosawa-san. Endo sent it two weeks ago. I did not show it earlier—was waiting for physical confirmation. Now we have it."

Kurosawa opened the folder.

Inside—three pages. First—the DNA-expertise protocol of the exhumed body from the grave of Kurosawa Ren, forensic laboratory at Hokkaido University, Endo's signature. Second—comparison sample: your archival, Kurosawa Yukio, taken in 2019 during a scheduled medical exam at reattestation (stored in the department bank). Third—comparison sample: Kurosawa Ayano, daughter, voluntarily given in March this year through the school nurse at the lyceum in Niigata.

"The conclusion is one," said Kenji. "On both axes. The body in the grave has no family match either with you as brother, or with her as daughter. Not Ren. This is a biological '*no*,' not just a paper one."

Kurosawa looked at the conclusion. Two match figures—both below the threshold with which the court works. Both—with a period.

"So there were already two proofs," he said quietly.

"Now three," said Kenji. "DNA. Dental chart. Takahashi's personal file. On three independent lines."

Kurosawa closed the folder.

Three folders lay on the working table beside each other: Yoshida, Mizuki-Ayano, Takahashi. Plus—the distance medical form for Ren. Plus—the medical journal with the absence of a propofol license. Plus—Endo's blue folder with the DNA.

Six papers. Six lines that had previously run through separate lives.

Now they converged on one point.

Kenji placed a palm on the table. Did not speak.

Kurosawa looked at the stairs.

"I'm going to Yasuko-san," he said.

Kenji nodded.

"I'm still here. I need to log this. I'll scan everything."

"Don't hurry. Three copies. One—in the prosecutor's safe by evening."

"Yes."

Kurosawa went to the stairs. On the first step he stopped.

"Kenji."

"Yes, sir."

"Thank you."

Kenji nodded. Said nothing more.



Kurosawa came back to the table.

One more thing.

"One more," he said.

"Yes."

"Yoshida's cabinet in the administration office. He left it here when he went in 2019?"

"Yes. Inoue said it stands in his old place. He did not move it."

"It needs to be opened."

"The cabinet is not here. It is on the second floor."

"I know. That is for tomorrow."

"Yes."

Kurosawa returned to the three folders. Opened Yoshida's folder once more at the first page. Read again quietly.

At the end of the 1986 position card was a paragraph he had passed over on the first pass. In the fine hand of a secretary: *"The candidate had his interview with director Mori Katsuya on the twenty-first of March 1986. The director gave a recommendation without questions. The candidate is a former ward of the home, 1970–1980. Has no personal relatives."*

"Kenji," he said.

"Yes."

"This confirms the biography."

"Yes. He grew up here, was educated here, came back to teach, became director. Half a century in one building."

"One room."

"What?"

"In his work he wrote that a person got stuck on one moment. He himself got stuck on one building."

Kenji nodded. Did not speak.

Kurosawa closed the folder for the last time.

He held his palms on the table. For a second.

Then took his hands away. Stood.

Kurosawa went up.



CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Yasuko-san

"Kurosawa-san. If your person is there—please, take him home."

Kurosawa came out of the basement into Inoue's office—closed the door behind him, turned the bolt. Inoue was sitting where he had been sitting. So was Toshi—with the same palms on his knees, in the same position, with the same two cups on the low table, which had now gone cold.

Inoue stood when Kurosawa came out. Kurosawa looked at him. Did not look long—but not fleetingly either.

"Inoue-san," he said. "I need to speak with Yasuko-san."

Inoue nodded. Did not ask why. He had already understood that the same people did not come back from the basement—so there was no point in asking.

"She is in the sitting room, on the ground floor, in the west wing. She sits there in December in the afternoon. It is her tea time with the children—but today the children are on an excursion to the port, they come back after five."

"Thank you."

Inoue looked at Toshi, then at Kurosawa.

"Nakamura-san stays with me."

"Yes," said Toshi. "I'll come to you when you call."

Kurosawa nodded.

He walked out into the corridor.

Walked slowly.

Passing the wall with the graduation photographs, he stopped. Once. Looked at the year 1993. At the girl in the second row—at her—at Mizuki, at the future Ayano. Looked for six seconds.

Then walked on.



The sitting room was in the west wing, with small windows that gave on the garden. Low ceiling. Walls paneled in light wood—old, worn, with two holes for clocks, of which only one still hung: small, round, with Arabic numerals and a dark wavy second hand that moved with a thin *"tick."*

In the corner of the room was a low wooden platform with tatami, and on it—a low table with two cushions. On the table—one thin teapot (the color of wet slate), one cup (white, with a thin crack across the bottom, traced in a thin golden line of *kintsugi*), and a small bamboo box for chopsticks, empty.

On the cushion on the left sat a woman.

Yasuko-san.

Kurosawa knew her from the photograph Kenji had sent from the pension registry. But in person, she turned out thinner. Seventy-eight years old. Small in stature. Back straight. Hair gray, combed back short, with a thin black pin above the left ear. Clothing—dark gray kimono of everyday cut, with a modest sash tied in two or three wraps. Hands—on knees, palms up, the way they are held by a person who is used to holding them.

Her face was of a kind familiar for Japanese women of her generation: thin bones, high cheekbones, with eyes that had dropped slightly with age—but had not lost a focused look. Such a look Kurosawa remembered in his mother.

She looked at him when he stopped in the doorway. Did not seem surprised. Did not rise.

"Kurosawa-san."

He nodded.

She had known his name before he gave it.

"Yasuko-san."

"Come in. Sit down."

He came in. He had already taken off his shoes at the *genkan*. Sat opposite her, on the right cushion—stretching his legs under the low table. Not the Japanese way. He knew he could not do it the Japanese way anymore; he was forty-seven, and his legs would no longer allow it.

Yasuko-san glanced at his legs—not with a look of judgment—and gave a brief nod.

"That will be more comfortable. Do not torment yourself."

"Thank you."

She took from the other side of the table a second cup—small, white, without a crack—and set it before him. Poured tea from the pot.

The tea was *bōjicha*—the one she made for the children. He knew by the smell.

He took the cup. Drank one sip. Held the cup in his palms.

"Yasuko-san."

"Yes."

"Inoue-san said you have been here since 1972."

"Since 1972. I came at twenty-two. Now I am seventy-eight."

"You remember Yoshida-sensei as a child."

"I remember. He was eleven when I came. He was quiet. Quieter than the others."

"What else do you remember."

Yasuko-san looked into her cup. For a long time. Then raised her eyes.

She looked at Kurosawa directly—that look Kurosawa had already known—from two hours ago, when Inoue had looked at him with it—the look that meant a person already knew what a guest had come with, and was only waiting for the guest to ask the question himself.

"Kurosawa-san," she said quietly. "You are looking for room number six."

Kurosawa was silent.

Looked at her.

Then nodded. Once.

"You know about it."

"Have always known."

"You went in."

"I did not go in. But I knew."

Kurosawa placed the cup on the table. Kept his hands on his knees.

"Tell me," he said.



Yasuko-san did not answer at once.

She took her cup. Drank one short sip. Set it down. Looked into the cup.

"My mother was a cleaner here before me. Do you know that?"

"No."

"Her name was Yasue. Yasuko is my name, chosen in her honor, with one different kanji. Mother came here in 1946, when the home took in the children of the war. She was taken on for cleaning because she had lost her husband at the front. I was born in 1949. I grew up here, in the service room, with my mother. Not as a ward—as the cleaner's daughter."

"I understand."

"In 1972 my mother fell ill with her lungs. I came in her place. I was twenty-two. She died in 1976—here, in the room next door—but she had time to work with me for four years."

Kurosawa nodded.

"Mother," Yasuko continued, "in 1975 made one duplicate key. The original of the key belonged to Mori—the then director. He kept the key in his desk. Mother did the cleaning in his office every morning, before he came in. One day she took the key—brought it to a locksmith on Hanazono-chō—had a copy made—and returned the original to its place the same day. No one noticed."

"Why did she make the copy?"

"Because the annex had just been built in 1972, and it contained rooms where cleaners were not invited. Mother did not like rooms where she was not invited. That was her principle. She used to say: *'Where you do not go, something grows that you do not want to see later.'*"

"I understand."

"She passed the key to me in 1976, when she lay down. She said I would never use it. But that I should keep it. And that I should know where the entrance was."

"You did not use it."

"I did not use it. Neither mother nor I. We kept it."

"Why."

Yasuko-san looked at him.

"Because we knew we should not. A cleaner in a children's home is, in a certain sense, the quietest of all who work there. Not because we are timid. Because a child in the home sees the cleaner every day—and must know that the cleaner does not bring trouble. A cleaner who has entered a room to which she was not invited is a cleaner who has eaten the child's trust for tomorrow. Mother and I decided the key would be for the day someone came in who was not

a cleaner."

"I understand."

"You are not a cleaner."

"No."

"You are a brother."

Kurosawa was silent.

He held the cup.

"I knew you would come," said Yasuko. "I did not know when. I only knew you would come."

"How."

"Because Yoshida-sensei left two days ago. He went to Erimo alone. He would not have gone to Erimo unless he was certain you would come here. He took to Erimo something he could not fail to take. So here he left something he could not fail to leave."

Kurosawa looked at her.

"Yasuko-san."

"Yes."

"You do not love him."

"Kurosawa-san. I do. But that is second. First, I understand him."

"You understand what he is doing."

"I understand that he is doing what he would rather not do. These are different things. He is not bad. He is stuck. The difference is that the bad can be judged, and the stuck must be freed."

"Freed."

"Yes. Led out. Shown the end. Only not by me. I am the cleaner.
Not my end."

Kurosawa was silent.

He knew how to hold a silence. Yasuko-san knew too.

She looked into her cup.

Then said:

"The key."

She drew from the sleeve of her kimono a thin cloth handkerchief. Unfolded it on the table. Inside lay a single key—long, black, metal, with a plain groove on the head. From 1975. Fifty-three years old.

"This is the key to the outer doors of the annex corridor. Not to room number six. That room Yoshida-sensei rebuilt in 1998, after Mori's death—a new lock—and I did not make a copy. In 1998 I could no longer—Yoshida-sensei was director now—and I had no access to his desk."

"I understand."

"But," Yasuko-san looked at him, "when you open the outer doors, you will go down the corridor to room number six itself. The door of the room is not locked."

"Why."

"Because Yoshida-sensei went to Erimo. He knew he was turning you toward them. This is his doctrine. He does not enter when he chooses that you should enter."

Kurosawa nodded slowly.

He understood. He had read the graduation thesis half an hour ago.

"The annex has been marked '*under reconstruction*' since 2005," Yasuko added. "Since then I do not enter. Inoue-san does not either. Only Yoshida-sensei had a key. But the outer doors of the corridor are the old ones, from 1972. A new lock was never put on them. In 2005 they simply put up the sign '*repair*' and closed them."

"My key fits there."

"Yes."

Kurosawa took the key. Held it in his palm. It was cold. Metal, with a thin layer of dust on the bit—a long dust—the dust of 1975.

He put the key into his left inner pocket, next to the chest pocket where the *nenju* lay.

"Yasuko-san."

"Yes."

"You want to tell me something more."

She looked at him. For a long time.

Then, quietly:

"Kurosawa-san. If your person is there—please, take him home."

Kurosawa did not answer at once.

He placed his palms on the table. Looked at her.

"I will," he said finally.

She nodded. Once.

Took her cup. Drank a sip.

"And one more thing."

"Yes."

"Yoshida-sensei will come back. Not today. Later, maybe tomorrow. He always comes back when he goes to Erimo. It is his ritual. He never stays at Erimo longer than two days."

"I know."

"You will not stop him from coming back."

"No."

Yasuko-san looked at him.

"Thank you."

Kurosawa nodded.

He stood—slowly—the knee had gone numb. Bowed once, deeply.

Walked to the door.

At the threshold he stopped. Turned.

"Yasuko-san."

"Yes."

"You have known him since childhood."

"Since eleven."

"What should he be called. When I see him."

Yasuko-san thought.

"By surname," she said. "Yoshida. He will not correct you. He does not like to give himself as Hiro. Hiro is his childhood name. He is Yoshida now. That is the one who has named himself already."

Kurosawa nodded.

Left.

Walked down the corridor. Did not look at the wall of photographs this time.

In Inoue's office he took Toshi. Kenji had already come up from the basement with two bags of scanned material. Kurosawa showed him the key in his palm. Kenji nodded—once—and glanced at his watch. Half past five in the evening. The children would soon be back from the port.

"Inoue-san."

"Yes, Kurosawa-san."

"We are going to the annex. Through the yard."

Inoue looked at the key in Kurosawa's palm.

Saw. Understood. Did not ask.

Nodded.

"Go," he said. "I will be here."

Kurosawa nodded.

He walked out of the office.

Kenji after him.

Toshi—with a slight lag, as always.

They went through the *genkan*. Put their shoes on. Kurosawa opened the exterior doors of the main block.

The yard was gray. Sky low. On the side wall of the annex was a small metal entrance—gray—with the sign "工事中" ("under repair") on an enameled plaque, faded.

Kurosawa walked toward it.



The key in his pocket.



CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Room No. 6

Six years, Ren.

The annex kept its own air apart from the rest of the house. Yasuko-san walked ahead with a short step, the key in her right hand—the same key her mother's brother had cut for her in seventy-five out of brass, its teeth worn down to flat grooves by fifty years of one and the same turn. Kurosawa followed her two steps behind, as one follows the elderly—without hurrying, without drawing closer, keeping the gap in which she could stop.

They went down a concrete slope from the back side of the main building—to the lower yard, dusted with the first gray snow. In the yard stood two iron pails of sand, a wooden shovel with a cloth-wrapped handle—and a metal door painted the same gray-beige color as the whole annex of seventy-two. The door had no

plaque. Only, around the lock—a brass rim, worn to yellow.

Yasuko-san stopped half a step from it.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes, Yasuko-san."

"I did not go in. Since seventy-five. I will turn the key and wait upstairs. If you need anything—call."

"Thank you."

She inserted the key. Turned it slowly, with two clicks—with the small resistance a key takes in a lock that has not been looked into in a very long time. The door yielded half a finger. Yasuko-san did not push it wider. She took out the key. Put it in the pocket of her apron.

"Take with you only what you can carry yourself."

Kurosawa nodded.

She turned and walked back to the stairs. Kept one hand on the concrete rail. Did not look back.

Kurosawa waited until her steps had faded into the upper corridor. Then pushed the door.

Behind it was a corridor.



Straight, long, with a ceiling at the height of a man's stature plus a palm. Walls—gray concrete without plaster, with small streaks where over these half-centuries damp had risen. One lamp in the ceiling in the middle of the corridor—of the old kind, in a metal wire cage—and one just like it at the very end, twenty-two steps away—both burning with an even yellow light. Yoshida had left them on. Kurosawa noted this and did not stop.

Twenty-two steps. He counted them in his mind—not because he wanted to count, but because the counting kept his hands at his sides and his shoulders lowered.

At the seventh step he noticed the smell—warm, domestic, with that light note of boiled rice that came through the door once every two days. At the twelfth—he heard, from outside, behind the metal door at his back, in the yard, one drop fall from a downspout onto concrete. One short sound. At the nineteenth—the ceiling of the corridor became half a palm lower—it was not so, only seemed so—and Kurosawa walked on.

At the very end—a door of dark wood. Brass handle. The order in the handle was old—from fingers that touched it every day—and the bronze had that thin sheen a hand gives, not a rag.

He put his palm on the handle.

The handle was warm.

Warm in the way the handle of a door is warm to a room in which someone lives. Not hot—warm to human temperature—with that thin note of wax from fingers that stays on brass from daily touch. Kurosawa held his palm where a man's fingers had held their palm six years running—and there was no sharp feeling—only that things touched become warm, and things untouched—cold, and that this handle knew its daily warmth without him.

He opened.



He knew someone was coming.

This was not a discovery. In the annex steps rang from the concrete clearly—right, left, right—and over the years he had learned to recognize Yoshida-sensei's steps from the ground floor. The steps that

had entered the corridor a few minutes ago were different. Heavier. Two: women's steps, small—and then men's, even. The women's steps had turned back. The men's—had not.

He set the book aside on the low stool beside the bed. It was a small book in a gray paper cover, with one kanji on the binding—an old translation of a Chinese poet Yoshida-sensei had brought him in the winter. He was reading it slowly. One page in the morning, one after the midday meal. Today he had read one, because he was not used to reading after the midday meal without Yoshida-sensei, who would be drinking tea nearby.

The step stopped outside the door.

Pause.

In that pause he had time to think about Yoshida-sensei. About how yesterday Yoshida-sensei had placed the book on the stool and said: "Ren, I will be gone for a few days." He had not said where. Had not said when he would return. Had not said what to do if someone else came. Yoshida-sensei did not say many things—not because he was hiding them, but because he considered: if it was needed, he would say.

Now it was needed.

Now it was late.

Then the handle turned.

He had time for one thing—to pull the blanket from his feet—and the door opened.



The room was small. Four tatami, slightly worn along the central path. One lamp on a low stand beside the bed, in a glass shade of cream color. Washbasin in the corner, low, with a single tap.

Portable toilet in a niche behind a screen of rice paper. Walls—tatami, from floor to ceiling, with thin bamboo stitching every half-meter. One low bed by the far wall, with a plain cotton blanket in beige stripes.

On the side wall, at shoulder height—a small shelf. On the shelf—a single porcelain figurine without a face. Fifteen centimeters tall, smooth, in the form of an empty cone. Kurosawa saw it in one second—with that peripheral vision a policeman keeps separate—and forgot it at once, because a thin man was rising from the bed in front of him.

The man was in a gray cotton pajama. Hair to the shoulders, gray in patches. Face—clean-shaven, skin pale. Hands slow. He did not sit up straight at once—he raised his torso from the bed calmly—the way one rises who has already lived through several guests over the years and knew that the guest was not in a hurry.

He put his feet on the floor. Did not stand.

Kurosawa stood on the threshold. Did not step further than the first tatami.

The man raised his head.

"Yukio."

Kurosawa recognized the voice half a second before the face. The voice—low, soft—the same one that had sounded in the receiver in the year twenty-two from Otaru on a January evening, when they had arranged to meet at a *kissa-ten*.

"Ren."

Pause.

"It's me," said Kurosawa.

Ren looked at him. Looked for about twenty seconds—without haste, without fear, with that slow focus that comes when the eye has not held something at this distance in a long time. Then sat upright. Lowered his right hand onto his right thigh. Tapped with a fist. Once. Slowly.

"It's you."

"I."

"You came."

"Yes."

Kurosawa took half a step inside. No more. Went down on his knees on the threshold—a motion older than himself—and sat on his heels. Placed his palms backs down on his thighs.

Ren watched him calmly.

"Yukio," said Ren. "Does Yoshida-sensei know you are here?"

Kurosawa considered his answer. No longer than needed to find an honest word.

"I don't know."

Ren nodded. Lightly. With that particular nod with which one hears a truth that changes nothing.

"He knows everything."

Kurosawa was silent.

Ren looked past him—into the empty part of the corridor beyond the door. Then back at him.



Yukio was grayer. The lock above his left temple had gone white—not gray—and one eye held more wrinkles at the outer corner than the

other. His coat was black. He had not worn such coats in his youth. Mother would have said that a man in a black coat looks older than he is.

Mother had died when he was five. Yukio had been one. This was long ago.

He did not know how long. He knew that between the time when they had sat at the kissa-ten on the second floor of Otaru station and Yukio had asked for black coffee—and this now—some time had passed. Yoshida-sensei used to say that time now was not important. That when it was important, he would say so.

Yoshida-sensei had not come today.

He tapped his fist on his thigh. Once. The hand did this by itself, when it met something new. Yukio was something new. Yukio was something old.

Behind Yukio's shoulder the corridor stretched long and dim. In this corridor six years ago there had been nothing—so Yoshida-sensei had said. He had said: "Ren, when you wake up, you will be in a room, beyond which is nothing. That will be good. You will be able to rest." He had done just that. He had rested. He had not asked what was beyond the corridor. There was no sense in asking about what did not exist.

Now beyond the corridor stood Yukio, and Yukio was in a black coat.

He tapped his fist on his thigh again. Quieter than the first time. Only for himself.



"Yukio," said Ren. "How long has it been?"

Kurosawa held the pause. Not because he did not know—but because he did not want the words to come sooner than they were needed.

"Six years, Ren."

Ren was silent for a long time.

Kurosawa counted the seconds mentally—not to know the number, but because the number kept his shoulders lowered. Ninety. One hundred. One hundred twenty.

"And Ayano?" said Ren.

"Alive," said Kurosawa. "In Niigata. Twenty years old."

Ren did not move. Looked at his own knees. At the thin fabric of the pajama over the bones that showed. Right hand on right thigh, calmly. Left—on left.

"Twenty."

Kurosawa nodded. Nothing needed to be said. He understood that Ren was now counting in his mind what Kurosawa had counted on the way here—and that between them for these twenty seconds there was nothing but arithmetic that neither of them wanted to do.

"Ayano," said Ren once more, quieter.

"Yes."

"Twenty."

"Yes."

Ren lowered his head. Did not weep. Breathed evenly.

Kurosawa sat on the threshold. Did not draw closer.

He knew that with one motion now he could disturb that thin thing on which Ren held—the thin thing Yoshida had sculpted for six years—and he did not want to. Not out of pity for Yoshida. Out of care for Ren. Ren was holding now on the fact that he knew the rules of his room—and that Yukio, having come into it, had accepted those rules without inquiring in advance.

He looked at Ren calmly. Noticed. Hands—dry, with a thin layer of winter chapping on the knuckles—not thin, but drained in that particular calm sense that comes from long years in one rhythm: rise early, read one page in the morning, eat twice, read the second page after the midday meal, lie down early. On the back of the left wrist—a flat mark from a watch that had been taken off and put on every day for years—and no watch on the wrist itself. Ren did not wear it. Yoshida-sensei took the watch away at night and returned it in the morning—Kurosawa guessed this in one second—and now there was no watch because Yoshida-sensei had not returned it yesterday.

Hair—longer than Ren used to wear it—but tended. The gray lock above the right ear had gone fully white. The skin of the neck—thin, without a sun-tan. Face clean-shaven. Someone had shaved Ren today. Kurosawa did not know who. Knew it was not Ren himself.



He looked past Ren's shoulder—at the shelf with the porcelain figurine.

Fifteen centimeters tall. Porcelain white, with a thin cream tint in the folds. Form—an empty cone, body without arms, without a face—only a suggestion of shoulders and a light curve where a neck ought to be. On the front face—a vertical line scratched with a

needle, shallow. In the Japanese tradition such figures were called *hitogata*—"in the likeness of a person"—paper or clay dolls into which, during a Shinto ritual of purification, sin, illness, evil were transferred. Then they were burned or sent down the water.

Kurosawa had known this since his father's house. His father had a book about *ō-harae*—the great purification at the end of the year—and read it in winter, when he drank.

Yoshida had been transferring something onto Ren for six years.

He held this thought for one long second. Then closed it, the way one closes the lid of a box that holds things better not kept open.

He did not move.

Did not move further.

Outside the corridor, from the far end, in the lower yard, somewhere, one drop fell from a downspout onto concrete. One sound. Then silence again.

Ren raised his head.

Looked at Kurosawa.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Did you come alone?"

Kurosawa thought.

"No."

"How many?"

"One is with me now in the house. Another—will be here in an hour."

"Who."

"Toshi Nakamura. You do not know him. And Kenji Yamada. You do not know him either."

Ren nodded. These names told him nothing. But he nodded.

Then—looked past Kurosawa's shoulder again. Into the corridor.

Kurosawa did not turn. He knew no one was there. Yet.



He sat upright and thought about how Yukio for six years had thought he was dead. Yoshida-sensei had never told him that directly. But one evening—a year or two ago—Yoshida-sensei had said: "Ren, you are resting from the world now." He had not asked then what that meant. He knew he would ask when Yoshida-sensei was ready to say.

Yoshida-sensei was always ready to say. Only not about this.

He thought about Ayano. About how at six in the morning of January in the year twenty-two she had been drinking milk from the bowl in which he was supposed to have buckwheat. About how she had said then: "Papa, are you coming today to pick me up from the drawing club?"—and he had said: "I'll come."—and had not come.

Twenty years.

This was not imagination. It was a number. He held it on his tongue like a smooth stone.

He thought about Yukari. The wife who had left in the year nine. He remembered her well—the motions of her hands as she cut onions in the kitchen—but did not remember the color of her voice in their last years together. When she had said: "Ren, I can't anymore."—had she said it thinly, or deeply, or evenly? He did not remember. He knew only that she had said it the way a person says it when she does not

want to hurt by leaving.

Yoshida-sensei had asked him once: "Ren, are you angry with her?" He had answered then: "No." Yoshida-sensei had nodded. With the nod with which a truth is received that need not be proved.

It had been—it seemed—recently. Yoshida-sensei always sat in seiza on the tatami beside his bed and asked two or three questions per visit. No more. He would answer. Yoshida-sensei drank tea and listened. Then left.

Now beyond the door stood Yukio. Yoshida-sensei was somewhere. He did not know where.

He did not ask. He was not in the habit of asking.



Kurosawa looked at the watch on his wrist only once—to know he had begun counting at fourteen thirty-four—and did not look again.

One minute.

A second.

A fifth.

Ren once turned his head—to the right—hearing some sound outside the door. Kurosawa heard it too: far, from the upper floor—Inoue was speaking with Kenji on the phone, quietly. Then silence again.

At the sixth minute Kurosawa noticed the book on the bedside stool. Gray paper cover. One kanji on the binding. He read it from seven paces away—「静」, "quiet." Later he would recall it had been a translation of Du Fu—not the early Du Fu, but the quiet Du Fu of his last years in the boat. Ren was reading him slowly.

At the seventh minute Kurosawa noticed Ren's left hand. On the back, between thumb and index finger—a thin white scar Ren had received at twelve, when he was cutting paper for a collage and Kurosawa, eight years old, had pushed his elbow. There had been blood then, and Aunt Kiyoko—Ren's future wife did not yet exist—had stitched the cut with kitchen thread and scolded Yukio quietly, so as not to wake their father.

The scar was the same.

At the eighth minute Ren said, very quietly:

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Don't leave now."

"I'm not leaving."

"Stay."

"I'll stay."

Kurosawa did not move. Neither did Ren.

Another drop fell in the lower yard. Another.

Beyond the corridor wall, somewhere far in the upper floor of the main building, a clock with a tower mechanism struck the half hour. Kurosawa heard it through the concrete as a thin vibrational stroke. One. Then a long vanishing of the sound.

He sat.

Ren sat.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Is it winter outside?"

Kurosawa looked at the ceiling of the room—not because the answer was there—but because that is what a person does who is gathering a simple fact in his head before speaking it.

"Yes, Ren. Our first snow was the night into Wednesday."

"In Otaru."

"In Otaru."

Ren nodded.

"Yoshida-sensei said this year's winter would be quiet."

"We'll see," said Kurosawa. "He may be right."

Ren thought.

"Will you let it live out for him?"

Kurosawa was silent. He knew Ren was not asking literally now. Knew Ren was placing on the table now—between them—everything he knew about Yoshida-sensei, and that this "everything" held on one understanding: Yoshida-sensei would decide for himself. Kurosawa allowed the pause to be what it was.

"We'll see," he said.

Ren nodded once more. Accepted this answer as one accepts a neutral weather.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"I'll stay here a little longer."

"Stay."



Kurosawa did not move. Ren did not move either. Between them—seven tatami, one lamp, one porcelain figurine on the shelf, and one book on the low stool, open on a page Ren had not yet read.

The room held them both.

Yoshida

Misako.

Toshi came into the corridor at fifteen forty-two. Kurosawa heard his steps on the eighth—because Toshi had set his foot down deliberately heavier than his normal step, so that Kurosawa would hear. Toshi did not hold his hands in front of him in the cuffs; the guard, senior sergeant Yamaguchi, walked two steps behind him, with the key in his right hand and the holster fastened on the clasp.

Kurosawa turned his head. Did not stand.

Ren saw his movement and turned his head too, calmly—with the same slow focus with which he had been looking at everything new the whole time.

Toshi stopped a meter from the door. Did not enter. Yamaguchi—likewise.

"Kurosawa-san," Toshi said very quietly.

"Yes."

"He has come."

"How?"

"On foot from the station. He came by train. From Hidaka he traveled overland—on foot to Samani, from there by taxi to Obihiro, then a train through Sapporo. Two days on the road. Yasuko-san is with him in the sitting room. Kenji says for me to call you."

Kurosawa nodded.

"Tell Kenji to keep the camera on the sitting room on his screen. Tell Yasuko-san to bring Yoshida-sensei up here. Alone. Without you, without the sergeant."

Toshi looked at him for one second.

"Yes."

"Thank you."

Toshi turned and walked back down the corridor. Yamaguchi—after him. The footsteps died on the upper floor. Then silence again.

Ren looked at Kurosawa. Looked until he saw Kurosawa did not intend to explain.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Yoshida-sensei is coming here."

"Yes."

"That is good."

Kurosawa did not answer. Ren noted this—and did not note it at the same time. Nodded. Lowered his right hand onto his right thigh and left it there. Did not tap.

"Yukio," said Ren, still more quietly. "Is Yoshida-sensei coming here for me, or for you?"

Kurosawa turned his head. Looked at Ren for one long second. Then said, with the small yielding with which one places on the table a thing Ren wanted to see:

"For himself, Ren."

Ren thought.

"That is also good," he said quietly. Not an evaluation. A statement of a fact he held calmly in his eyes.

Kurosawa did not answer.



Kurosawa waited.

He heard, upstairs, the doors of the sitting room open. Heard two voices sound—a quiet man's and a quiet woman's—and steps begin on the stairs. One pair of steps, then another. Yasuko-san went first—by the custom of the hostess—Yoshida-sensei walked half a step behind her.

Kurosawa rose. Not at once—with the pause in that second when the body asks the head whether it is ready, and the head answered: ready. He stood upright. Placed his feet shoulder-width. Kept his hands at his sides.

Ren saw this and also rose. Not at once—with the same slow motion—but stood. Placed his feet awkwardly, with the uncertainty that comes after six years without proper shoes. Stood five seconds, found balance—and did not sit back down.

Yasuko-san appeared on the threshold. Nodded to Kurosawa.

"Kurosawa-san. Yoshida-san."

"Thank you, Yasuko-san."

She took a step back into the corridor. Yoshida passed her. Yasuko-san did not look at him. She turned and walked back toward the stairs—with the same calm short step with which she had come—with a hand on the concrete rail.

Yoshida stopped half a step from the threshold. Did not cross.



He was exactly as Kurosawa had seen him on the Erimo lighthouse—in the same gray coat below mid-thigh, the same dark leather shoes, the same thin face with high cheekbones. Only now—after two days on the road: on foot from Hidaka to the Samani pier, taxi across the valley to Obihiro, train through Sapporo to Otaru—his lips were thin and dry. The coat carried the smell of carriage dust and the dry trace of rain on the collar. The shoes had dried on top, but in the crevices of the soles still held a crumb of gravel from the Obihiro station.

In his right hand Yoshida held a small case. Black, with a brass latch, the size of a medium book.

He looked past Kurosawa's shoulder—at Ren.

Ren looked at him.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Ren."

Yoshida smiled. With one corner of the mouth. One motion carried through to the end. The way a person smiles who comes home after a long journey and sees that the home has held together without him.

He turned his gaze briefly to the small porcelain figurine on the shelf of the side wall. Looked at it for one second—with that calm eye with which a master looks at a thing he has placed by his own hand in the place where it was to be. Did not correct anything. The figurine held its place on its own. He was satisfied with that.

Then he looked at the bedside stool. Noted the open page in the book—at the place where Ren had left it when he heard the steps. The corner of his lips lifted briefly once more. He kept in his memory which page Ren was to have read today after the midday

meal—and saw that Ren had not read it.

This did not sadden him. This did not console him. He merely noted it.

Then Yoshida looked at Kurosawa.

"You found him."

Kurosawa looked into his eyes. Did not narrow. Did not turn away.

"I am arresting you."

Yoshida nodded. Lightly.

"I know. Let me finish. This is my doctrine."

Kurosawa was silent.

He heard through the walls of the annex—far above, in the sitting room—Kenji say something to Yamaguchi. The plastic of the holster clicked ringingly. Yamaguchi's steps came up to the stairs of the annex and stopped.

Kurosawa did not move.

He knew that this scene could be closed now with a single motion. One gesture of the hand—and Yamaguchi would come down, two more from the yard would come up, Yoshida would be laid into steel, driven to the district station, given a card there, prints taken, put in a cell. Judicial expertise, investigation, indictment, court, verdict. Three or four years of process. In those years Yoshida would write a book about the doctrine. A public book—in soft cover—and in it there would be a paragraph about Ren, soft and warm, which Kurosawa would not be able to read without thinking about his second of inattention on Erimo.

He knew this.

He held his hands at his sides.

Yoshida stepped over the threshold.



He came into the room—evenly, without haste—and stopped a step from Ren. Did not draw closer. Did not touch. Only looked.

"Ren."

"Yes, sensei."

"Yoshida-sensei must go."

Ren watched him.

"Where, sensei?"

"To my sister."

Ren looked past Yoshida's shoulder into that same empty part of the corridor beyond the door he had looked into a minute ago. Then back at him.

"To Misako."

Yoshida smiled a second time. Just as briefly.

"To Misako."

Pause.

Ren lowered his head. Did not weep. Breathed evenly. His right hand slowly went to his right thigh and remained there. Did not tap.

Yoshida turned to Kurosawa.

"Do not take from him what I gave him."

Kurosawa did not answer.

Yoshida waited for an answer two seconds. Then—with the small yielding with which one hands the word to a person who prefers not to give it—nodded.



Kurosawa looked at him.

Then—not because he decided, but because the body decided before the head—Kurosawa lowered himself to his knees. Not on the threshold—he had stood on the threshold long enough. Now he entered the room, took three steps past Yoshida, and sat on the tatami a meter and a half from him, on his heels, with his palms backs down on his thighs.

He sat as his father had sat at New Year's bowings—evenly, without haste, with that straight back that the body holds by itself when the head has released it for a few minutes.

Yoshida saw this. Did not understand at once. Then understood.

He also lowered himself. Slowly—with that slow motion of a person whose knees have known seiza for forty years and had begun in those forty years to hurt little by little. His left hand came to his left knee back down. His right—to his right.

They sat opposite each other. Three tatami between them. The case with the brass latch lay on the tatami half a step from Yoshida's right knee. Ren on the bed behind Yoshida's back—did not move. Toshi on the threshold—did not enter.

Kurosawa looked at Yoshida.

"You killed him."

It came—as it had come at the Erimo lighthouse—before he had time to think from what place in himself he had said it. But this time

he knew from which. From the same place from which the question had not come out at the lighthouse.

Yoshida held his gaze.

"Yes," he said quietly. "Yes, Kurosawa-san. I killed him."

Pause.

"Not in the sense in which people kill with a knife. In the sense in which a person kills who takes from another six years of his life. I killed him. I say this to you now because you need to hear it. At the lighthouse I told you I preserved him. That was true. It was also not the whole truth. I preserved him by what I took from him."

Kurosawa was silent.

Yoshida did not look away.

"I owe you this word," he said. "I give it to you."

Kurosawa looked past Yoshida's shoulder—at Ren. Ren sat upright on the bed, with his hands on his thighs. Did not interfere. Did not look.

"You did not ask him."

"I did not ask."

"You thought for him."

"Yes."

"Six years."

"Yes."

Kurosawa turned his eyes back to Yoshida. Did not raise his voice. Did not lower it.

"Misako."

Yoshida blinked once.

"Yes."

"You think it is she there, in Ren's head."

Yoshida looked at him for a long time. Did not answer at once. Then said—with the same quiet even voice with which people speak a phrase they have held in themselves sixty years:

"I do not think, Kurosawa-san. I know."

Pause.

"I know this not the way science is known. I know it the way a fisherman knows there will be a storm tomorrow when the water turns two shades darker before it can be seen from the shore. I know this in myself. Do not ask whether it is true. The truth and what I know—are different things. I know."

Kurosawa nodded. Not in agreement. In acknowledgment that he had heard.

"You placed her there."

"I did not place her there. I only left the door open."

"That is your phrase from Erimo."

"Yes. It is my one phrase. I repeat it because I have no other."

Pause.

Kurosawa looked at his own knees. At the thin fabric of his dark trousers. At the dust from the corridor—a small gray thread that had caught on his cuff. Did not shake it off.

"Sasaki," he said.

Yoshida did not answer at once.

"Yes."

"That was your choice."

Yoshida lowered his chin half a finger. Not a nod. Something more.

"Mine. Not hers."

Kurosawa nodded again. The same way.

"You chose."

"I chose. I did not choose her. I was choosing you. I set the back door with the timer, with the calculation that it would be blown through in the second you looked at it. I did not calculate that she would leap. But I did calculate that if she did leap, I would not argue with it. That is what you wanted to hear from me. I say it to you."

Kurosawa was silent.

"You owed her," Yoshida added. "I did not owe. That does not comfort. I know."

"No," said Kurosawa. "It does not comfort."

Pause.

Toshi outside the threshold shifted his weight from his right foot to his left. The steps did not ring—Kurosawa heard it by the thin rustle of his trouser fabric against the jamb. Yamaguchi stood two landings up. No one came down.

Kurosawa noted this. He understood that if Toshi took half a step forward now and said one word—Yamaguchi would come down in ten seconds, and the scene would change. Toshi did not take the half step. Toshi held his silence the way one holds a key in a pocket when it is not yet time to open with it.

Kurosawa accepted this.

He knew—with that thin corner that knew about his next actions half a second before the actions themselves—that legally he ought now to rise, give the order to Yamaguchi, put steel on Yoshida, drive him to Otaru. That this was the line he had served for twenty-three years.

He knew it.

He did not cross it.

He held his palms on his thighs, backs down—as Yoshida held his—and allowed these two pairs of hands to hold themselves the same in two bodies that held different things inside.

"Yoshida-san."

"Yes, Kurosawa-san."

"How many years have you waited for this."

Yoshida thought. He counted not for himself—he knew—but so that Kurosawa would hear the figure slowly.

"Twenty-three."

"Since Otaru in two thousand and five."

"Since Otaru in two thousand and five."

"You saw me there."

"I saw you there."

"You chose."

"I chose you."

Pause.

Kurosawa nodded. Accepted.

He understood—with the slow clarity with which an investigator in the thirtieth year of service understands—that he had just been given three things he had been searching for through three books. That it would not lighten. That it would now live in him apart from his actions. That this was what Yoshida wanted to finish in himself. Not confession. Testimony.

Kurosawa was witnessing.

Yoshida saw it.

"Now it is possible," he said quietly.

Kurosawa looked at him.

"Yes."

Yoshida rose from the tatami. Not quickly. The body knew how to rise from seiza after a long sitting—and it rose.



He took a step to the center of the room. Lowered the case onto the tatami beside his right foot. Took off his coat—unhurried—hung it on the brass hook above the washbasin, the same one on which for six years Ren's spare pajama had hung. Unfastened the cuff of his right sleeve. Rolled the sleeve up to the elbow.

On the forearm—two fingers below the elbow crease—was an IV cannula. Already inserted. Since yesterday. Held in place by a strip of white plaster wound with thread so it would not slip. Port closed with a rubber plug. Trocar clear, with a thin notch for tubing. Ayano—the former Michiko from Jindai-en, the current nurse at the Niigata clinic—had come to him the day before and placed the cannula herself, with cold hands and without a word. Yoshida had summoned her with a single line from the payphone at the Obihiro passenger station on Tuesday evening, as he stepped off the train.

One line was old, learned forty years earlier: "Get ready, come." Ayano had come to Genshō-an on Wednesday by the night train, placed the cannula on Thursday morning, and left back the same day. Kurosawa saw this only now. He understood it had been impossible to see the first time.

Yoshida sat down on the tatami. A plain motion of seiza—knees on the tatami, heels under the buttocks—with the naturalness with which a person sits who has accumulated three or four thousand hours in this pose in a lifetime. Right hand came to right knee, back down.

He opened the case.

Inside: one syringe with twenty milliliters of clear liquid, in a plastic sheath. One short luer-lock adapter. A thin swab with isopropyl alcohol in a sealed sachet. One small pack of cotton. Everything laid out tidily—not like a nurse's kit, but the way a master lays out an instrument he has long been preparing.

Kurosawa recognized the propofol at first glance. Not by the label—there was no label—but by the characteristic milky-clear note of the liquid in the syringe, with that light pastel impression the lipid emulsion gives. Twenty milliliters. Standard induction dose for an adult. Ayano had calculated it to the milligram. Kurosawa was placing in his head one check mark—"Michiko-Ayano, Niigata clinic, theft via wholesale warehouse"—and closing the folder.

Yoshida broke the syringe's seal. Fitted the adapter—with two fingers—with the thin click a luer-lock gives when it seats evenly. Broke the seal of the swab. Wiped the port of the cannula. For one second he held the syringe in the air—not to think—but so that the liquid in the syringe would settle, the way water settles in a cup when it has just been poured.

Yoshida raised his eyes. Looked at Ren.

"Ren."

"Yes, sensei."

"Do you remember, I told you that one day I must leave?"

"I remember."

"This is it."

Ren nodded. The way a pupil nods who has carried for ten years in his bag one sentence from a teacher and has now taken it out, unfolded it, seen that it is the same.

"Yoshida-sensei."

"Yes, Ren."

"Thank you."

Yoshida looked at him for a long time. Then—with the small yielding with which a person allows himself to step half a palm off the rules of politeness—touched with his right hand the right corner of his eye. Did not wipe anything. Simply touched. Then returned the hand to its place.

"You are welcome, Ren."

Pause.

Yoshida turned his gaze from Ren and looked at the syringe. Held it in his right hand. The left hand lay calmly on his left knee, back down, with open fingers.

Kurosawa was watching. Did not interrupt.

He understood—with the slow clear understanding with which an adult hears for a second time a tale told to him in childhood—that what was happening now was the last conversation

of a master with the one pupil who had received him. That this was a farewell. That this was a ritual. That no court would have a procedure for this—because no court writes procedures for what it does not see.

He held his hands at his sides.



Toshi stood in the doorway.

He came in quietly—Kurosawa heard one short step behind him—and stopped where the room ended and the corridor began. The cuffs on his wrists did not clink. Yamaguchi behind him did not step into the annex—stood on the stairs two landings up—and Toshi had come alone.

Toshi looked at Yoshida. Then at Kurosawa.

"Kurosawa-san."

One word. Quietly. Without request, without command. Only a statement of fact: he was here, he was waiting—and a question, whether Kurosawa wanted this fact to have a continuation.

Kurosawa looked at him.

"No, Toshi."

Toshi nodded. Lightly. Accepted the answer.

He took half a step back. Now he stood on the threshold itself, but did not cross. Watched. Did not move.

Yoshida did not notice these two things—not because he did not see them, but because he no longer needed to see them. He held the syringe in his right hand and the adapter in his left. Connected the syringe to the port. Clicked. Pulled the plunger back half a millimeter—to make sure the tubing held in the vein. Saw a thin red

thread in the clear short segment between the cannula and the port. Nodded to himself.

Then he pressed the plunger.

Not fast. Not slow. Evenly—with the same steady force with which one pours water from a ceramic pitcher into a cup—and the plunger went down evenly.

Yoshida looked not at the syringe—at Ren. Looked with that particular quiet gaze with which a master looks at his last piece placed on the shelf. Not with pride. With attentiveness.

Ren held his gaze. Did not turn away. Did not weep. One hand lay on his right thigh, calmly. The other—on the left.

Kurosawa sat on the threshold.

He noted the time in himself—not because he wanted to count, but because the counting kept his shoulders lowered. Yoshida had begun the injection at sixteen zero-two. In fifteen seconds the plunger would reach the end. Another twenty seconds—the liquid would enter the bloodstream to the heart. Propofol, through six to eight loops of vascular circulation, would reach the brain and bind the GABA receptors. Then—sleep. Then—the thin long inhale a body takes before a long exhale. Then—a quiet exhale. Then—silence.



Kurosawa watched.

He knew propofol in this dose and at this speed gave a sweet sleep—not suffering. Knew a person felt only a brief warmth in the vein, then light dizziness, then—sleep. Knew breathing would fall silent at the second minute, the heart at the third. Knew that in the medical dictionary this was called induction. In obituaries this word

would not appear. It would be: "*passed away in his sleep.*"

He knew also that this could be stopped now only by one motion—snatch the syringe from Yoshida's hand—and that this motion would be a violation of something for which he had no word. Not the law. The law demanded that motion. Not conscience. Conscience was silent in him.

He allowed the thing for which he had no word to hold his hands at his sides.

Yoshida drove the syringe to the end. Carefully disconnected it from the port—with one finger held the plug—and put the syringe back into the case. Closed the case. Did not rise.

He sat in seiza on the tatami, evenly—with that evenness with which a person sits who has kept his back straight for forty years and knew no other posture—and waited.

One minute. Did not move.

Kurosawa looked at him.

"Yoshida-san."

Yoshida raised his eyes. Not at once. With the small delay with which a person answers his own name when anesthesia is already holding him by the shoulders.

"Yes, Kurosawa-san."

"I have arrested you."

Pause.

"You knew this."

"I knew."

Yoshida looked at him calmly. Another pause. Then—with that thin evenness with which one holds a cup when the hand is already tired but still sets it down straight—he said:

"Thank you."

Kurosawa nodded. Did not answer.

Two. The thin color was leaving the face, the fingers, the backs of the hands. The head lowered half a palm forward. No heavier.

Ren stood by his low bed. Did not move. Looked at Yoshida.

Kurosawa did not look at Ren.

At the second minute and ten seconds Yoshida quietly—with the evenness with which one speaks the last note of a chord—said one word:

"Misako."

Pause.

Then another pause, longer than the first. Then a third, longer than the second.

At the third minute Yoshida's chest made one slow motion up and did not make the motion down. His hand—the one which had held the empty fingers of the syringe half a minute ago—lay back down on his right knee calmly, with a thin layer of old wax on the fingernails from rubbing the skin of the Kannon in Genshō-an.

He did not fall. His posture held him another thirty seconds after he had left it. Then the left shoulder blade slowly leaned to the side—not sharply—and Yoshida lowered onto his side, onto the tatami, with a motion that was natural to the extent that natural is the motion of a person falling asleep on a futon.

He lay there.

His legs remained in seiza. The right palm—the one in which the syringe had just been—came to the tatami beside his face, open, palm up.

The room held its air apart.



Kurosawa stood.

Did not go to Ren at once. For a minute he stood where he had stood. Looked at Yoshida on the tatami. At the empty palm, open up. At the lock of gray hair that had fallen onto Yoshida's forehead.

He understood—not as a thought, but as a thin sensation in the chest—that this scene would be tried in him longer than its memory would last. That Prosecutor Fujiwara from Otaru at three in the night would phone him and ask: "Kurosawa-keibu, why did you not intervene." That he would answer: "There was nothing to intervene in." That this would not be a truth and would not be a lie. That Fujiwara would not be satisfied with that. That the applications of the internal disciplinary commission would be taken up for review. That Tanaka Ryosuke in Tokyo would sign his retirement. That all this was long, slow machinery—that had now only begun.

He allowed himself one full pause. Not to think. To let the pause be.

Then he turned his head.

Ren stood on the same spot beside the bed. Did not weep. Breathed evenly. His right hand slowly rose and touched the corner of his eye—wiped nothing—only touched. Then dropped back onto the right thigh.

Kurosawa took a step into the center of the room.

Did not draw close to Yoshida. Passed him at half a step. Lowered himself onto the tatami beside Ren—at the distance at which one usually sits down beside an elder brother at a low table—and sat on his heels. Kept his hands to himself. Did not touch Ren.

Ren looked at him.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Stay."

"I will."

Kurosawa sat. Ren sat. Yoshida lay.

Toshi quietly turned back to the stairs and went out into the lower yard. Kurosawa heard through the walls—far, in the lower yard—Toshi saying briefly, calmly, in the same quiet voice of his, one phrase after another into the receiver to Sergeant Yamaguchi. "Yamaguchi-san. Call a doctor. Call SAT. Call the prosecutor from Otaru—Fujiwara. There is a body in the annex. Kurosawa-keibu is here. Room six. Do not hurry. No one is hurrying anywhere."

Kurosawa heard him through the concrete as a thin vibrational stroke. One. Then the long vanishing of sound.

He sat.

Ren sat.

Yoshida lay.

Beyond the corridor wall a drop fell from a downspout onto concrete.

Another.

Then silence again.



At the third minute after Yoshida's death, Ren turned his head. Not quickly. Calmly, with the same slow motion with which he had done everything through these six years.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Yoshida-sensei will not come again."

Kurosawa looked at him. Did not hurry with an answer.

"He will not, Ren."

Ren nodded.

"This is what he wanted."

"I know."

"This is not what you wanted."

Kurosawa thought.

"No, Ren."

"But you did not hinder."

Kurosawa was silent. The silence was the answer.

Ren nodded once more. Accepted. Then said, very quietly:

"Thank you."

Kurosawa turned his head. Looked at him for one long minute. Then said:

"What do you thank me for, Ren."

"For being here when he went."

"That was not for me."

"I know."

Kurosawa nodded. Did not turn his gaze away.

"I will stay with you until evening," he said. "Then doctors will come for you. One from Jindai-en, one from Sapporo. You will be taken to a center. It is not a prison. It is a home. I will come."

Ren thought.

"You said this to me once already."

Kurosawa waited.

"In Otaru," said Ren. "At the *kissa-ten*. You said: '*See you at New Year's*.'"

"Yes."

"We did not see each other."

"No. We did not."

Ren looked at his own knees. Was silent. Then—with the small yielding with which a person allows himself one unnecessary word—said:

"Now we will."

Kurosawa nodded.

"Now we will."

The room held its air apart.

Beyond the corridor wall, in the lower yard—another drop fell from a downspout onto concrete.

Then silence again.



CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Home

I want to show her Yuri-san's photo album.

Ren was transferred to Teine Kōseikai on Tuesday. In a gray Toyota HiAce with tinted glass, with two paramedics and a nurse in a white coat, and a coffee thermos on the front seat. Kurosawa followed in his own car. The drive from Otaru to Sapporo took sixty-eight minutes. The first snow lay along the shoulders in a thin band and disappeared under the wheels of those who had left the city earlier.

At the center, Ren was received by Dr. Sase—short, forty-eight years old, in a restrained blue sweater over a white shirt. He did not ask questions. He held the folder with Endo's transfer letter—Endo had signed it from Tokyo on Thursday—and nodded with a thin nod. Kurosawa remained in the vestibule until evening. He was asked not to worry about Ren. The room chosen was small, with one

window facing south. Bed—low. Table by the window.

At five he went up with an orderly to the room. Ren sat on the bed in the gray pajama—the same one in which he had been taken out of Jindai-en—and was reading the same book in the gray paper cover. The orderly left. Kurosawa stood on the threshold.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"The window faces south."

"Yes."

"Yoshida-sensei said that a window facing south is good. In winter there will be sun."

"Yes, Ren."

Ren nodded. Went on reading.

Kurosawa stood one minute more. Then said, quietly:

"I'll come to you tomorrow."

"Good."

He went out. The orderly closed the door after him soundlessly.

He drove home at nine in the evening. Did not go into the kitchen. Lay down on the futon in his work shirt.



Toshi gave his testimony two weeks later.

In Prosecutor Fujiwara's office in Otaru—the same Fujiwara who in twenty-six had signed the warrant on Toshi over an unpaid tag—a long office with two windows and blinds that were always raised two thirds. Toshi sat on a wooden chair in gray civilian, with the cuffs

removed for the testimony. Yamaguchi stood behind him, with the key in his right hand.

Toshi spoke briefly. Answered Fujiwara's questions with one or two sentences. About the network—said what he knew. About Jindai-en—said he had never been there. About Ren—said he had not seen him until the day of Yoshida's arrest. About Yoshida—said: "He is my teacher. I did not have a pupil of my own. I will not hand over what I did not have."

Fujiwara entered this in the protocol.

Then Toshi added—not for the protocol but for Fujiwara personally:

"Kurosawa-san in that minute had nothing to do. And he did nothing. It was not a crime. It was witnessing."

Fujiwara said nothing. Wrote the word "witnessing" in a notebook to the side. Not in the protocol.

Five days later the prosecutor's office moved Toshi's case from the accusation of complicity to the accusation of failure to report. In a week Fujiwara petitioned the Otaru court to replace imprisonment with a probationary term. The court accepted. Toshi walked out of Tsukigata on Thursday at four in the afternoon. Kurosawa did not come. Toshi did not look back.

He took the bus north, to Furano. To the cabin he had left in January. Kenji later found him by satellite aerial photography: the chimney was smoking. Toshi did not appear at the Furano-mini for rice and tea for two weeks running. On the third—he came once, bought rice and tea, and did not buy anything else. Kenji closed the query.



Kenji closed out the network in three weeks.

Eight clavicles of the nine columns of Erimo cape were returned to families. The ninth column stood empty—the same empty column, the ninth—with two terns that landed on it once every two days. Kenji left it. Wrote in the report: "Empty. No niche." Tanaka Ryosuke read the report and did not ask.

Two children from Yamagata, who had "disappeared" in eighty-eight and ninety-three from the children's homes of Jindai-en and Sanbi-en, Kenji identified through dental charts via the archive of the Hokkaido district dental association. Both families in Yamagata still existed—elderly parents, another daughter—and Kenji went to them himself, by train, with two small boxes. In each box—one clavicle, wrapped in white silk cloth. Kenji bowed both times. Did not speak for long.

Michiko—the former ward of Jindai-en, the current nurse of the clinic in Niigata, whom Yoshida had taught to call herself Ayano—was arrested two weeks after Yoshida's death. In her apartment on the second floor of an old building in the Higashi-Niigata quarter they found: three ampoules with residues of propofol in the refrigerator, two empty cannula boxes in a drawer under the bed, one small porcelain figurine without a face on the nightstand. Michiko did not resist. Did not speak.

Kurosawa went to her on Monday.

The Niigata detention center stood north of the station, in a gray concrete box of sixty-seven, built between two residential buildings as if inserted there so that no one would see it from a distance. Kurosawa showed the guard his retirement ID—a green card with a red stripe in the lower corner—and the expert-consultant credential Kenji had issued him the previous week. The guard nodded. Did not

ask.

In the interview room stood a table of molded plastic, two chairs, and one window covered with frosted glass. The fluorescent lamp under the ceiling had one dead strip out of four. Kurosawa sat. Placed a small canvas bag on the table.

She was brought in ten minutes later.

She was in a hospital shirt—the same one in which she had been arrested at the clinic—ironed, clean, with two plain ties at the back. Hair gray, short. Face thin. Kurosawa had never seen her—only in the photograph from the Jindai-en archive—and now recognized her at once by the eyes. Michiko was in herself. Not tear-stained. Not empty. In herself.

The matron left her by the chair and stepped out into the corridor.

Michiko sat. Placed her hands on her knees. Backs up.

Kurosawa opened the canvas bag. Took two things out of it. Placed them on the table between himself and her.

Two porcelain figurines without faces. Fifteen centimeters tall each. One—from the Jindai-en archive, of the year eighty-eight, from the inventory number Yasuko-san had written down for him on a scrap of paper in December. The other—from the search of her apartment, from the nightstand. Kurosawa placed them beside each other—at a hand's distance from one another—the way one places cups on a table when drinking tea together.

Michiko looked at them.

Not at once. First she looked at the table. Then at her own hands. Then at the two figurines. Did not reach for them. Did not touch.

Kurosawa waited.

"Michiko-san," he said quietly.

She turned her eyes to him.

"You waited for him forty years."

She did not answer. Breathed evenly.

Kurosawa nodded. It was not an answer. It was the acceptance of silence as an answer.

"He is dead."

Michiko lowered her head. Not fast. Slowly—with the slow motion a head makes that leans not because it has lost the strength to hold itself, but because it has decided in itself to acknowledge something.

It was not a nod.

It was a bow.

Kurosawa saw it. Did not show he had seen.

"I know you loved him."

Michiko raised her head. Looked at him for a long time. Kurosawa held the gaze.

"I am no longer Ayano," she said.

The voice was quiet, even—the same voice with which a nurse speaks to a patient who has just woken from anesthesia. Not empty. Not in tears. In herself.

"I know," said Kurosawa.

Pause.

Kurosawa did not hurry. He placed his palms on the table beside the two figurines—did not draw closer, did not touch—and sat.

Michiko sat. Two figurines without faces stood between them—a forty-year-old and a twenty-five-year-old—the same hand had made them both, with the same long fingers with the small scar on the right index.

Three minutes.

Kurosawa heard through the walls of the detention center the thin sound of the ventilation—even, like the noise of water in pipes—and did not move.

Michiko did not move.

Then Kurosawa stood.

Did not take the figurines. Left them on the table—both—at the same hand's distance from one another in which he had placed them.

"Michiko-san," he said quietly, from the door.

She did not look at him. She was looking at the two figurines.

Kurosawa went out. The matron stood in the corridor—did not look into the room—and Kurosawa nodded to her. She did not immediately close the door. Then, understanding—she did.

Michiko remained sitting motionless. Kurosawa knew this walking down the corridor. He did not look back.

At the first questioning with the investigator of the prosecutor's office the next day, Michiko answered in one sentence:

"Yoshida-sensei is dead. I am no longer Ayano."

Then she fell silent. Then she said nothing more.

Endo—alive, consulting from Tokyo—reviewed the case and wrote one page in which she described the psychological structure of a sleeper assistant without an ideological shell. Kenji read it.

Kurosawa read it. Neither of them asked how Endo held those two words—"psychological structure"—evenly inside her.

Ayano—Ren's daughter, twenty years old, master's in art history in Niigata—was not informed of Michiko's arrest. Kurosawa asked Tanaka to have her name removed from the protocols and replaced with "witness-relative." Tanaka signed without a word. Ayano herself did not ask—she had not known Michiko and was not to know. Kenji arranged with Nao—and Nao arranged with Ayano in a thin conversation over tea on Sunday—that Kurosawa would come to Ayano in Niigata in December. Ayano nodded. Did not ask more.



Kurosawa filed his retirement on Monday.

He placed the resignation on Tanaka Ryosuke's desk at eight thirty in the morning—while Tanaka was still drinking tea from the thermos he had brought from Tokyo—and stood two paces from the desk with his hands at his sides. Tanaka took the resignation. Read it. Did not sign at once. Held the pen in his right hand, cap toward himself, another fifteen seconds. In those fifteen seconds he looked at Kurosawa. Not evaluatingly. Not with reproach. With the calm gaze with which a division chief who had come from Tokyo to this post only two years ago looks at his predecessor—and sees: what had happened at Erimo, and what had happened in Jindai-en, were not two cases into which one could fit an official conclusion; this was one life of one officer.

Tanaka placed the pen on the resignation. Wrote his own name. Then signed. Said nothing. Returned a copy to Kurosawa.

Kurosawa bowed. Not deeply.

"Kurosawa-keibu," Tanaka said only one thing.

"Yes."

"Go home."

Kurosawa bowed once more. Left.

In Tanaka's reception, his secretary—a young woman from Tokyo, thirty-two years old—did not lift her eyes from her monitor. That was correct. Kurosawa walked to the stairs. On the third-floor landing he passed Aoyama—the same Aoyama from the homicide unit who had been with him in Shiretoko in twenty-seven—and Aoyama nodded. Kurosawa nodded back. They did not stop.



He packed a box in his office on Tuesday evening.

One box of brown cardboard, the size of two volumes of a school dictionary. Into it he put: the folder on the Kurosawa Ren case, closed, with a red "archive" sticker; the photograph on the desk—a small one in a plain wooden frame, showing the family house in Otaru, taken in seventy-five in March; the porcelain cup with a thin crack in the bottom, from which he had drunk coffee for fourteen years; the yellow paper with the duty roster that had lain in the pocket of his coat since July of twenty-eight together with the sheet "Kurosawa" from the Erimo cape; the small key to the side drawer, which was now needed by no one.

He held one more thing in his palm before laying it in. One postal envelope, cream, thin, without an address—the one that had come to him in the autumn of twenty-seven with a photograph of the Erimo lighthouse and the line "seven days. Alone. Or with one. Not more." The envelope had been kept in the lower left drawer along with a pair of old pens and one eraser. Kurosawa looked at it for one long second. Then placed it in the box.

One more thing. From the upper right drawer, from under the stapler—a small ring of cheap silver, with a thin engraving, in the shape of a simple band without a stone. Ren's ring. Toshi had passed it to Kurosawa the week before—had come from Furano by bus alone—had kept it for himself for three years in a scrap of white cloth, in a tin box on the upper shelf above the bed, and had said: "Kurosawa-san, this is Ren's. Yoshida-sensei left it with me for safekeeping in twenty-five, when he was teaching. He did not explain. I preserved it." Kurosawa nodded, took the ring. Did not ask how. Now he placed it in the box with the rest.

One more thing. The small bundle of soft paper that Sasaki had set on the dashboard of the car thirty minutes before the Erimo lighthouse. Kurosawa had taken it from the car that day—himself, without a sound—when he handed the keys back to the patrolmen. He had kept it with him for three months. Had not unwrapped it. Now he unwrapped it above the desk. A small porcelain figure without a face, in a blue kimono—an *ichimatsu-ningyō*—the one Ayano-the-nurse had sent to Nao in Niigata in October. Sasaki had taken it, brought it to Sapporo, kept it with her to the lighthouse. Had wanted to show him. Had not had the time. Kurosawa wrapped it back in the same paper. Placed it in the box.

One more thing. Ren's drawing—the one Ren had given him at Teine Kōseikai the last weekend, folded in four. Kurosawa did not unfold it. Did not want to look at it in the office. He placed it in the box last, on top.

That was all.

He closed the box. Wound tape around it once—evenly—and set it under his left arm.

The office held its light without him. The fluorescent lamp under the ceiling hummed thinly—at the same note it had hummed for all fourteen years—and Kurosawa heard it separately, as something that would hold on here after he was gone.

He switched off the desk lamp. Did not look back.



He walked out of the department at eighteen forty-five.

Kenji's car was in the parking lot. Kenji sat behind the wheel with the window rolled down. Phone in his hand. Kurosawa came up, placed the box on the roof of the car. Kenji lowered the phone.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Kenji-san."

Kenji was silent half a second.

"I'm going to Nao's in Niigata on Friday. I want to show her Yuri-san's photo album. The one she made in her master's."

Kurosawa turned his head. Looked at him calmly.

"Good."

"You don't mind?"

"No."

Kenji nodded. Did not hold the gaze long.

"Kurosawa-san."

"Yes."

"I will come to you."

"I know."

"Once every two weeks. Monday evening. Tea."

"Good."

Pause.

"Kenji-san," Kurosawa said quietly. "One thing."

"Yes."

"Nao-san. Do not hurry. She is young. She is at work. Do not hurry."

Kenji looked at him calmly.

"I am not hurrying, Kurosawa-san."

"Good."

Kenji nodded. Kurosawa took the box off the roof of the car, tucked it under his right arm. Said no more. Walked across the lot to his car. Held the box level.

Kenji watched his back until Kurosawa sat behind the wheel and started the engine. Then he raised his window. Drove off.

Kurosawa sat in the lot another minute. The box lay on the passenger seat, under his right hand. He looked through the windshield at the department building. At the fluorescent lamp in his former office on the fifth floor—that rectangle of yellow light someone had left on after his exit—and did not go back to switch it off.

Then he started the engine and drove home.

EPILOGUE

The Drawing

Will you come tomorrow?

Kurosawa went to Niigata on Thursday in mid-December.

The journey took him two days—from Sapporo by ferry to Hakodate on Wednesday evening, then the night train to Omiya, then a change to the direct line to Niigata with a lunch stop at Takasaki. He traveled slowly now. He had time. Ayano was waiting for him at four in the afternoon at a café on the second floor of Niigata station—small, with nine tables—with large windows onto the suburban line.

He arrived ten minutes early. Ordered coffee, black. Placed a small gray briefcase on the table—the one he now carried only for what he did not want to hold in his hands.

Ayano appeared at four zero-two.

She was tall—like her father—with thin features, in a dark green coat with a high collar. Hair gathered in a plain bun. In her hands—one book in a white cover and a small satchel from the university library. Twenty years old—Kurosawa knew—but in that second she looked two or three years older. Not because she looked worn. Because she held her back straight, the way people hold it who have spent two years in a master's program and learned to sit six hours over a single cup of tea.

She saw him. Came over. Did not bow. Placed the satchel on the neighboring chair and sat opposite.

"Uncle."

"Ayano-san."

"Thank you for coming."

"Nothing to thank."

She glanced at his right hand—at the briefcase. Did not ask. Ordered tea. The waiter brought it a minute later. Ayano held the cup in both palms—did not drink—and looked at him.

"Uncle," she said. "Why so long?"

Kurosawa looked out the window. Beyond the glass a suburban-line train was pulling in—gray, with a green stripe along the flank—and stopping at platform five. He waited until the train had stopped. Then turned his eyes back to her.

"I didn't know," he said.

Ayano nodded. Not in forgiveness. As a sign of hearing.

"Did he recognize me?"

Kurosawa did not answer at once. He knew—with that thin corner that knew the answer before he was asked—that the truth would not be the one she hoped for, and not the one she needed. He held the pause long enough for the words to find their place.

"He remembers you at fourteen," he said. "The way he saw you last, on the morning of the year twenty-two."

Ayano lowered her eyes to the cup. A thin steam rose and disappeared.

"I don't remember him grown," she said.

"Yes."

Pause.

Kurosawa opened the briefcase. Took out one thing. A thin white paper, folded in four. Did not put it on the table at once—held it one more second in his hand—then unfolded it and placed it before her.

Ren's drawing. The one Ren had given him last Tuesday. A small room. One lamp. A low bed. A shelf with a porcelain figurine on the wall.

Ayano looked.

Looked for a long time. Did not touch the paper. One palm on the cup. The other on her knee. Her face did not change.

Then, quietly, she said:

"He draws the room."

Kurosawa nodded.

"Every day."

Pause.

"He wanted you to see this."

Ayano turned her eyes to him. Looked at him for a long time. Kurosawa held the gaze.

"Is he waiting for me?"

Kurosawa thought. Not to find a word—but to let the truth settle.

"He is always waiting there."

Ayano nodded.

Then—with the short motion of one who has made a decision without hesitation—said:

"I will come. At the new year."

"He will be glad."

Pause.

Ayano folded the drawing in four, carefully, with the motions with which her father and her uncle had folded small papers from their journals when they were to be kept. Put it in the inner pocket of her coat. Did not look at Kurosawa's briefcase. She knew there was something else there. Did not ask.

"Uncle."

"Yes."

"Thank you again."

"Nothing to thank, Ayano-san."

Kurosawa rose first. Ayano too. Her train left at six. His—the night sailing back to Hakodate. He bowed. Ayano bowed. Not deeply.

They walked out of the café separately.

Beyond the station snow was falling in the same thin vertical grain Kurosawa had left in Sapporo in the morning and met here again in the evening.



Winter in Sapporo held its form. Snow was falling thinly, without wind—in that straight vertical grain that begins early in January and lasts until midday without a break.

At Teine Kōseikai it was two degrees warmer than outside, and in the vestibule it smelled of a citrus floor cleaner—the same one used at medical institutions in Hokkaido since the nineties. Kurosawa

took off his coat in the cloakroom, hung it on a wooden hanger with two metal clips. Left his shoes on the lower shelf, put on gray guest slippers of soft felt. Nodded to the volunteer girl at the desk. She nodded back.

He went up in the elevator to the third floor.

Ren's room was at the end of the corridor. A door of thin light wood, with a small brass plate: "Kurosawa Ren." The brass was new—installed six weeks ago, when Ren had moved from the temporary room on the second floor here. Kurosawa looked at it with a quiet attachment—the attachment a person keeps for things that ought not to be theirs, but are.

He knocked. Twice. Lightly.

"Yes," said Ren from inside.

Kurosawa opened.



He stood on the threshold one long second. Not because he could not enter. Because to make the step from the corridor into the room of a brother who for six years had lived behind different walls is a motion the body makes more slowly than the head. He allowed the body to find its rhythm.

Then he entered.

The room was small. One window facing south, at the lower part of which stood the lower edge of the white sill, and beyond it—snow—snow steady, distinct, with the vertical black lines of the cedars that stood in the yard of the center, the way they stand in place where they were set. Bed by the far wall, made up with a plain cotton blanket in beige stripes. Table by the window. On the table—a stack of white A4 paper, about ten sheets, and a metal box

of pencils. In the box—two "HB," one "2B," one sanguine, one graphite stick without a jacket. That was all.

Ren sat at the table. In a gray sweater, in gray cotton trousers. His hair had grown a little longer than it had been in October—Dr. Sase had not insisted on a haircut—and one lock of gray above the right ear lay on his shoulder. He held a pencil in his right hand. His left hand on the sheet, pressing the corner of the paper down.

Drawing.

Kurosawa came in quietly. Closed the door behind him. Sat on the chair on the far side of the table, at the distance at which one usually sits down beside a brother with whom one holds a long silence. Did not look into the sheet.

"Yukio," said Ren, without lifting his head.

"Yes."

"The snow today is quiet."

"Quiet."

"I looked out the window this morning for twenty minutes. Then sat down to draw."

"What today."

Ren thought.

"The room."

"Again."

"Again."

Kurosawa nodded. Did not look at the sheet. He looked past Ren's shoulder—at the snow outside the window.

Ren continued drawing. The pencil moved across the sheet thinly, with the slow precise rhythm that comes when the hand knows its motion and does not ask the head. Kurosawa heard the thin dry rustle of graphite against paper—and one line, and a second, and a pause, and a third.

So they sat for about fifteen minutes.

Outside the window snow was falling evenly. In the corridor beyond the door quietly—once every seven minutes—a nurse walked past with a tray, and the steps of her rubber slippers could be heard through the thin wood. Then silence again.

Kurosawa thought about the family home in Otaru. About the room on the second floor in which he and Ren had lived together until Yukio at seventeen had gone to Sapporo for university. In that room there had been two beds—one by the east wall, one by the west—and between them a low table with two drawers. Ren used to read on his bed until eleven at night. Yukio would fall asleep earlier. Sometimes Yukio woke at two in the morning and saw that Ren's lamp was still on. He did not wake him. Only turned onto his side and fell asleep again.

That was a long time ago.

Kurosawa thought this, and did not say it aloud.

Ren went on drawing.



At half past one, a nurse knocked at the door—young, in a white coat, with the name "Haraguchi" on her badge—and opened it half a palm.

"Kurosawa-san. Kurosawa Ren-san. Tea time."

Kurosawa turned his head.

"Thank you, Haraguchi-san. Five more minutes."

"All right. I'll set the cups in the sitting room."

She closed the door. The steps in the corridor faded.

Ren raised his head. Looked at Yukio as if past him—with that particular slow focus he had always had after Jindai-en, and which Dr. Sase called "correct." Not illness. Not recovery. A way of being.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Will you come tomorrow?"

Kurosawa thought. Not longer than needed to find an honest word.

"I will, Ren."

"I will wait for you."

"I know."

Ren nodded. Lowered his head. Continued drawing.

Kurosawa sat on the chair calmly. Did not move. Let the pause be what it was. He knew that everything between them held now on one fact: he had come today, he would come tomorrow—and that this fact for Ren mattered more than all the words Kurosawa could or could not say. In the same way the snow outside the window held on one fact: it was falling.

Five minutes later Ren set down the pencil.

Looked at the sheet. Nodded to himself. Then folded it in four—carefully, slowly—and pushed it half a palm toward Yukio. Did not hand it over. Simply pushed it.

"Yukio."

"Yes."

"Take it home."

Kurosawa took it. The folded sheet lay in the palm without weight. He did not unfold it. Held it a second, then put it in the chest pocket of his sweater—the way one puts a sheet one is to keep whole until evening.

He did not look at the drawing. He kept his eyes on Ren.

"Thank you, Ren."

"Yes."



In the sitting room of the center Haraguchi-san poured Ren green tea in a white cup with a thin crack in the bottom. For herself, too. For Kurosawa she brought coffee in a porcelain mug with the center's logo—a plain black circle with the inscription "手稻厚生会" on the side. Kurosawa thanked her. Sat beside Ren on the low sofa. Did not speak.

Ren drank his tea slowly, in small sips. Held the cup with both hands. Looked out the window. Haraguchi-san tidied unobtrusively. Did not intrude.

At three Kurosawa rose. Bowed to Haraguchi-san. Offered Ren his palm, back down—not for a shake, but for that short touch Ren allowed himself once per visit. Ren, with his right palm, touched Yukio's palm for a second. Then took his hand back.

"Until tomorrow, Yukio."

"Until tomorrow, Ren."

Kurosawa walked out of the room. Haraguchi-san accompanied him to the elevator. In the elevator she said:

"Kurosawa-san, Ren-san drew longer today than usual."

"How long."

"Three hours. Morning and after the midday meal. We put the drawings in the lower drawer of the desk. He wants that."

"Thank you, Haraguchi-san."

The elevator stopped on the ground floor. Kurosawa got out. In the cloakroom he put on his coat and shoes. In the vestibule the volunteer girl nodded to him. He nodded back.

Beyond the glass doors of the vestibule snow was falling in the same vertical grain the morning had begun with.

He walked out into the snow.

On the way to the car he stopped for a second. Not because he had felt something—he did not feel anything then—but because on the side path stood the winter rowan with small red berries, dusted with the thin white grain—and he liked how that color held in the gray day. He stood three seconds. Then walked on.

In the car he started the engine. The heater came in with a thin note in half a minute. He pulled out of the center's yard. On the way back to Misei the radio was off. He did not turn it on.



Kurosawa came home at six in the evening.

The city held the snow. He parked in the lower yard of the building—the same building in Misei where he had lived for twelve years—and rode up in the elevator to the fourth floor. The corridor smelled of drying linen from apartment number forty-eight—old

Mr. Onda dried his laundry on the balcony and left the window open. Kurosawa forgave him that smell.

He opened the door of his apartment. Took off his shoes at the *genkan*. Hung his coat on the wooden hook. Walked into the kitchen.

One lamp above the kitchen table. He switched it on—yellow soft light, with a thin note from the old filament—and did not switch the rest on.

On the chair beside the table stood the box from the department. From Monday. Not yet unpacked.

He set it on the table.

Sat in his usual place—back to the window, facing the stove. Set the mobile phone to silent, placed it to his right beside him. Then opened the box.

He took things out one at a time.

First—the Kurosawa Ren folder. Placed it on the table to the left. Did not open.

Second—the photograph of the family home in Otaru. Placed it to the right. Looked at it one second. Wooden facade, low, with a roof pitched to the right. He had grown up in it from four to eighteen. Ren—from eight to twenty-two. His mother was no longer in the photograph.

Third—the porcelain cup with the crack. Set it in the center. Did not brew coffee in it.

Then—the yellow paper with the duty roster. Placed it below. Did not read.

Then—the sheet "Kurosawa" from the Erimo cape. Unfolded it—for the first time in a year and a half—read it. It was blank. Only one word, in black pen: *Kurosawa*. Not "inspector." Not with a first name. Only the surname. Yoshida had written it with his right hand, with that small slant of the letters Yoshida had held since middle school. Kurosawa looked and folded the sheet back.

Then—Ren's ring. Small, silver, in the scrap of white cloth from Toshi. He unwrapped the cloth. Placed the ring beside the cup. Folded the scrap of cloth neatly, placed it under the ring.

Then—the photograph of Misako. The one Yasuko-san had given him at Jindai-en in December when he had come last to collect the last of Ren's things. A small black-and-white card, with thin serrated edges, from nineteen seventy. An eight-year-old girl in a sundress with little flowers, with two braids—standing on pier number two—laughing into the camera. Behind her shoulder—the sea of Otaru in a summer misty haze. Kurosawa placed the photograph to the left of the cup.

He looked at it for one minute. At the thin line of the horizon above the girl's shoulder. At the calm sea. At the pier Misako would fall from a month and a half later and not surface. At the twin brother—Yoshida at eight—standing off-camera, holding the camera. That was his hand that pressed the shutter. Those were his eyes that saw Misako in that moment.

Kurosawa looked away.

Then—the photograph of Sasaki Yuri. Nao had sent it in November. From an envelope with three prints, she had written: "Yukio-san, of these three Yuri told me she loved this one most. One I keep for myself. One for you. One for Kenji-san." Kurosawa had chosen the middle one—Yuri in uniform, next to the department

car, her face turned three-quarters to the camera, with that short smile with which she had held every working day. He set the photograph to the right of the cup.

Ren's drawing lay separately. In the chest pocket of the sweater, folded in four—the one Ren had given him after the midday meal today. Kurosawa had not yet unfolded it. He kept it closer to the heart, not on the table. Not yet.

Four objects on the table. Only what could be carried by one hand. Only what held in the light of a single lamp.

He stood. Went to the stove. Poured water from the ceramic pitcher into a Turkish coffee pot—twenty-two grams of coffee, three hundred thirty grams of water—and set it on a low flame. Stood by the stove. Looked at the water.

The mobile phone vibrated once.



He looked at the phone. The screen showed a number he knew.

He took the receiver to his ear at the kitchen threshold. Knew it was Nao. Nao called on Monday and on Thursday evening—once a week to him, once a week to Kenji—and today was Thursday.

"Yukio-san."

"Nao-san."

"Kenji-san was with me on Sunday. Showed me the photo album. The one Yuri made in her master's."

"I know."

"Thank you."

"Nothing to thank."

Pause.

"Yukio-san."

"Yes, Nao-san."

Nao thought. Kurosawa heard her breathing on the other end. She breathed quietly, with that small note Sasaki Yuri had had too—when she was preparing to say something she had held in herself for three weeks.

"Yuri had one book at my house. Old. About rabbits. A children's one. She brought it in twenty-twenty-one—she was staying with me temporarily then, before her new apartment—and she forgot it when she left. Forgot—that's not true—I think she left it for me. Did not say so directly."

"Yes."

"I keep it on the lower shelf by the window. I look at it once a week."

"Yes."

"Would you like me to send it to you?"

Kurosawa was silent for a long time.

He stood at the kitchen threshold, with the phone in his right hand, with his palm on the wooden frame of the jamb. The water on the stove was beginning to sound. Thinly, not yet boiling—with the note that comes half a minute before boiling.

He allowed the pause to be what it was.

"Yes, Nao-san. Send it."

Pause.

"Thank you," said Nao.

"Nothing to thank."

"Good night, Yukio-san."

"Good night, Nao-san."

He placed the phone on the kitchen table—beside the cup—and turned back to the stove.

The water came to a boil half a second later than he expected. He took off the pot. Poured coffee into the porcelain cup with the crack. Steam rose in that vertical thread easy to break if one places the cup poorly. He set the cup level.

Sat on the chair with his back to the window. Held the cup with both hands. Warmth passed through the porcelain into his palms—that thing that always comes later than a person expects it—and stayed.

He took a sip.

The coffee was plain. Hot. The way he liked it.

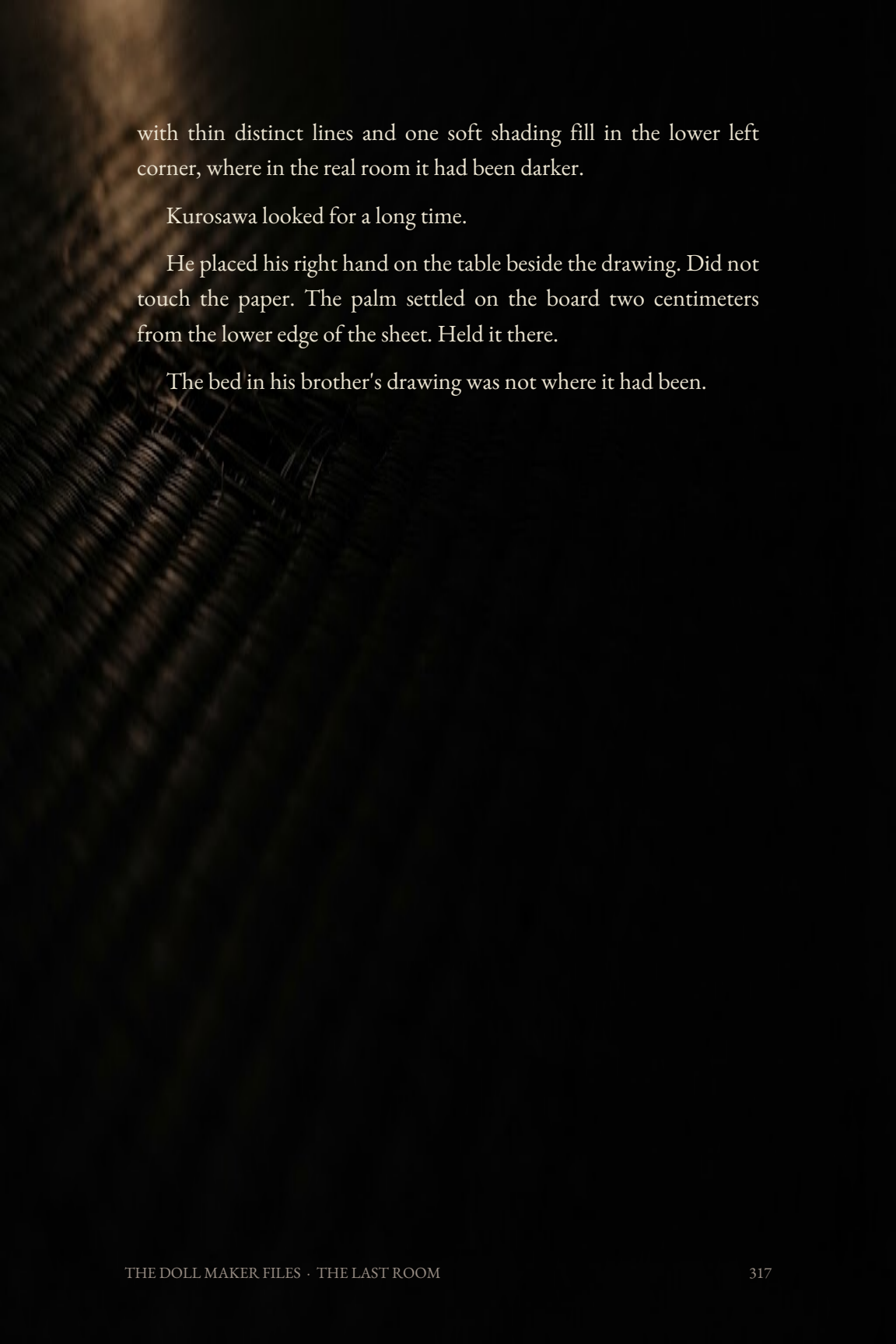
On the table before him—four objects. The sheet "Kurosawa." The photograph of Misako. The photograph of Sasaki Yuri. Ren's ring.

He looked at them for a long time.

Then drew from the chest pocket of the sweater the folded sheet. The one Ren had given him today. Held it in his palm one more second.

Placed it on the table beside Yuri's photograph. Smoothed it with his fingers. Carefully.

The drawing was plain. A small room. One lamp. A low bed. Walls without ornaments. Washbasin in the corner. One shelf with a porcelain figurine on the wall. All—in pencil of medium hardness,



with thin distinct lines and one soft shading fill in the lower left corner, where in the real room it had been darker.

Kurosawa looked for a long time.

He placed his right hand on the table beside the drawing. Did not touch the paper. The palm settled on the board two centimeters from the lower edge of the sheet. Held it there.

The bed in his brother's drawing was not where it had been.



About the Author

Yehor Selin is the author of «The Doll Maker Files».